



heather
loosens up

arnica
butler

HEATHER LOOSENS UP

By Arnica Butler

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A Note To Readers

My beta readers conveyed to me that the tone of this book is different than my other books, in that it reads more like an account of events than my usual fare. In this, they are correct, and I will take up their suggestion to forewarn readers: Heather Lets Loose is an embellished mashup of several true stories, with minor to major embellishments. All names, characters, and settings have been changed significantly, to the point that the story is hardly a true account of any particular event, but because it is strongly inspired by and rooted in true stories, the resulting story arc does come across quite a bit differently than other works of mine. I'm very satisfied with the raw and realistic tone, myself, so I hope the change is well-received by you as well.

Mum will always be the word on the origin of the stories upon which this one is based (winking smiley emoticon).

As always, thank you to the aforementioned beta readers, without whom publishing in a genre like this would be either unfeasible or terribly edited, and thank you to all readers who support indie publishing in their own favorite niches.

I hope you enjoy this story as much as I enjoyed writing it.

-AB

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PART I: SALTY'S

CHAPTER 1

Toby's scowl made almost three bulges of skin in his forehead as he surveyed the dim street to the left and right of his truck.

Force of habit.

There were parts of town where you could leave your vehicle unattended, provided you had enough cash on hand to buy your tools back from whoever had stolen them. It was the price of doing business in certain parts of town, and Toby didn't even get worked up about it anymore: he just carried the cash.

There were other places in this city where leaving his truck parked on the road could possibly invalidate his insurance policy. At first glance, the area around Salty's Haven gave off a bit of that vibe.

The neon sign (reading only "Saltys," no apostrophe) was partially illuminated, the first "s" a bright, flamingo color that drained away to grayish-pink by the end of the word, reminding anyone who looked at it of stale meat. The outline of the martini glass that followed the final "s" was more corpse-colored, once having glowed blue. The tropical color scheme, faded or not, was spectacularly out-of-place in the Midwestern climate, below freezing for six months of the year. As if to punctuate the joke, someone had set a palm tree, made of plastic and tinsel, next to the entranceway.

"Hooooo shit," Toby said under his breath.

He looked at his phone again, re-reading the text message from Heather: yes, this was the place. Salty's Haven on 17th and Sheridan.

The picture began to look less ominous as he crossed the street: the cars in the parking lot were new, but affordable, family cars. A sign of respectability. If the cars were old, this was a shit part of town. And if the cars were new but unaffordable, tinted and tricked out, then it was a good idea to – in the parlance of some inhabitants - "bounce."

Toby opened the door to Salty's Haven and relaxed even more. The clientele as evidence, Salty's was clearly one of those bars that delivered the ambiance of a dive-bar to suburban mid-career "suits" who worked in the office parks several blocks away.

Toby scanned the room quickly and located his wife among a throng of loud, drunk women. He typed her a message to let her know he was there. She was caught up in a story, and if there was one thing Heather hated, it was to be interrupted. He decided to wait at the bar.

The bartender was a young, brown-skinned, good-looking guy. Clean-shaven and athletic in appearance. He approached Toby right away, with one wary eye on the table of women, who were being fairly rowdy and looked like they might boil over into table dancing or stripping. Something about the kid's haircut and police-face said he didn't let that kind of noise go on in his bar.

He sized Toby up with a quick up-and-down. The two men had an instant impression of each other, both athletes who would recognize the other as such. They were both stars of soccer and hockey, wily forwards who relied on skill and speed, but Toby had the small paunch of a man who didn't take it, or himself, quite as seriously anymore.

The bartender was still ripped. Give it time, Toby thought.

"W'can I get you?" the bartender asked, leaning on the bar with his arms spread open wide, an unconscious demonstration of his physical prowess.

Toby leaned on the bar. He was past his own prime, starting to feel it in his knees, had a rotator cuff injury that would never heal, and he couldn't spread his arms out like that anymore. He felt the electric tremor of competitiveness kicking around in his gut. He'd have liked to have shown this kid a thing or two on the ice or the field, but it was eleven o'clock on a Thursday night in Toby's world: a babysitter was being paid for, his wife was drunk, and he had to be up at five in the morning.

Toby turned on what he was calling his middle-aged man charm instead. "I just need your finest, cheapest beer, good man," he said, in a jovial tone he had cultivated for situations like this one.

Probably because they were cut from the same cloth, even if it had been tailored twenty years apart, the kid smiled and the rapport became instantly friendly. "A Budweiser man?" he suggested. "Or MGD?"

"Coldest," Toby said. He was also a man who was long past debating the qualities of shitty beers. A peal of laughter, of the kind unique to groups of middle-aged women who have stayed out way too late on a weekday

with too much wine, erupted from the direction of another table, where yet another group of ladies was cloistered.

“Ladies’ night?” Toby asked the bartender, who grinned as he removed the cap of an MGD bottle with an expert motion.

“This place is right by the hospital, man,” the kid grinned. “Medical staff, admin ladies. *Nurses*. Line ‘em up, knock ‘em down.” He shook his head and looked down at the bottle of MGD, as if disappointed in it suddenly. “You want a glass for that?”

Toby swiped up the beer and shook his head at the same time. He took a generous swig and swiveled to face the table where his wife was sitting. His phone was in his left hand, ready to send a second message and get her out of here without having to be introduced, in turn, to each of the crowing birds Heather was entertaining.

But Heather was already standing up, an unusual smile attempting to crack through the typical seriousness of her mouth. It was clear from her smile, her bright eyes, and the slightest wobble as she took a first step, that she had consumed too much alcohol. For her, that probably meant two glasses of wine. Five foot six (eight in heels), very slender and well-toned, Heather’s body size was easily saturated by a single glass of wine. Added to that, her generally uptight nature forbade drinking in most situations. Heather was a cheap, but infrequent, drunk.

Toby smiled over his beer as he took a swig, thinking of what he would say to her. He was annoyed by having to come pick her up, but Heather’s tipsy walking and loose smile changed his sentiments immediately. Maybe this was one of those nights that Heather would let loose and be fun.

It could even lead, he dared think, to sex.

On a Thursday night.

But Heather was up to more than simply being drunk this evening. Making a sharp turn toward the bar when she reached it, stopping far short of where Toby was sitting, she leaned provocatively on the bar, one leg crossed over the other. She gave a flirtatious toss of her shoulder-length blond hair, and the bartender dropped Toby like he was dead weight.

Smiling, obviously flirting, he approached Toby’s wife. “Whatcha need, pretty lady?”

Toby rolled his eyes and took another swig of beer with his eyes closed.

When he opened them, the bartender and Heather were leaning toward each other over the bar, their heads almost touching. The bartender said something, and Heather's mouth turned up in a smile just before a tinkling laugh spilled from her lips.

The sight of it was so jarring that Toby misjudged the distance to the bar and set his beer down with a too-loud crunch. Neither one of them looked over. Heather tucked a strand of hair behind her ear and smiled at the bartender.

Toby's cock thickened with a single pulse as a slow-burning sensation, equal parts jealousy and arousal, filled him as though it had been poured down his throat like hard liquor.

Had she not seen him sitting here? he wondered. A slew of partial thoughts burned through him, settling in his chest and his cock, fluttering like butterflies in both places.

The bartender pushed himself away from Heather and went around the bar to fetch something. Heather turned to look at Toby point-blank, finding him with her eyes, right where she expected him to be. She had seen him, all right.

Mystified, Toby stared at her.

"What brings *you* here?" she asked, putting her hand on her hip and leaning against the bar as she rolled her body to face him.

Heather was wearing a charcoal-gray suit with a blue blouse. The top button was undone, something Toby noticed right away because having a top button undone was not Heather's thing. Heather used a lint brush every morning, and they didn't even have a pet. Buttons did not get loose on Heather's clothing unless Heather *let* them get loose. Which she did not do.

It wasn't a lewd open button; most women, in fact, would wear their blouse opened that far, but on Heather, it looked sloppy. The blouse folded down on the button side, revealing a glimpse of the curve of her small, taut breast.

Toby laughed, a low, almost adversarial laugh. "What are you *doing?*" he asked.

Heather emitted a sound, a kind of sharp laugh that disintegrated into a lopsided smile, tucked the same strand of her hair back around her ear,

and shook her head. “I don’t knooooow,” she purred.

Toby’s gut went cold as Heather stepped closer to him, sliding an empty glass along with her. “I had three glasses of wine,” she whispered loudly. “And a gross cocktail.”

Toby was just making a gesture with his head, narrowing his eyes in confusion and giving a nod of disbelieving approval, when the bartender popped back with a bottle of red wine and a glass. “One Shiraz for the lady,” he said charmingly. A smile was plastered on his face but he was looking back and forth from Heather to Toby, a definitive glimmer of possessiveness in his eyes.

Heather was amused by this, because she gave her shiny hair a shake and smiled.

It was at this specific moment that Toby glanced at her hand and remembered that her wedding ring had been taken in for repair. Her bare fingers were long, neatly manicured, and only the slightest pale shadow of the ring marred her finger. She looked, quite suddenly, very young and very available. Toby’s chest felt tighter, and his cock strained against the confines of his jeans.

Heather extended a hand to Toby as though he were a stranger. “Heather,” she said.

Flummoxed, Toby took her hand, and shook it limply in his confusion. “Coop,” he said. Coop was the inescapable nickname of all men with the last name Cooper, and even Heather had a tendency to use it when she was around his friends, who may have been hard-pressed to remember his given name if asked.

Heather’s eyes glimmered, and she smiled for him, as if he were precisely what he wasn’t: a stranger in a bar. She grinned, and it was sexy. “Chris,” she said, leaving her eyes on Toby for just a moment too long before swinging them toward the bartender. “Thank you for the wine. Put it on the tab. Very nice to meet you, Coop.” She gave Toby a sidelong, very sexy glance, and rolled away from the bar. The two men watched her leaving: a tight, small ass in a dark, shape-hugging skirt that came to just above her knees.

Toby’s mouth was falling open, so he closed it by taking a sip of his beer. Just moments before, he had wanted to get home, but now he was

intrigued by whatever it was that his wife was doing and didn't mind sitting there to watch it.

Whatever it was.

What the fuck was it?

The bartender leaned on the bar, close enough for Toby to hear him over loud top-40's music that had very recently begun but which Toby only heard just then. "Hospital admin," he appraised. "Line 'em up, knock 'em down."

Toby looked at the kid incredulously. "Seems a little old for you," he said.

The athletic swagger erupted inside the bartender, and he stood up to his full height. He was an average height, maybe 5' 10," but his abdomen was flat and his muscles were hard in all the right places. He shook his head as if he almost lamented that it was this easy for him to reel the ladies in. He lifted a glass overhead and slipped it onto the rack. "Even better. That one, she's a suit. Uptight as hell when she first got here." He leaned back down, closer to Toby. "But those are the hottest ones. Uptight, hasn't had a good lay in years, a little tipsy... she's putty in my hands."

Toby raised an eyebrow. "Oh yeah?"

It was an inappropriate response, and he knew that, but he thought it would be funny when he finally collected his uptight wife and took her home. If there was one word that *least* described Heather, it was "putty."

More like steel-re-inforced concrete, buddy, he thought.

The bartender nodded sagely, and then, grinning, leaned on the bar again to confide in Toby. "This whole group of 'em, they're hospital girls..." He pointed, not even trying to hide it, to each one in turn. "Hospital - slept with her - admin, admin - boned her - hospital, slept with her, her too, admin, that's who I was after next... and then you have..." his finger ticked to the right and pointed toward Heather. "The Suit. Sales, probably. She's got a corporate credit card and no limit. Got a little too drunk, see how her hair's out of place, but you can see.... it isn't ever like that, usually. *She* is lookin' for a good time."

Toby stared at the bartender. What an arrogant ass.

Although he had to admit - bitterly - that a large portion of the bartender's assessment appeared to be correct. All but the last part, of course.

Toby finished his beer and flicked it toward the bartender with the back of his fingers, pondering his final comment. *She's lookin' for a good time.*

“Oh, yeah,” he said idly, peeling the label on his beer. “How you know that?”

The bartender rose up, giving a short laugh. “I’ve seen it *all* from back here,” he said arrogantly, removing a glass from the racks above the bar to wipe it. “Women like *that*, even if they’re a little older – hell, especially if they’re a little older – you *always* try to get one like that to go home with you.”

“Uh-huh,” Toby said, half-sarcastically. “And why’s that?”

The bartender smiled at him. “Well, she’s fucking hot, for one thing. And she’s got no ring, but there’s a little tan line on her finger.” He nodded and lifted the cleaned glass to the rack. “Divorced,” he said happily. “Or cheating.” He gave Heather’s table a glance. “She doesn’t seem like the cheating type, but... I could be wrong.”

Toby tapped his beer. “You grab me another one?” he asked.

As Chris-The-Bartending-Asshole pulled a bottle from the fridge, Toby looked at his wife. She gave him a glance – long enough not to be accidental, short enough to be secretive. It made him even harder, though he wasn’t sure why.

Or what Heather could possibly be up to.

“What if she’s just sent her ring out to be cleaned?” Toby mused, when the bartender came back with his beer and set it on the table. Toby glanced at him for his answer.

The kid shrugged and wiped his hands, smiling confidently. “Sure,” he said. “I’ve met *a lot* of ladies sent their ring out for cleaning, man.” He adjusted a glass. “I’m pretty sure that one’s coming home with me.”

Stunning.

Toby took a sip of his beer. “Oh, yeah?” he said, amusement and competitiveness scratching around inside of him. “You think you stand a chance?”

He could see the kid bristle with the same competitive itch as himself, but he was also young, and the hothead in him had been triggered. “What, you think I don’t?” he said incredulously.

“She seems out of your league,” Toby told him, marveling at how easy it was to get these young guys riled up. He could actually see the kid puffing up like a peacock.

The bartender grinned at Toby, but it was the grin of combat. “Oh, she does, does she?”

Toby nodded.

The bartender licked his lower lip and folded his arms on the bartop, which required him to spread his legs apart. He wagged a finger in Toby’s direction. “Your tab says I get her number.”

“Huh,” Toby said, getting in the spirit of things. “That’s not much of a challenge.”

The bartender gave him a look of disbelief. “No, pops? What would impress you, then?”

Toby gave it some thought. “For my tab?” he asked.

The bartender nodded.

“And I do what... pay you twice if I lose?”

Another nod.

“Not a very risky bet,” Toby commented.

“Good for you, because you’ll lose it,” he said, tone joking, eyes full of the amplified seriousness that all men in their twenties seemed to have about anything requiring even a drop of testosterone.

“You gotta get some kind of physical interaction,” Toby said, suppressing a smile. “Before I leave, and you have to give me proof.”

It should be interjected here that Toby, like most men of his ilk, was drawn to gambling like a moth to a flame. Chris The Bartender was the same kind of guy, only younger, and so they were settling into the language and trade of gambling men. Toby wasn’t actually thinking about what he was saying, any more than a sailor is thinking about a knot when he ties it. It would only come to him later that he was betting his wife.

The bartender spread his arms wide and bent them at the elbows to lower his head close to Toby. “You see that table she’s at? I’ve fucked *two* of those chicks. In this bathroom.”

He waved a hand toward a passageway that evidently led to the bathrooms.

“No shit,” Toby said. He was fucking with this guy now, but there was an element of seriousness brewing in his own dark places. That serious

element was inflating his cock, which pulsed painfully against his zipper as he thought of his wife pressed up against a bathroom wall with Chris's cock sawing at the juicy gash between her legs.

Toby smiled. "What's your top shelf whiskey?" he asked.

The bartender pushed off the bar, his eyes locked on Toby's, his mouth turned in a smile, and fetched the whiskey without saying anything more.

Challenge accepted.

Toby accepted the whiskey, smiling, but when Chris turned away to attend to some other customers, the sky fell down on him.

What had he just done? Made a bet with a total stranger over whether the stranger could fuck his wife in a bar bathroom? Was that the bet he had just made?

He glanced over at Heather, who was chatting with the dwindling group. She was leaning on her elbow, her stray lock loose, her long legs crossed, the slit of her skirt revealing her leg all the way to her upper thigh.

Almost, Toby thought, as if she were *inviting* something.

Interesting threads of guilt, cold jealousy, and excitement wound around his insides. He took out his phone and typed a message to Heather.

*This kid at the bar just made a bet
with me that he can get you to fuck
him in the bathroom*

he typed. His finger hovered over the "send" icon (*I am sending this to my wife, what am I doing?*) and then, as if his hand had been taken control of by someone else, jerked to press it.

He watched Heather as she slid her phone across the table to read the message. Her face remained expressionless as she scanned the screen, looked at the woman she was talking to, and then discreetly shifted her gaze in Toby's direction. Her lips tightened, but turned up in a wry smile.

Toby's chest felt like it was being crushed – in a good way, the way a pretty girl you have a crush on could squeeze the air out of you just by walking by. The feeling was one he hadn't had for a long time, but he could taste the familiarity of it, working through his system like a drug.

Heather typed something on her phone, and it was almost as if he could feel each finger that touched her screen poking at his heart and his balls simultaneously.

*Really. What an ass.
Both of you.*

Toby read the message and smiled, but a new message was materializing beneath it, and it stopped his heart right in his chest when it appeared.

What's the bet?

Toby's hands were shaking slightly. He looked over at Heather, who was feigning absorption in a conversation with the ladies at her table, her fingers stroking her wine glass seductively. He typed. Sent. Stared at his screen.

My tab

It took Heather a long time to respond, and Toby had a feeling he had pissed her off. His head was swimming: what the hell was he playing at? His stomach contorted into electrifying twists. Of course, Heather wasn't going to sleep with some bartender, he thought, trying to be reasonable. She would laugh it off here, and there would be hell to pay in the car on the way home. Rightfully so. He could almost hear Heather now: "I mean, what kind of *man* barter his wife at a bar?"

He stole a glance at Heather's table. She was looking at him, her mouth tight but smiling, a curiously mischievous expression on her face.

She started to type, carelessly, with one finger, as if she couldn't be bothered to answer a text. Toby watched her reply materialize on his screen.

*So you want to gamble your wife
for an MGD...*

He looked over at her. She was smiling pointedly at him, and on her face was an expression similar to the one on the bartender's face when he made the bet. A competitive, challenging look. All in good fun. A smirk. Heather made sure he was looking at her and rolled her eyes.

I did just order a whiskey...

he typed.

Heather smiled as she read the last message.

Toby was overcome by a sudden desire to make Chris look like more of an asshole than himself.

*He said you're an easy mark
No ring, probably divorced*

...Hospital staff...

Heather added before he could look up.

He nodded at his screen and smiled. He added:

*Line 'em up, knock 'em down he
said*

When he turned to look at Heather she had the phone in her fingers, and was looking at her screen with amusement. The bartender finished serving drinks to the batch of customers – some worn-looking ladies in scrubs who smelled like ashtrays – and spun around to clean something up at his drink station. Toby slid his phone into his pocket but stopped to turn it toward him when it pulsed with an incoming message.

*Guess if it's for a good cause.
He IS pretty hot*

He was frozen for a moment by the chill that ran down his spine, the second or so that it took for his reasoning mind to kick in while his gut instincts seized him by the insides and made his blood pound in his ears.

It was a joke, he told himself. His wife was not going to fuck a bartender in the bathroom of Salty's Haven.

But his heart was beating like maybe she would: strong kicks that felt like ice picks, all the blood gushing into his cock and staying there, straining against the physical realities of his flesh.

In the time it took him to un-freeze, Heather had stood up and crossed the small room toward the bar. She had a grin on her face, an unusual expression Toby wasn't accustomed to seeing and truthfully had never expected to see on Heather's face. She didn't so much *walk* to the bar as *saunter*; her hips moving sensually side to side, the loosened neck of her blouse shifting precariously over her bosom, promising but failing to deliver a glimpse of her breast down to the silky bra that cupped it.

The bartender gave Toby a haughty glance as he moved over toward where Heather was approaching, sliding a clean white rag along with him. If Heather found him to be "an ass," she kept it hidden in her face.

She looked, quite suddenly, like a different woman. Toby watched as though he were the audience at a movie theater, and Heather was a woman who was not his wife, as she smiled at the bartender and leaned against the bar.

The bartender leaned over to speak to her, and the two put their heads very close together. Toby couldn't hear what they were saying, but Heather's expression reminded him of a poised viper. She was going to say something seductive, he decided, and then kill his hopes with a well-placed dagger. *I'd love to hook up with you*, she would purr in his ear. *But see that man over there? That's my husband*.

He waited, smiling as if it had already played out as he imagined, but Heather was leaning in to speak to the bartender for far too long. The kid was still smiling arrogantly, and his arrogance only seemed to increase the longer she stood there.

Toby's heart had another moment of motionless panic when Heather lifted her finger to the kid's chin, placed it beneath his jaw, and said something to him with her lips very close to his mouth.

Close enough that bartender-kid would have felt the warmth of her breath, smelled the scent of her lipstick, imagined the taste of her lips vividly enough to make his dick hard.

There was no punch line. Heather leaned toward his ear, her finger still on his chin, and said something into it that made the bartender shift his feet and drop his mouth in surprise. Heather turned away, and the surprise turned to arrogance. He made his way over to Toby and swiped at the table, humming with conceit.

Toby stole a glance at his retreating wife, punched down the growing arousal and jealousy brewing in his gut, and waited.

The bartender stole a glance in her direction before looking back at Toby, conceit in his eyes. “Looks like you’re leaving a big tip,” he said. He let out a low whistle and swiped at the table. “Tell you what though, we’re cool. That one is a... *real* dirty girl. Ready to jump on it. Even I didn’t see that coming.”

Toby burned inside and out. He was sure a patch of red skin was creeping from behind his ears to his face, but he couldn’t place a finger on the emotion driving it. Was he angry? Humiliated? Turned on? Jealous?

He cleared his throat. “So... you gonna tell me what she said?” he asked, trying to sound like his interest was purely of the brotherhood type.

The bartender shook his head, cleaning the bar distractedly. “I am... not even sure I can repeat it,” he said.

This answer seemed genuine. He actually seemed like he might have trouble repeating it.

Toby’s phone buzzed. He felt for it, but his eyes were on the bartender, who still seemed so impressed by whatever Heather had said to him that he didn’t know where to put his hands, his eyes, or his brain.

“C’mon,” Toby urged him. “Can’t be that good.”

“She told me,” the bartender said, looking up at him half-seriously, half-greedily, as if he had won the lottery and just couldn’t believe it yet. He paused, leaned closer, stole a glance at Heather’s table, and then whispered: “She asked me if I’d be into helping her out with something.”

Toby glared at him and didn’t speak.

“She said – and I kid you not, man, believe me even I had this gal wrong – that she wants me to taste her pussy and tell her if the pineapple juice worked.”

His eyebrows were pointed straight at the ceiling, and he gave a disbelieving laugh, a gruff, “hee-hee,” before returning to shaking his head.

Toby stared at him. “*That* woman,” he said, finally, hooking a thumb in his wife’s direction. “She just walked up to you and said that,” he said doubtfully.

The bartender shrugged. “Lady needs help,” he said, as if the matter were beyond his own pay grade.

Toby pulled out his phone after he walked away.

Tell me what he thought of that

A throb gripped Toby’s penis so fiercely he almost dropped his phone. His eyes jerked from the bartender to his wife to the bar and all around again. What was the game plan? What were they even doing?

I think he jizzed his pants a little

Toby wrote honestly, scarcely able to believe this conversation was occurring with his wife.

He must be in a dream, he decided. He even tested the theory by looking down at the floor, which he noticed was missing in most dreams.

A worn, thrice-painted wood floor stared back at him.

He looked back at Heather, who was sharing a meaningful glance with the bartender as he prepared some drinks.

Okay but seriously,

Toby wrote, when Heather didn’t look over at him for a full five minutes. She had finished her wine. Toby had ceased drinking the whiskey – he had only ordered it to run up his tab in a show of confidence. He felt like things were slipping slightly out of his control, like he wanted the game to end.

Sure, he might have wanted to see it play out, just as the bartender hoped it would... but Heather wasn’t doing anything more than teasing, and this guy was going to get pissed off once he figured out the game they were playing.

*I think this guy is going to get
pissed when he figures out what's
going on
Better go*

He watched Heather reading her phone. The smile on her face felt like a kick in the balls for some reason.

Of course she had known that's what would happen. She had probably played this game just to prove her point.

This thought provided Toby with a modicum of relief: Heather was just being regular, old Heather, and he was going to get a lecture all the way home about not wagering his wife at bars for drinks, and that was good.

That was what he wanted.

So soon?

Heather was looking at him after he read the text. He couldn't figure out what she was getting at: was she being serious, or was she fucking with him? The reins in this game had somehow come into Heather's hands, and if the smile on her face was anything to go by, she seemed to be... enjoying herself?

I think so, Toby typed. Guys don't really react well to getting wound up and then disappointed

*Hmmmm
Who says I'm going to disappoint
him?*

Toby was a machine guy. One of the things – maybe *the* thing he liked about machines is that they didn't get out of his control. When things did go sideways, he was really good at rectifying them.

This felt like everything was going sideways, and Heather was some kind of rogue machine that wouldn't come back under his control.

He pondered it for a moment. Heather was pushing the envelope, or something... it was hard to say because this wasn't a game they had ever played before, and he had not expected her to react this way at all. Things had definitely gone into uncharted territory.

Adapt, he told himself. ROTC training was good for something.

There were two options: one, just get up and go outside, wait for Heather, make her feel bad for taking things so far.

Appealing, though not technically very fair.

And very un-technically, not what he felt like doing in his gut.

For some reason, in his gut, he had the inclination to do just the opposite. He actually had a sliver of hope that Heather would take things to the actual limit.

She would not, he knew.

But they could get close.

Now why did he want that?

Because Toby, forty years old or not, was a guy, this last line of questioning dissolved in his head like a sugar cube in hot tea. He gave a final size-up glance at the bartender, who didn't seem like the actual fighting type, but who Toby was also fairly sure he could take down if he got too riled up.

Risks and rewards tallied themselves loosely somewhere in his mind, but he was typing long before the accounting had actually been done, probably because there was much less blood in his brain than there should be.

He stared at his phone, trying to think of what to write. Something clever, something fun, but something firm, to make his real intentions clear.

Heather was rising from her chair, standing up to her full, glorious height. Another button had somehow popped open, and now, when she moved, the shiny, clean white of her satin bra winked from behind her blouse.

She was looking at Chris, a smile on her lips. She waited until she had his eye, and then she briefly turned up the volume on her smile. She looked away; she walked toward the hallway Chris had pointed at earlier.

There was, in the world of men, no mistaking the signs. She wanted Chris to follow her, and the thing he was following her *to* was undeniably sexual.

Chris clapped his hands together and rubbed them, his eyebrows high, his eyes wild, looking at Toby. He touched the tip of his tongue to the center of his teeth and grinned. “Looks like somebody’s losing a bet,” he told Toby. “Gotta go wizz. You need another drink before I go, sailor?”

Toby lifted his glass. He did not.

Toby was moving his body, forming a smile, and remaining rigidly calm on the exterior, but behind this facade, his blood was churning and hot. Chris hopped over the swinging half-door to the bar, and pointed at a customer on the other side of the mirrored island. “Be right back, buddy, just have to see someone about a horse.”

Toby lifted the whiskey to his lips and looked at his reflection in the mirror.

Calm down, he told himself. Heather was not going to fuck some kid in a bathroom at Salty’s fucking Haven.

It was way too unhygienic for her.

Seconds elongated, while a burning in his chest made him feel like he was holding his breath. His cock throbbed, his ears were ringing. Part of him wanted to leap from the table and kick a door open back there, but another part of him wanted to wait in this cold puddle of jealousy and see what happened.

Nothing would, of course, but it would be... what? Okay? Nice?

Terrible. Terrible, if it did.

A minute had gone by. Nothing strange about that, Toby told himself, taking another sip of whiskey. His wife was a woman. Women took notoriously lengthy times in the bathroom.

The minutes ticked by, feeling like hours, while Toby’s neck grew hotter. He could feel his skin reddening, sweat forming at the nape of his neck. A droplet formed and slid down his spine. He picked up his phone, typed a message to Heather, and held the device in his hand, his thumb hovering over the send icon.

What are you doing?

Something – something he couldn’t name – immobilized him. His breath was cutting through him in ragged, ice-cold slashes. More minutes – or were they days? - passed, while a tunnel formed in his vision, straight to

the yawning hallway, blurring out the vivid scene at the bar. Into the blur went the sounds around him: the voices, the clatter, the irregular bursts of high-pitched, female laughter. All that remained was his own heart, pounding in his ears, the sound of his blood squishing through his veins.

And his hard, aching cock.

Chris The Bartender came through this tunnel, eons later, an arrogant smile on his face. He hopped over the door again, a smooth movement, hand on the hard surface of the tabletop, legs swinging easily and high to the side. Clapped his hands together, rubbed them, and grinned at Toby.

Chris was lifting his hand to his face as Heather appeared in the hallway behind him. Hair still slightly mussed. Lips reddened slightly with lipstick. Her walk unsteady but composed, her face devilishly angelic. She was looking at Chris, her features stitched together in a look that approximated “I-told-you-so.”

And in the foreground, Chris’s finger, just beneath his nose. His nostrils flared slightly as he sniffed the tips of his fingers.

Chaos reigned inside of Toby’s chest: fury gripped his esophagus, sent his heart into an erratic pattern. The heat on his neck squeezed another droplet of sweat out, and it snaked down his spine. An urge to reach over the bar and grip Chris’s hand like a vice, sniff the fingers he was implying had touched his wife’s pussy, and then slam his head into the table, felt so visceral inside of him he thought for a moment he had actually done it.

Heather was sitting down, dropping casually into her seat, the flock of females around her closing in like a gaggle of geese.

Toby’s vision went black for a second, or blinding white, and then Chris was standing in front of him, grinning. “Too easy,” his mouth was saying, the words liquid and dissolving in the rush of blood in Toby’s ears. “I’m not gonna make you pay up.”

The phone in Toby’s hand vibrated. He was still paralyzed. Chris was shaking his head, reaching for a glass; Heather was laughing, pushing the hair from her face in his peripheral vision.

His cock throbbed again, reminding him of the terrifying mixture in his system.

Chris was pouring a whiskey. He set it in front of Toby and looked at him seriously over the bar, one elbow down, a glint of male bonding in his eyes. “Hey man, this one’s on me, chill out.” He looked down at the phone

in Toby's hand and his smile became somehow condescending. "Read your message, man," he said, shaking his head.

Toby tilted the phone.

Time to go, bad boy. You good to drive?

"It's seventeen," Chris said, still wearing that peculiar grin. "Last one's on me."

"I gotta drive," Toby found himself saying, his hands working to take money from his wallet, a twenty. Vague wisps of thoughts urged him to leave more, make a sportsmanlike show, but there was no five in his wallet. Heather was standing up, walking toward the bar. Slinking, if you were to be fair about the way she was doing it.

Chris and Heather exchanged glances, they burned like kerosene in Toby's veins. Chris was on the machine now, turning it over to Heather, she was signing a receipt, no words exchanged.

Heather set the pen down. "Thanks," she told Chris, who only smiled and tore off the second copy as it was ejected from the mouth of the machine.

She turned, waved at her table, and walked out.

Another smile from Chris, his head shaking in... what? Disbelief? Condescension? Who could tell?

Toby's legs threatened to give as he stood up, ears still ringing. His tender cock chafed against his jeans. "Thanks," he heard himself say. He wanted the whiskey but didn't trust his hand not to shake when he picked it up, so he slid it to Chris's side of the bar. "That one's for you."

Another slow shake of the head, but Toby was already turning, walking away. His groin ached, his abdomen was spasming, and the ringing was so loud now he wouldn't have heard anything Chris said to his retreating form.

But Chris said nothing.

*

Heather had a buzz, and it unsettled her that she liked it as much as she did. Outside the bar – Salty’s had been the choice of the staff she was romancing, not her own – the world was brighter. The streets were shiny from a brief downpour she couldn’t remember happening, the atrocious neon lights of the “Saltys” sign pooled in impressionistic puddles of light. In her ears, a high-pitched buzz roared above the wet tires on the street and distant honking.

Toby was crossing the street. He looked like she had expected him to – well, like she had thought he might, if her suspicions were correct. In his eyes something she would have mistaken for anger was burning, but it wasn’t anger. It was something else entirely.

He walked toward her as if he had no intention of stopping, and for a second or two, she second-guessed herself. Had she been wrong, thinking that he enjoyed the show she had given him? A moment of clarity worked its way into her alcohol-soaked high as he approached her, something intense burning inside of him. For a second, she was gripped with the terrifying thought that he might strike her.

He stopped abruptly, just inches from touching her body, and stared at her. The night had cooled, his breath was visible as it left his mouth, his jaw shifting from side to side slowly.

They stared at each other, the air almost on fire between them. Heather, a woman of carefully plotted daily schedules, of precise career planning and weekly meal preparation on Sundays, her Germanic origins alive and well in each punctual, orderly task she did in her life, felt the rare sensation of something being out of control in her world. The feeling snaked around her like a beast, and her cheeks flushed with excitement.

Toby put a hand on the window of the truck, stepping closer to her. He was raging inside, and Heather couldn’t help but feel the effect of it. Even if he was mad, it was intoxicating to see *something*, anything, swirling beneath his placid and resigned exterior. She hadn’t seen anything there for years.

His hand was on her throat. How it got there – in a sudden movement, a pulled punch, or slowly, trembling – she had no idea. But it closed around her neck gingerly, applying no pressure, only the insinuation of... something. His thumb stroked the hollow of her throat, and the sensation of it traveled straight to her pussy, where it bloomed into a pool of

electricity. She dedicated a moment's thought to this feeling – she was actually turned *on*.

“What did you do?”

His voice was shaking – only barely, hardly noticeably at all. But she felt the tremor like hands on her body, and it made her shudder.

“What do you think I did?” she countered. His thigh was close to her, and she felt the jerk of his cock when she uttered this question, confirming that she had guessed right, played the game right. Why she had done that, she couldn't say. But he was turned on, all right.

Guilt, she knew, should be coming for her now. But it wasn't.

Toby's hand was at the side of her leg now, bunching up the fabric of her skirt. His jaw had stopped moving side-to-side, and his hazel eyes seemed almost rigid in their fixation on her own. She noticed the stubble on his jaw, had a tremor travel down her neck as she thought of it scraping the inside of her thigh, the side of her own jaw. His fingers were moving along her leg, past the thigh-high nylons he had never paid attention to, pausing to investigate the lace that bound them to her skin.

His pupils dilated when his fingers encountered the uneven slipperiness between her legs, the dampness of her panties. Was he investigating, or was he there simply to pleasure her? Did it matter to her which it was? His touch was igniting her like it hadn't for maybe a decade.

“Did you win your bet?” she said, and she was excited that his cock pulsed again, next to her thigh. Now that he had hiked her skirt up, she could feel against the front of her leg that his jeans were wet with precum.

“Did I?” he asked. His eyes were on her lips now, trying to find something there, maybe thinking of how he could actually eat them. His finger hooked beneath her panties and he pushed himself closer to her. A car passed them: they were in public for Christ's sake. “Yeah-ha,” a boy's voice called from the vehicle.

Heather's lids were half-closed now. Toby had his knuckle on her clit, a finger inside of her, a move he had never done before. He ground his finger against her swollen button, which sent a jolt of pleasure through her and made her whole body give a tiny jerk with each rhythmic pulse. She felt her lips peel away from each other and her mouth fall open to take a breath. Stars began to invade at the very corner of her eyes.

Another car, another lewd comment, Toby's hand on the door handle next to her, her body pulling forward, his hands pushing her into the truck, lifting her by the hips so she could scoot in, a depression in her high as his fingers left her body and left her hanging so close to orgasm it made her teeth hurt.

He was climbing inside. He had given a short look to both sides of the truck while he unfastened his belt and drew his zipper down. He had the look of a man who was no longer going to fuck around on his face; he was driven too far. It had been a long time since she had seen that look, more than a decade. In fact, the last time she had seen was the night they had first had sex, much the same way, in her car, in the parking lot of student housing. Sweet Toby who she had been stringing along had begun by making out with her through the window, and then, like tonight, the look of hunger consuming him now had traveled across his face and he had opened the door, flung the seatback down, and fucked her right there in the car.

His hands pushed her skirt up and pulled her panties down. She was his helper in clearing them from her legs, one shoe fell to the ground with a sickening plop, but the price of them and the possibility of a scuff marring her perfect appearance evaporated from her mind when Toby climbed on top of her, one hand wrestling with his cock in his pants.

There was no more talking, their eyes were locked, and Toby was inside of her in seconds. The scrape of his stubble on her neck made her shudder, she could feel his jeans and the zipper somewhere on her thigh as his very, very hard cock filled her. She was slippery, sloppily wet: there were no rubbery places where his cock squeaked by, no softness in his dick, none of the usual semi-disinterest in either of their bodies.

He grabbed her hair and pulled her head up, bit her upper lip over-zealously, and fucked her. She felt herself boiling over almost immediately: the orgasm came on so quickly that the images in her mind sped by, layer after layer, no narrative composed in them at all. She lifted her head to bite Toby on the shoulder, her body spasming so violently that when Toby came inside of her she almost didn't realize it.

Toby leaned his forehead against hers. Her legs were shaking, he was panting, sweat had beaded on her upper lip. They remained like this, both of them stunned by the passion that had gripped them, the sweetness of

it. A loud honk behind them, and the teasing call of a male voice, made a curtain fall over Heather's mood suddenly.

She sat up and slid into the driver's seat. "Close that door," she ordered Toby. "Oh, shoot, no, wait... get my shoe, grab it off the ground!"

The dreamy state she had been in was evaporating quickly: she had just fucked her husband in the car, on a street that, while not exactly a freeway, was busy enough that three or four people had seen (and commented on) what they were up to. Her clients could have come out of the bar at any moment...

She flipped the mirror toward her face and straightened out her hair – she was a wreck, but it was easy to fix. She dabbed at her mascara, straightened a blurred line of lipstick, and smoothed her tidy blond hair back into place. "Oh my God," she commented, daring at last to look toward the entrance of Salty's. "I can't believe we just did that."

Toby was smiling. He had the satisfied smile of a man who has just gotten laid, and anything else he was thinking about seemed to have gone out the window of his mind. He chuckled and handed her the dropped shoe, as she straightened her underwear, feeling his warm cum slippery on her thighs.

"You're not driving," he told her.

Heather gripped the steering wheel. "I know," she said. "I'm just making sure none of those ladies see me switching seats."

Toby scooted closer to her. "You can climb over my lap," he said.

Heather could feel her uptight nature clawing toward the surface. Sometimes she felt like it was a zombie in some B-grade horror film, clawing out of the dirt of a grave, moaning incoherently. She looked at Toby and bit her lip, not aware that she was doing it, not knowing that she was only driving Toby a little crazier by doing so.

She looked at the door and scooted sideways. "Okay," she whispered. "Let's go."

As she passed over Toby's lap, she felt his cock, still hard, against the very top of the indent of her crack, hard against her tailbone.

Still hard, after all that.

She had a fluttering feeling in her abdomen, and her dripping pussy squeezed tight against the ache that was resurging.

Toby turned on the truck. "What was *that*?" he asked.

Heather was far from sober. All that had transpired in this odd evening was welling up, flooding her mind, making it impossible to see any of it clearly right now.

They stared into the street.

Her chest started to feel cool again. It was the coolness of worry and guilt, and it only amplified itself, because she felt guilty and worried that she enjoyed it.

She looked over at Toby when the staff she had brought to Salty's exited the building. Good: at least they hadn't seen her.

But this didn't lift the clouds that hovered over her head: to the contrary, it made it all that much darker.

She put her hand out to Toby's thigh. The words were coming out of her mouth before she had even completed a thought. Was it because she was drunk? Was it because she couldn't believe what had actually happened? Or was it because... she was the sort of person who could convince herself, really convince herself, that things had happened exactly as she had planned for them to happen, if only she told the lie frequently enough, and with conviction?

"Nothing happened with that guy," she said. So much time had passed that it didn't seem like a response to Toby's question anymore, more like an unbidden confession.

Toby turned to look at her. The expression on his face was hard to get her head around.

"I could see you were getting hotted up about it," Heather sighed, waving a hand dismissively, "and I was drunk, so I waited for him and then I told him, 'hey will you go pretend something happened between us, it turns my husband on?'" She leaned her head back on the seat and looked at Toby.

He couldn't deny it turned him on, she thought, as she waited for his response. She pushed hard against the guilty feeling that was trying to trample through her memory. What she had just said was true... this is what she had said to Chris. Word-for-word.

Toby was still looking at her strangely. "You what?" And then, interrupting himself: "What did he say to that?"

Heather surprised herself by being ready for this question, just in the nick of time. Somehow, she had sensed Toby would ask *just that*, and she

kept her face perfectly still, her eyes on his, and in the fractions of seconds that she had to think about her answer, she decided to keep some of the truth concealed.

After all, what would come of telling Toby anything but this:

“He was like, ‘No shit.’ And he shrugged and said, ‘well, helps me win a bet.’”

And this was exactly what Chris had said. Word for word. So when Heather dropped her voice to a rugged baritone, imitated Chris’s young, iGen accent and the way he shrugged his shoulders, she came across as believable.

Because, Heather reminded herself, she was telling the truth.

In another flash, she resolved to tell the truth, the whole truth, if Toby were to ask any more questions.

If he said, for example, “Did anything else happen?” she would tell him.

She would.

Toby shook his head and looked out the window. “Well,” he said.

He put the truck in drive.

“That was pretty hot,” he added, finally.

Heather’s heart soared, relief rushed through her veins. And then, following behind it, black and thick and slow-moving, came guilt.

“It was,” she said, smiling.

That was true, too, she reasoned.

Toby pulled into the street and made a three-point turn to take them out to the highway. They drove in silence, Toby with a smile on his lips. Heather smiled, too. But it was mostly to erect a wall, so that Toby would not turn to her and ask: “What happened after that?”

Because Chris *had* shrugged, and he *had* said, *no shit. Well, helps me win a bet.*

And then he had loped into the hallway, where she was waiting by the women’s bathroom, and they had high-fived. Chris had moved closer to her with each exchange of words they shared – and what had they spoken about? Chris had said something about this being a common fantasy for men, she had expressed surprise.

He had moved closer. Close enough to notice the stubble just crowning on his jaw, the shape of his muscles under his shirt, a slight bend

on the bridge of his nose. That he smelled like cedar for some reason.

“It is,” he had told her, his eyes freezing her in place like they were a tractor beam. “I don’t mind playing my part.” He had leaned toward her, into her, while in one motion so smooth and quick it was happening before she had any time to think about it, let alone stop it: his fingers were under her skirt, right against her clit through the fabric of her panties, and she stared at him as he looked in her eyes and grinned.

Through her body a tremor passed that felt like nothing she had ever felt before. She would think about it later: was it the illicitness of what they were doing? The fact that the bartender was so hot, or that he was technically assaulting her? Was it that the game had gone too far, that she held some resentment toward Toby for playing it at all? Was it the possibility of being caught, or the thrill of getting away with it? Was she doing it because she had led Chris on, and she felt like he deserved something at least? Because Toby had a point: men didn’t enjoy getting fucked with when it came to this particular topic.

She would never know why she stood there, frozen in place, her lips parted, staring into Chris’s eyes as he hooked a finger under her panties, gave her clit a practiced and skilled rub, then pulled his hand from out of her skirt and strolled away down the hall.

It was almost – *almost* – as if it had never happened at all.

Returning her conscious mind to the car, Heather leaned against the back of her seat, fighting a frown that threatened to turn her mouth down. Guilt was blackening her good time.

Toby put a hand on her knee, and the heat of his touch traveled down her leg and to the center of her pussy. A flash of Chris’s lips, the hard muscle of his body against her, the too-bright hallway light, the fear closing around her neck...

And Heather, who would have been the last person to suspect herself of it, was suddenly almost uncontrollably horny again.

They drove like this for a while, out of the seedy part of town and into the suburbs, where bars like Salty’s did not exist and you could leave your car on the street with the keys in it and reasonably expect it to be there the next morning. Safe, bright streetlights flooded the avenues and courts and circles with names like Trailhead and Rainbow Creek. It was the safe, comfortable, income-affluent part of the city.

The sizzle between them – did Toby feel it, too? - seemed to dampen as the lights grew brighter and cleaner. Heather looked out the window, and felt the danger and taboo of what she had just done becoming more absurd with every new, well-lit street sign they passed. She felt like she should say something, and the closer they came to home, the more she felt like it needed to be said. The distance between the drunken high and the crazy behavior at Salty's grew, and she began admonishing herself for acting so insanely.

And yet, if she let it tempt her, the memory of the evening pulled at her, drew her into a dark corner of her mind where she kept her desires and bad habits as tightly locked away as possible. She could feel the pull of doing something reckless, something free and different. Something *bad*.

She looked over at Toby almost the exact moment he narrowed his eyes, and opened his mouth to say something. He took a sharp inhale, and then paused, as if he had decided it was best not to say it.

"What?" Heather said, in that tone of voice that wives everywhere reserve for their husbands when they bit their tongues. She regretted prompting him immediately, and looked away.

For a moment there was hope: Toby said nothing and she couldn't see his face changing in the corner of her eye. Perhaps Toby, too, thought better of mentioning anything that had just happened. As the physical distance between them and Salty's grew, the absurdity of what they had done grew as well. At least for her. Surely for Toby, too.

"It's just..." Toby said, his voice trailing off as they turned the corner onto High Creek Trail Court, their own street.

Heather felt cold descending through her body from her cheekbones. She didn't move.

Toby pulled the car over three houses from theirs. They had parked here more than once when some marital spat had continued from the Costco or the bank, and they wanted to end it before they went into the house.

Heather turned to Toby and gave him a smile, racking her brains for something to say. Anything. Anything to distract him from whatever he was about to ask, because she was drunk and the whole evening was really, really weird, and inside her chest two feelings she rarely let affect her – thrill and guilt – were tearing her apart.

Toby was looking at her. “It’s just... what did you say to him at first? At the bar?”

The question made Heather blink slowly. It wasn’t the dreaded question, the one that would open her up to admitting something she actually couldn’t believe had happened, something she would take back in an instant if only there were a way to do it. Something so wrong, so out of order, that she almost felt dizzy thinking about.

But that wasn’t Toby’s question. Toby’s question was about something else entirely, and it confused her thoroughly, so she stumbled through several starts to her own question. She shook her head, babbled, and generally made herself look as guilty as she felt, even if it was about something else entirely. “Wh – huh? What? At the bar?”

Toby gripped the steering wheel and faced the windshield, his eyes narrowing, his mouth sort of puckered. This was his expression for when something was amiss at work, or the kids lied to him about something.

Heather's stomach curled into a tight knot.

“At the bar. Before you disappeared down the hallway. You came over and leaned over the bar and said something to him.”

This hit Heather like a brick wall, and her mouth fell open soundlessly. She had been so caught up in what had actually happened in the hallway, that she had wiped this entire scene from her working memory.

But it was there, for sure: all that had been required was for Toby to dredge it up.

“Uh...” she stumbled. “When I was at the bar...”

She had said: *That guy over there is my husband, and he likes it when I talk dirty to strange men. The only problem is, I can’t think of anything dirty to say. So maybe you should think of something.*

And Chris had leaned next to her ear, his breath moist and hot against her skin, a smattering of stubble scraping her cheek and making her instantly wet, all of her inhibitions melting in his baritone voice:

I think you can come up with something.

And then, she could remember this, but under the streetlight in her own neighborhood it seemed more like a scene from a movie, an actress who looked like her and not herself. The actress was smiling, and the actress had her lines ready, and they came out of her mouth as if she had rehearsed them a thousand times, shamelessly:

Okay, tell him I need you to see if that pineapple drink did me any good.

This was a reference for Chris alone: the rowdy hospital girls she had taken to the bar had struck up a conversation with him upon their arrival. They got drunk quickly and they were young and pretty, which is probably where the hospital staff reputation came from. Within minutes one of them had squawked at Chris: “Is it true pineapple makes your pussy juices taste better?”

So Chris had lined up six drinks with pineapple juice and said coyly: “Tell you later.”

This had been early in the evening. Heather had rolled her eyes. Just another dumb-dick bartender with decent looks who said this kind of thing with impunity because his looks happened to be boyish and clean-cut.

What had happened between that moment and when Chris, boyishly handsome, athletic, bartender-slut-man, had slid his finger into her panties, she couldn’t say.

But that was then, and this was now. And it seemed impossible to explain to Toby *now*.

She shook her head. “Honestly, I can’t even remember,” she said, her voice light and carefree as she could make it.

Toby turned upon her, incredulity on his face like someone had slapped it there. “You don’t remember,” he repeated. The tone of his voice was flat, but very, very pregnant with the idea that he didn’t buy it.

Heather looked at her hands. “Oh...” she said, and whatever end she had intended for that expression eluded her instantly. “I don’t... it was just something to like, make you think I was saying something dirty to him. It was... I was just playing along.” She stopped herself there: when she was fibbing, or outright lying, she had a tendency to jabber away until she’d told the whole truth, and this was as dangerous professionally – and now personally – as it sounded.

“Because he told me what you said.” Toby’s voice was cold.

This had her attention. She snapped her head to look at him. She raised her eyebrows and made a gesture that was her attempt at saying “Your guess is as good as mine.”

“Something about pineapple juice?” Toby prompted.

Heather put a hand to her face, covering her mouth: the movement was involuntary. “Oh God,” she said. And then, hurriedly: “I forgot I said that.”

“That’s pretty bold, Heather,” Toby said. “I mean that’s... that’s like, really leading a guy on.”

Toby’s tone was different than she expected, and it gummed up her thoughts.

He turned to face her. “Don’t... okay, don’t get me wrong about any of this, because, I don’t know, it was a game and we were playing it, and it was really hot. Okay? But... I don’t know. You can’t say stuff like that to a guy like that and then just... drop him on his face in the hallway. You know? That’s like... really dangerous.”

Condescending. That’s what was in Toby’s tone. A thousand marital fights before this conversation, left like cooling coals in some compartment of her mind, sprang to life as if someone had thrown gasoline all over them and fanned them for good measure.

“Excuse me?” she practically yelled, folding her arms. “Don’t take that father-knows-best tone with me. You’re the one who bet some rando bartender that he could fuck your wife. *For a tab.*” She was seething by the time she arrived at this last part.

Toby unclenched his fists, putting his palms out. “Look,” he said sternly. “I am not trying to start a fight here. Okay? I’m just telling you, as a guy, that if you come up to me and whisper in my ear that you want me to lick your pussy and tell you if it tastes like pineapple -”

“That is *not* what I said!”

“ - whatever, something like that, I’m paraphrasing here, then I am -”

“Well, that is a mighty big liberty you took with your ‘paraphrasing,’ Tob’, because -”

“I am going to, as a guy, be pretty ticked off when you are like,” Toby switched to a high-pitched, bimbo-voice that drove Heather absolutely bonkers, ““Oh, hahaha I’m actually married and I just want you to *pretend* that I let you lick my cunt...””

Heather’s head was imploding, and she knew she was losing control of her emotions, and about all the wrong things. She hated that fucking voice.

“Oh. Okay. But, ‘hey, buddy, I’ll bet you you can fuck my wife’” - Heather used a deep voice with moronic intonation - “will just *charm* everybody.”

“It was a game. You were playing it.”

Heather’s mouth fell open in outrage, and she made an incoherent noise and shook her head wildly before stammering: “A game, huh? Except now you’re going to tell me that I’m out of line, that -”

Halfway through her sentence, the fist of guilt reached out of the place she was trying to bury it, and then pulled its whole decaying body right out of the mood to leap at her. Sure, she could argue the procedure of the argument here, but at the end of the day, she *was* the one who had taken things too far.

Way, way too far.

Did it matter that Toby was admonishing her for the wrong thing completely?

Heather swallowed.

It would have mattered, in another life. Now she was just a woman who had let Chris The Bartender slip a finger in her panties. A woman who had kind of liked it. But definitely a woman who had taken things too far, even for a game.

“That?” Toby prompted.

Heather put a hand to her mouth and looked out the passenger window. She shook her head. “You know what?” she said. “You’re probably right.”

Toby stared at her for a full minute. She expected him to make a joke (write the date down! I am right! Heather said so!), in fact, she wished he would.

But he didn’t.

And deep down inside, where she didn’t want to think about it or even look at it, she had a suspicion that he said nothing because he knew that his wife, Heather, Attila of Arguments, was backing down for some other reason.

She turned to him after a few minutes passed and said hotly: “You’re right. Okay? Now let’s get home.”

Toby stared a few seconds more, and then he slid the truck into gear, and let it roll to their house.

CHAPTER 2

The kids were in bed, doors closed. Toby paid Alyssa, his receptionist/on-call babysitter, in cash and stared through her head while she recounted the events of the night, which were incredibly boring. The kids were on their electronic devices, then they fell asleep. Somehow Alyssa, with her monotone voice and attention to detail – two qualities that made her both indispensable and utterly infuriating – managed to drag this saga out for what seemed like ten minutes. She then rattled off all the things she intended to do tomorrow in Toby's employ, which Toby patiently pretended to listen to while edging her toward the door and thinking about his wife.

He wasn't sure why he had started the fight with her in the car. Had he started the fight? Was it even a fight? It should have been, but it left him unsettled because Heather had done something he felt he could say with good accuracy she had never done before: admit he was right.

"... and then, if I have time, I'm going to get to work on reorganizing those boxes in the back, the invoice ones? But it really depends on how long it takes me to straighten out that mess with FedEx."

Alyssa was blinking at him.

You're right. Okay?

"Okay," Toby told Alyssa, moving toward her so she would shuffle out the door.

"I'm sorry it's taking so long," Alyssa continued, failing, as was her tendency, to pick up on the cues Toby was giving her to wrap up the conversation. "It's been on the back burner for weeks now, but things just keep popping *up*."

"It's fine," Toby said warmly. Then, more gruffly, edging Alyssa into the mudroom: "It's been a late night, Alyssa."

Her face fell.

"Al," he corrected himself quickly. For some absurd reason, Alyssa had come into the office a week ago and started insisting that everyone call her Al, which no one could make heads or tails of or do anything about, because she'd been there two years and looked so much like an Alyssa that it defied realism.

She smiled. Toby edged her through the mudroom and opened the door to the front porch as she talked. “Okay, yeah, well, just wanted to let you... thanks for the gig. Anytime, I’m happy to come over, your kids are super-easy... you probably don’t even need a babysitter, but maybe I shouldn’t say that or I’ll put myself out of work...”

She paused to take a breath and Toby said something lame like, “Well, safety first, happy to have you,” and pushed the door closed on her, a hint she thankfully took at the last minute to give a flappy wave and skip down the steps calling, “See you tomorrow! Thanks again!”

Silence.

Toby entered the house, locked the door, and stared into the darkness. A nightlight in the upstairs bathroom cast an eerie glow on the upstairs balcony, connecting the kids’ rooms from the stairway. Beyond the living room, the hallway to the Master bedroom was lit by Heather’s bedside table. The stove light glowed in the kitchen.

Alyssa had temporarily swarmed his mind like an army, bent on tossing the place and filling it with banalities twenty years too fresh for him. Something about “tik-toks,” which he assumed was some idiot Internet thing. She had dampened his libido, and temporarily stunned his imagination. But the light in the bedroom, singular and dim, snaked along the floor and reignited his fantasies, his disturbed thoughts about the evening, the lingering doubts about what had happened. The guilt that he felt when he had thoughts like the ones he had had, and the lurid arousal he had felt.

He walked toward the bedroom, his arteries pulsing with the cool tingle of excitement. The bile of guilt threatening to rise up in his throat.

There were many things Toby didn’t tell his wife, and most of them had to do with sex. He assumed this was the case for most men, because he assumed that most men, like him, were pretty decent guys whose heads had been filled since age thirteen with the most filthy sexual garbage imaginable. That sea of filthy thoughts didn’t even include the shit dumped there by Internet porn: that was just his imagination.

It was the usual litany of filth, the kind of shit you could find on any decent porn site, and if he were to judge by the number of videos tailored to his liking, he was in good company with all the other men out there. Anal

sex, a little humiliation, gangbangng women, some dubious consent, some bimbo action, all that.

But there was one little corner of his mind that did not have a huge following, and it was a secret he liked to keep from his wife, any of his buddies, and if at all possible, from himself.

This was the part of him that sometimes watched his wife at a distance, if they were at a party, say, or a bar. The weird part of his mind that observed his wife the way *other* men would observe her: the straight, no-nonsense natural blond hair, perfectly coiffed. The naturally lean body, carefully molded by targeted weight lifting, swimming, and jogging, into a magnificent form that gave no indication of having given birth to two children. The petite features, the wide-set eyes, the hint of Scandinavian that flared in her coloring and bloomed in the shape of her face and the straightness of her eyelids. Her good posture and graceful movements.

The fantasies began like this always: an appraisal of his wife as a woman. The way she crossed her ankles when she sat on a certain kind of chair, the suggestion of pertness in her breasts that she kept covered with modest blouses, the seriousness with which she took herself as a professional and the promise of some rowdy sex kitten beneath the clothing.

The fantasy, making good time, progressed from those thoughts to dirtier ones, the kind all men would have. What did it feel like to sink into her wet pussy, and how wet did it get? Was she the kind of woman who would get on her hands and knees and let a man fill her ass with his cock, and how tight would it be in there, what sound would she make when he stretched her open? Was she the kind of woman who secretly, deep down inside, wanted to be thrown on a bed with her head hanging over the side and get throat-fucked like a cheap and dirty whore?

Where the fantasy started to derail was at the next bend. Sitting wherever he was, observing his wife this way, he would take a look around the room and start moving the men around her into position with her. His wife, never a woman whose fealty he doubted, would respond to these men, slowly at first. A shy smile, a tuck of her hair.

And then? Then she would fall on her knees and start sucking cock, or let some burly guy spread her legs wide open while he barreled into her pussy and she shrieked that it was so much bigger than her husband's.

From there the images became almost too much for Toby to watch: the neatly trimmed triangle of blond hair, slightly darker than the hair on her head, stretched to a thin line around a giant cock, her red pussy slippery and squelching as he plowed in and out of her. Her skin shiny with sweat as she turned over to take it in every hole of her body, all the while clamoring for more.

But you can't turn off the porn inside your own head: you can only throw the equivalent of a pillow on it and hope it doesn't make too much noise.

So when he had arrived at Salty's Haven, and found his normally straight-laced wife even drunker than she had claimed to be (Heather would not even consider driving a car if she'd had even two drinks, and she could only be pressured into driving after one if she had a half hour of soda water and cheese snacks to dilute it), and there was a very eligible male specimen flirting with her behind the bar, Toby had felt his fantasy kicking hard from beneath the pillow he had been trying to smother it with.

And then, in a series of events he could not easily piece back together, Heather had set his demon free by actually *doing* something he fantasized about.

The hallway to the Master Bedroom was dark enough to look gray in his vision, the light slowly eating up the space between him and the inevitable: his wife. His wife, who was a real person, his real spouse, and who had inadvertently carved out a new, dark channel in his fantasies about her by... what?

Something was nagging at him. Something about the way she had spoken to the bartender? Something that didn't add up? Was it a good thing or a bad thing, this thought that wouldn't leave him alone?

She was standing in the ensuite bathroom in her white satin underwear, setting a toothbrush back into the holder. She wiped her mouth and looked up at him as he entered, but he could barely see her face through the darkness. Her movements were loose, she was really quite drunk.

It happened with increasing frequency, this many years deep in their marriage, that conversations went unresolved. He was sure there was a lot more to say about what had happened tonight, and he could sense that Heather felt the same way. It was almost as if the air was thicker between them.

You have to say something, he thought. You can't just walk into a bedroom and say nothing to your wife.

He started to unbutton his shirt, a plain-looking plaid work shirt that Heather had purchased at an expensive store. Heather was watching him in the mirror, her hands on the counter.

The scent of her pussy wafted up from his jeans when he unzipped them. The scent was enough to nudge the dark monster in his mind, and it was up and roaring before he even had a chance to think about it.

Heather was moving toward the end of the bathroom where the shower was.

“So,” Toby said, looking down at a button on his shirt. He kicked off his jeans and started walking toward Heather. The rational desire to have a conversation about that evening was being eaten by his dark secret in huge gulps, and the desire to do something carnal to her again was taking over.

Heather turned on the water and closed the shower door. “So,” she said. Her voice was shaky, odd. There was plenty to talk about, Toby reminded himself weakly from the corner of his mind the monster was pushing him into. Plenty... to... discuss...

But his hands were on her bare shoulders, his thumbs hooking under her bra. His mouth went to the side of her neck, just below her ear, and he felt gooseflesh fluff her baby-fine, invisible hairs. They scraped his lips, and his cock pulsed. In his mind, he replayed – perhaps with some serious editorial license – Chris The Bartender speaking close to her ear, and his chest grew as tight as his balls.

Heather had turned her head to look at his hand stroking the length of her arm, which was slightly lifted to the shower door. The water kept running, steam was wafting from the stall. This was the kind of thing Toby would have been irritated by, with the same time-tested miserliness of all men about utility bills, but he barely registered the wastefulness of it. His eyes were on Heather's prickled flesh, on the flush he could barely see spreading down the side of her face, on the heat of her body and the scent of her pussy, which he could smell from where he was.

He pushed her hair to the side: it wasn't long enough to catch on her shoulder so he held it away from the back of her neck to place his lips on her spine. A very small shudder traveled through her. Maybe it was his imagination. “What did you say, exactly, to Mr. Bartender?”

He was out on a limb here, and he knew it as soon as he'd said it. It's just that there was no putting his monster back in the bottle: he should not talk about this evening, he should enjoy the fantasy of it, maybe try to eke out one more fuck, or maybe just count his blessings and go to bed... but that wasn't what he was doing.

Heather was still as stone for a moment her mouth open, her face pointed directly at the shower door and her eyes, if he could have seen them, rigidly fixed on something deep in her mind. There was a moment of free fall – Toby was about to retreat, prepare for a fight, curse himself for screwing things up.

And then Heather lifted her arms, and put them on the back of his head. Her silky-smooth skin rolled into contact with him, from her tailbone against his crotch, to her back against his pubic bone, the length of it slowly sinking against him until she was against his chest. He knew she could feel his rock-hard cock, and the pulse of it as she ran her fingers through his hair. "I told him," she said in a throaty voice, "exactly what you said."

Her hand dropped to his dick, and he was laid bare by that treacherous organ: any denial he might offer, any words that could come from his more rational head, were canceled by the excitement he could not stop from entering his bloodstream, filling his cock, making it pulse violently at her touch.

Exactly what he said... Toby's mind spun and spun, like a drunk on the dancefloor alone. What *did* he say the bartender had told him his wife had said?

"I need to hear you say it," he breathed against her neck. His voice had a growl at the bottom end of it, a need underlying it that rubbed him the wrong way, a need that Heather would notice.

He brushed it aside, or maybe Heather did, as she nudged her ass against him a little more insistently. "I told him to see if that pineapple drink worked."

Toby's hand was against the front of her neck now, and the words vibrated against his hand. Her voice was low, almost like a sexual caress. Her hand moved against his cock, brushing it with her palm. His dick was still sticky with the remains of their last encounter, and damp with fresh precum. Heather grasped him, just in time to feel his dick squeeze itself, his veins pulse beneath her hand.

“You asked him to lick it,” he prompted her, and let his cock do the assuring for her: that’s okay, he wanted her to know. I *want* you to have said that.

I want you to have done it.

The voice inside his head that made this clear pronouncement was so loud and clear that Toby froze for a moment, thinking he’d said it aloud. Heather’s hair swung as she dropped her head forward, and then sensually back, so that her ear was next to his mouth. The hand he had placed on her throat was still there, but his other hand had trailed down to her pussy, his long middle finger slipping into her very wet slit.

When was the last time he had found Heather so incredibly wet? When was the last time he had been this hard? Being married for so long, they seemed to both have come to accept that every sexual encounter proceeded much more like a checklist for a task or a chore: Heather would stroke him with what he felt was a bit of impatience, and he would play with her clit until she seemed aroused. But now they were standing in the bathroom, naked, having barely touched each other, and they were both ready to go like star-crossed adolescent lovers.

“So, how was he?” Toby growled. “Was he good?”

As if the ideas in his head were suddenly fed rocket fuel, he felt something surge inside of him, expanding so rapidly he thought he might tear out of his own skin. Heather’s loose, liquid body squirmed beneath the touch of his fingers, driving him even wilder. Ordinarily there was some kind of distance between them, the suggestion in her movements that she wasn’t particularly keen to be there. It bothered him like a high-pitched mosquito in his ear – never deterring him, never really showing him where it was, but there nonetheless. Now, Heather melted into him, hot and wet, and the space was gone.

She made a noise, a response to his finger swiping over the delicate nerves of her clit, which darted in her liquid slit like a fish in oil. He found it again and the shudder that went through her body went through his as if he could feel what she had felt. “Did he get to taste you?”

Heather’s head moved, and she looked straight ahead again. If he hadn’t been so lusty, he might have heard the odd, distant quality in her voice. “I have to tell you something,” she said.

Toby was beyond recognizing anything except what he wanted to hear, so he turned his wife around and pushed her against the wall, one hand plunging into her sopping pussy. Heather's mouth fell open, and then her eyelids became heavy, and a glassiness that was purely carnal consumed her pupils.

"What do you have to tell me?" Toby breathed. "Did you let him eat your pussy? Did he make you come? Is that why you were so wet?"

Several things happened very quickly: Heather's eyes opened in surprise, Toby found his cock and rubbed it against her clit, the sweet, hot, ripeness of her cunt slurping over his crown like a slobbery kiss, and he lifted her leg to better position himself to be inside of her.

Fucking her against the wall.

"Did he make you come?" Toby asked again, thrusting himself deep inside of her. He knew he wanted her to say 'yes,' and he knew he was playing a game that he, dangerously, could only be certain was partially a game. Heather gasped, and her body pressed against him, hot and velvety. He stared at her eyes, and her mouth, as her hard nipples gave rubbery scrapes against his chest and she bounced slightly with the rhythm of his fucking.

Heather dug her fingernails into his shoulder and tipped forward slightly, unable to support herself as her pussy spasmed and squeezed, her liquid heat gushing deep inside of her. "Say it," Toby breathed. He was just fractions of a second from coming, but he felt like he would be there forever, hanging on her words, until she said what he wanted to hear.

"Oh God," Heather said, squirming. "Toby," she panted. "I can't..." her words were eaten up by a gasp, her body going from limp to rigid again, her heels closing around his back and pushing into him to grind herself against his body.

"Say it," Toby growled. "Say it and then I'll fill your pussy up with cum."

He thrust deep inside of her, and she wriggled, trying to stroke herself against him, which was practically unbelievable if she had just come, but everything was so unbelievable and far outside anything they'd ever done that neither one of them could see it for what it was: Heather wanted to come again, and Toby wanted her to squeeze the cum from his

dick by telling him she had let the bartender suck her clit between his lips until she did exactly what she was doing now.

He refused to move, even as Heather squirmed and made noises like she had never made before. The look in her eyes, Toby would recognize later, was almost fearful, and though he would never want to admit it to himself, the look made him wilder than her thigh muscles squeezing his chest or her pussy slurping on his cock.

“Say it,” Toby growled, pushing into her and pressing her hard against the wall. She was pinned there, her legs fighting his weight and meeting with no success. The harder he pinned her, the more she seemed to get wet, and the more her pussy spasmed around him.

“Okay,” Heather gasped. “Okay... he made, he made me come.”

“Hard?”

Heather’s eyes questioned him for a moment, flashed with fear, and then seemed to recuperate in a bewildered way. She put her mouth close to his ear. “Harder than I have ever come before.”

Toby gritted his teeth and put his hands against the wall, slamming his dick as deep into his wife as it was possible to go, all the way into the deepest places inside of her. Looking at her face, but with the images of the bartender’s eyes hovering just above her mound, Toby’s cock exploded inside of her. He clapped a hand over her mouth as she began to yell, but didn’t hear himself, the deep, animal groan that was escaping him.

The next segue of events happened in Toby’s memory like a montage of scenes in an art movie: Heather’s head tipping forward onto his shoulder, their chests slippery with sweat, sliding against each other. Heather’s leg dropping to the floor, a trickle of cum sliding down his balls, panting, Toby smiling shyly, Heather twisting her hair above her neck as she stepped into the shower. All the while, nothing said or exchanged.

Toby was in the shower next in the montage, standing behind Heather, his hands exploring her breasts, feeling the heavy weight of them in his hands. Heather’s body was against his, cooler than the water she liked to scald herself with, her hands still holding up her hair. He wondered why she didn’t want to get it wet, moments before, or at the same time that he started to say: “Wow, what was that?”

Or that was close to what he intended to say, at least as far as he remembered it. But the question never left his mouth fully-formed, because

Heather let out a strangled sobbing sound, and dropped her hands to her sides. Toby watched water snake down her neck, into her blond hair, the world going sideways or upside down – Heather's sob was so incongruent with anything he was thinking.

His first instinct was to drive the sound of her cry straight to the deep, dark cave where his desire was hiding. The monster was retreating, but Toby caught up with it: of course your wife is crying because you got your dick so hard thinking about her fucking another man. *Pervert.*

“Heather,” he began, leaving his insides to chastise his impulses and doing damage control outside. “Heather, hey... please don’t get upset, I’m sorry if that was... I thought you were into it, and I...”

He what? What was he going to say?

Heather was already shaking her head, pushing the shower door open. She must be disgusted with me, Toby thought, watching her yank a towel from the rack and wrap around herself. Her movements were jerky; he took them for anger. He tried to prepare a defense, but there was no defense for him, was there?

Heather looked at him, her lips pressed together, head tipped to the side. It was easy to read this as disappointment in him, and inside his chest two impulses began to fight each other for prominence. One was the part of him that agreed with her: he was a very filthy man. A bad man, and he should never have degraded his wife like that. It would never happen again and he was very sorry.

The Other Toby – this was porn-watching Toby, Toby of the fantasies – was angry and kicking back. So a man has a fucking fantasy, and it’s a little weird. What happened here anyway, besides a little imagination being put to good use? It wasn’t like he had actually *asked her* to sleep with the guy. For fuck’s sake.

Heather had stomped into the bedroom and collapsed on the bed. She hunched over a little, a disturbing change of her erect and proper posture, which never took breaks, not even at funerals. Toby’s stomach sank, shame beginning to creep around his temples and cheeks, he could feel himself making that face that men make when they’ve done something very, very bad from a woman’s perspective, but very, very delightful from their dark internal monsters’ viewpoint. The one politicians pretty much had

permanently drawn on their face: downcast eyes, lips pressed together in a frown so exaggerated it was almost comical.

Part of him was still defiant, sure, but that voice was getting packed away as fast as Toby could pack it, because... well, Heather was going to cry.

She looked up at him, hands together, eyes wet with tears about to slip down her cheeks.

Her own lips pressed together.

Queer, he remembered thinking, and then he pushed ahead, trying to get his apology out as fast as possible: "Heather, please, I'm really sorry if I upset you... I just... I thought you were into this?" He ended it as a question, the dark monster fighting back, a fist through the wall. She *was* into it, after all. When's the last time you ever felt her pussy so wet? What was *that*?

"Oh, Toby," she sniffed. "I have to... I have to tell you something."

They had a friend, mutual, named Jake, who was a firefighter in Chicago and one of the most fire-obsessed fuckers Toby had ever met. Jake spent at least an hour at every event creepily, almost sexually, describing how fire behaved, which is why Toby at that moment had a very good mental image of what was happening inside of him. If you had a hot fire in a compartment, it layered like a lava lamp, and you could see it through an opening: super hot gas, hot gas, and then this layer of smoke-free air that was maybe only 108 degrees or something, where people could still be alive. He had seen the videos, because Jake showed them relentlessly to anyone he could convince to watch them. And if you fought the fire incorrectly, you could disturb this layering (he'd shown these videos, too), and the layer of smoke would form waves, wobble violently, and ultimately flip. Hot down, cool up, a total mess, "angry" smoke everywhere.

"And then," Jake would state theatrically, "you are fucked."

That was really the only way to describe the effect of Heather's words on Toby's broiling, layered emotions. She was crying, he felt guilty – and then everything flipped, and everything was on its head. And he didn't even know what the "something" that Heather had to tell him was. He just knew it was not good.

"Something" is always bad, if your wife puts the words "I have to tell you" in front of it.

Toby's head gave a small jerk of incomprehension, and no sound came out of his mouth, because he couldn't have told anyone what was happening inside of him any better than a house filled with a flipped thermal layer could be anything but fucked.

"I... I... don't know what happened," Heather whispered, looking past him, at the edge of a wall or a patch of carpet, some place to put her eyes that wasn't at him. "I really... and then, I didn't know what to do. At all. So I just... acted like it didn't happen, and now..."

"What? *What* happened?" Toby said. His voice was flat, a dull probe, a request for information only, no feeling there. Nothing but angry smoke, whatever that meant. Half a hard-on, whatever that might be. Jealousy, clawing its way back into his chest cavity, making his blood pressure high, ringing in his ears.

Dark-fantasy-Toby was rising up again, ears perked.

Silence banged away at the air in the room and made Toby's ringing ears tinny.

Heather's eyes went back to his, then looked away. "You won't... I can't even believe it."

"Heather," Toby sighed. His right hand hurt. It was balled in a fist when he looked down at it, his knuckles bone-white, and he consciously unclenched it.

Heather wiped a tear from her eye. "How serious are you about this... I don't know, game?"

A change of subject. The angry smoke in Toby started to flicker with fire. A bad sign in Jake's world, an unknown in Toby's.

"Why are you changing the subject - ?"

"It's relevant," she said quietly. Her eyes met his to underline this final statement.

Relevant.

Relevant.

How serious he was about this "game" was relevant to what she had to say. Something that happened.

Light was beginning to dawn for Toby, and he was just feeling through the brightening darkness, getting his hands on what it all meant, when Heather blurted:

“I was just playing a game, like you said. I told that guy, ‘oh, that guy over there is my husband so go tell him this’ – the thing about the pineapple juice – ‘and it’ll make his day.’ Something like that. He went along with it, I felt like he was getting a kick out of the game we were playing, right... and so I didn’t expect, Toby I swear, I didn’t think anything like this would happen.”

She looked at him, as if her confession were over, she was so sorry, and now she had the relief that comes with lifting a weight off your shoulders.

“Like what?” Toby asked. It would have been anyone’s guess what he sounded like in that moment. A hungry dog? An angry boyfriend? An adolescent football player? A reasonable guy? “Anything, like what?” he clarified.

Heather looked confused for a second, then stricken as she herself realized she hadn’t told him anything at all.

“I didn’t think -” she began again.

“What. Happened.”

A sniffle. Her fingers wiped away a tear with impatience. She bit her lower lip and pushed her hands against the bed, lifting her butt slightly from the bed. “He met me in the hallway. I said, ‘how did it go?’ or something like that.”

She looked at him again, and this time it was a plea.

She didn’t want to finish the story.

Toby stared back. Two Tobys, actually: husband Toby, who was making a good show of being mad. And Fantasy Toby, who was grinning and drumming his wedding-arched fingers like a ghoul.

“It was just.. it all happened so fast...”

“Heather!” Toby snapped, unable to take the suspense anymore, tiring, both as Husband and Fantasy Toby, of the time it was taking her to *tell* him.

“He just... slid his hand up my leg, and then... and I was so shocked I just... let him.”

There was no more thermal layer inside of Toby to upset. He blinked, his cock twitched, his pulse pounded in his ears.

“Tonight. This happened tonight,” he said.

Heather nodded.

A sob. "I'm so sor-"

"He stuck his hand up your skirt, tonight, and you just... what?"

She shrugged helplessly. "I didn't-"

"Under your panties?"

Heather, shocked, nodding.

Toby closed his eyes. Did he want this to go away? His cock was throbbing to life again, but the feeling in his stomach was one of impending vomit. Fantasy Toby was cheering Heather on, begging for details, painting a vivid picture in his mind.

Husband Toby was sick. This was too far, not what he really wanted. This was all supposed to be a game, just a game, not real.

"Did you like it?" Toby heard himself, recognized his own voice, felt his own mouth moving. But it was as if he were watching a movie now. *He* wouldn't have said that.

Heather couldn't look any more contrite or shocked, so she remained just as she was, mouth open, eyes brimming with tears.

"Did he make you come? For real, not in -"

"Of course he didn't... make me come!" Heather said. "I just told you, it happened so fast that I -"

"That you what? Let some guy stick his fingers in you in a bathroom and then, oops! I forgot to -"

"You were playing a game!" Heather shot at him. "You obviously *liked* it! I don't know what happened, I don't *know* why I did any of the stuff I did!"

Heather's eyes dropped to Toby's groin, where he had been holding a towel loosely. It was no protection for the growing erection. Heather's eyes went wide, and she got the gleeful look she got whenever she remembered some key point she wanted to make in a marital fight. "Why did *you* do it, anyway? Why were you so turned on by it?"

Her eyes narrowed, she folded her arms across her chest. She had, like an animal being attacked, been cornered, and now she was turning back on her attacker, teeth bared.

"That is..." Toby began. He was going to say, "not the point," or maybe "not the same," but Heather looked at his dick pointedly, and so he stopped.

“I mean, what am I feeling bad for?” she said, throwing a hand toward him. “You obviously get off on this. Bartering your wife.”

“When I thought it was fake,” Toby said, but he could hear the lack of conviction in his own voice. For a moment Heather looked as if tears would brim over in her eyes again. And then, as if she had caught something in the air, she sniffed and pointed at his cock, saying: “You don’t think it’s fake right now, and you’re getting off on it.”

It wasn’t surprising, Toby thought, that she said that.

Worse for him, it was true. But not surprising.

It was true that each word of her confession had strummed at something inside of him, that picturing her in a hallway, or a bathroom, or wherever she had been, with Chris’s hand up her skirt, made him hard. It was true that replaying in his mind the way Chris had brought his hand to just under his nose to sniff the smell of Toby’s wife – the real smell, caught on the fingers that had touched her body – drove him wild.

Heather was gathering herself up, morphing from the crumpled and tearful heap on the bed to an increasingly angry, disappointed wife. Her back was erect now, her arms folded across her chest, her features hardening.

They stared at each other. Toby desperately wanted to escape from this twist in reality. If he could find a way back to where Heather hadn’t mentioned this one final detail, to where they were both consumed by their fantasies...and away from what now seemed like a confrontation, and one that did not look likely to end well.

Heather rubbed her nose. “I’m sorry,” she said. “I didn’t know what to do, and then... everything happened so fast...” Her voice trailed off, her eyes wandered to the side, staring emptily. She suddenly collected herself, and looked up at him. “But I’m not going to feel really bad about it, not when you don’t even seem to... it’s not even that you don’t care, it’s like, you *like* that this happened.”

Toby cocked his head. Now she sounded accusatory, and *he* felt cornered. “I don’t...” he began.

“Don’t, what? Like that your wife flirted with another man? Or that something actually happened between us? Or... what? What is it you *don’t* like, Toby, because I can’t be sure.”

“I don’t like,” he started again, but he needed more time to be able to finish the sentence.

“What kind of man wants his wife to *do* things with another guy?” Heather demanded, and the tables were abruptly (and deftly, Toby noted, with some admiration) turned on him completely.

He began to splutter, much like Heather had, and shook his head. “I don’t... you’re not... You’re missing the *point*,” he finally spat out.

“You started that game.”

Heather’s voice was cold.

Toby was silent. He was no longer in control of the narrative: not the one between Heather and himself, nor the one inside his own mind.

“You’re the one who was turned on by -”

Toby jumped at this. “Oh, me? Me, I’m the only one turned on here? So tell me this, Heather: why were you so wet when we had sex in the truck? Huh?”

There was a very, very tense moment while they looked at each other with a vibrant passion that could easily have been hatred or love. Heather dropped her eyes and said nothing.

Toby looked at the ceiling.

“Why are we *fighting* about this?” he asked the ceiling. Heather, he could see, near the bottom edge of his eye, shrugged. Toby walked to the bed and sat down next to her. He had a deep desire to start anew on a venture into lovemaking, but he sensed it was probably the wrong time. For Heather, anyway. He put a hand on her thigh, and his cock clenched as he felt the smooth perfection of her skin. “Look,” he said, softening his tone, and as he did, Heather’s hand fell to rest on top of his. It fell as if someone else had been holding it and let go, hitting his with a splat, a sound of resignation more than anything else. But it was progress. “We both had a good time, didn’t we? I mean us, together. Right? So who cares about this little detail? If -”

“Detail” had reacted inside of Heather and brought her back to life. She whipped her head to face Toby.

“*Detail!*?” she asked.

He had known, as soon as the word had sailed from his lips, that it was a poor choice.

“I didn’t -” he started.

“You think of this as a *detail*? Another man touching your wife’s-”

“Heather!” he barked, taking her by the shoulders. “Stop trying to make this into a problem!”

Heather stopped mid-sentence. Her surprise registered in her arched eyebrows, her mouth half-open.

“But it *is* a problem,” she insisted. “Isn’t it?”

Toby held up a finger, because he could see that they were going to get stuck in endless circles if someone didn’t get this conversation off the track they were laying. “Don’t,” he urged her, “interrupt me, and try to turn this back into a conversation about how I’m a bad person because I liked feeling jealous. Okay? Let’s talk instead about the fact that we *both* liked what happened.”

Heather – and this really did seem like a first to Toby – clearly had no idea what to say. Her features bore an expression so foreign to her face that she didn’t even look like his wife for a moment.

He pressed on, sniffing, if not victory, at least the possibility of a truce. “You enjoyed it, Heather. You can’t lie about that any more than I can.” To illustrate the last point, he waved vaguely at his cock.

Heather stared.

“You can’t say you didn’t.”

Heather looked for a moment like she might pick a fight, and then she shook her head again. “I just... it feels so wrong to... you know. Say something like that.”

Toby waited.

“I guess I just can’t believe that you actually *liked* that,” she said. “It’s like.. it seems like a setup. I mean, what kind of guy wants another man to touch his wife? That’s like, it doesn’t even make any sense. And we’re *married*. This isn’t supposed to be... going on.”

Toby scratched his head with the back of his thumb. “There are more men out there who like this kind of thing, actually,” he said. “And women, too. It’s just that -”

“Oh, right. Swingers. People who say they have an open relationship and act like everything’s fine except they get divorced every two years? No, thanks. That’s not my idea of marriage.”

Toby rubbed his face. “I’m not sure what kind of conversation you want to have, here, Heather,” he said. “I don’t -”

“I want to talk about what happened!” she shrieked. “*That’s* the conversation I want to have!”

“But you’ve already told me what happened. And you want... what? What do you want me to do?”

Heather was apoplectic. Her mouth opened and closed like a goldfish’s for a moment.

“I want you to... I want you to be, I don’t know. The kind of man who gets mad about this sort of thing, or the kind of guy who is actually jealous when his wife gets hit on by a stranger, or something.”

“You want me to go and defend your honor?” Toby asked. The first half of his sentence was wary, because there was nothing on earth that would likely move him to go “defend” his wife’s honor at Salty’s, especially not against Chris. “What, you want me to get mad at *you*, call you a slut and beat you or something? Stop talking to you? What?”

“Slut?!!” Heather screeched. “I’m not a -”

“I’m not saying you are,” Toby said, holding a hand up to stop the deluge of epithets leaving Heather’s mouth. “I am just asking if that’s what you want from me.”

“No, it’s not what I want from you!” Heather sneered. “I want... I want... I don’t know. I want you to *care* that this happened and I don’t want to have an open relationship and I just want... I just wish this evening had never happened.”

Toby’s heart sank with disappointment.

“Why?” he asked.

Heather looked at him incredulously. He took her hand in his and kissed it, then massaged it between his two palms. “I’m asking a serious question here. Why does this bother you so much? Mm?” He kissed the back of her hand by linking his fingers to hers, and then lifting her hand to his lips. “Maybe this is like, I don’t know, an opportunity. We both had fun. Real fun. So why does that have to be a problem?”

Heather shook her head. She squeezed his hand, and a tear rolled down her face. “It just *is*, ” she breathed.

“I’m not mad,” Toby said bravely. “Are you?”

Heather rubbed her forehead and leaned her face into her palm, resting her elbow on her bare knee. She *had* to know that if Toby couldn’t claim to be mad, she really didn’t have a leg to stand her own anger up.

“Just be honest,” Toby continued, feeling like he was making headway, but through a minefield. He squeezed her hand again. “We did something new and you liked it. I liked it. Why does it have to be a problem?”

It was a conversation he had fantasized about having with his wife, but never believed for a moment would actually take place. The sensation of watching a movie returned to him. Things could have gone any way at that point. Toby had no idea what she would say or do next.

“So,” she said, her voice quiet. “You’re saying, I guess, you don’t really care?”

“That’s a loaded question, Heather, if I ever heard one -”

“No, specifically about what happened.”

A pause.

“Okay look, Heather. You’re trying to make this into something like, it means I don’t *care* about *you* because I don’t care – in the sense that, I’m not mad about it – that Chris felt you up. But it’s not that I don’t care about it, or don’t care about you. It’s...” he sighed, looking up at the ceiling. “It’s just not something I ever told you about because I felt like you would react...”

“How?” Heather demanded.

“Like this. Exactly like this.”

Heather’s eyes narrowed and she stared at the wall in front of her, but said nothing for a few moments.

“So you actually *like* that this happened,” she finally said.

Toby paused, trying to find the best way to agree with her without setting off some other argument. Finding none at the ready, he nodded his head instead.

“Well,” Heather said, “I don’t think this is a very good idea.”

Toby’s heart sank.

“I think we better just act like, I don’t know. This didn’t happen, or something.”

“Why’d you tell me about it, then?” Toby complained.

Heather shot him another look. “I felt *guilty*,” she said. “I didn’t expect you to... to... get a hard-on about it.”

“But this is what I’m *saying*,” Toby said, exasperated. “If I have a hard-on, and you are into it... then what’s the problem? Maybe this is

something that will, like, we could get into it.”

“Get into it,” Heather said flatly.

“Or not,” Toby added quickly, wanting to prevent Heather from flaring up again.

“I don’t want to be a swinger,” Heather told him, again, in a flat and resolute voice that seemed to have no potential bend in it.

Toby laughed. Even if the idea was blooming in his mind at that very moment, with possibility and arousal, he knew that saying anything but what Heather wanted to hear right now would be a terrible idea. “No one is saying that,” he said reassuringly, bringing a hand up to her back. “It was just a little fun.”

Heather looked at him. “So you’re not mad?”

“It was just a game,” Toby said. “It got out of hand.”

He could feel himself talking Heather off the ledge, Her body was leaning into him, she was feeling better... it was disappointing, in a way, but a relief in the other. He might have sexual fantasies, but he didn’t need them fulfilled so badly that he would risk losing his wife. Or even spend a whole night arguing.

Heather sniffed. “It did.”

Toby pulled her close to him and rested his chin on her head. They sat like that for a long time, and then Heather rubbed her nose and squirmed away to her side of the bed. “I’m so tired,” she said. “I’m so... drunk. I need to just go to bed.”

She rolled onto her side and burrowed under the covers.

Toby stared at the wall, the empty bathroom, the odd light from the shower still on and casting a strange glow over the sinks.

When he turned around to look at Heather, and maybe say goodnight, she was already asleep.

He turned off all the lights but the one on the bedside table, and padded to the junk room/office. Because Heather might be tired, but he definitely was not.

PART II: JERSEY

CHAPTER 3

“Don’t worry,” Toby told Heather, passing her a third gin and tonic.

“They’re running a shuttle back to the hotel.”

Heather took her drink and looked at it with mixed feelings. She was already pretty slammed: the only thing this drink was going to do was make her feel terrible in the morning.

But if she was going to exercise any self-control, it fizzled instantly in the primary-colored flashes of light from the stage, and opening measures of The Electric Slide.

She tipped her head back and downed the drink. It was a comedic gesture, for Toby’s benefit. She was hardly a hard-core drinker. He laughed and put his fingers gently under the bottom of the glass as if he were helping her. “There you go. That’s it. Just let the gin make it all better,” he said jokingly.

It was a strong drink, burning in her throat. She closed her eyes. “Dang,” she said, wiping her mouth. “That was *strong*.”

Toby shook the ice in his whiskey. “I got you a double.”

Ordinarily, Heather would have been dismayed by both herself and Toby, getting her that much booze. Since the night at Salty’s that had gotten so out-of-hand, she had kept a lid on her drinking as much as possible, limiting herself to one drink and throwing herself at the opportunity to be a designated driver. She had kept it up for eight months, not wanting an open door to anything like what had happened at Salty’s happening again.

But this was, without a doubt, the most uncomfortable wedding she’d ever been to, and it required some help.

Toby’s hand descended into her lap like a crane, lifting the emptied glass from her loose fingers. “Get you another one?” he asked.

She brought a hand to her face, tapping her lips lightly with her fingers. Her lip gloss stuck to the pads of her fingertips and she pressed her lips together to fix the unevenness made by her touch. “Why not?” she replied. The booze was already going to her head, and it felt dangerous. She didn’t want to smooth away the feelings that kept her far away from doing anything remotely related to what had occurred so many months ago. That included drinking, having fun, staying out late, flirting with or even talking

to bartenders. She gave a glance around the lame wedding, and boozily confirmed that there was no danger of any of those things (drunkenness apart) happening here.

Toby departed, and she was left staring at the nearly empty dance floor, on which a handful of couples were trying, with little success, to save the event from itself by dancing without any genuine enthusiasm.

No one was sure what had transpired between the bride and groom, but they were as visibly annoyed with each other as it was possible to be at your own wedding. Dave, the groom, was an old buddy of Toby's, who had worked for him on and off for years while he circled his career options a little bit like a vulture, settling at last on the carcass of used car sales. Liz, the bride, was a bookish, mousy woman Dave had dated for eternities, who had a PhD in biology, worked for a pharmaceutical company, and tested things on mice for a living. No one present, Heather was sure, actually believed that these two would be getting married without Liz's job being dangled as a sweetener for Dave: why *she* was doing it, no one knew for sure, but everyone guessed (without saying it outright) that it was probably fear of loneliness. It was a semi-sad, resigned wedding.

Heather looked at Liz. Her hair was dyed blond for the wedding and piled on her head in a sculpture of curls and hairspray that looked ripped from the pages of a New Jersey hairdresser's magazine from the eighties. She and Dave were sitting at a table, hands laid on the white tablecloth, Dave's over Liz's in a very stiff display of affection.

The cold between them was like a polar vortex, giving the entire party severe wind-chill. Liz's mother had suffered a mini-stroke two days earlier, and the prevailing rumor was that the wedding itself had caused her so much stress she had literally stroked out, leaving one side of her face mouth drooping slightly more than usual. Not enough to keep her from insisting that the wedding should go on as planned.

Whether this was the cause of the glacial temperatures between the couple, no one knew for certain. But the obvious coolness between them was having a dampening effect on everyone, and the DJ hired at the last minute due to a cancellation by the "real DJ" was not helping anything. They might have been better off with no music at all.

Toby was back. He was pretty lit, and had been since their arrival in New Jersey. He was moving with loose, exaggerated movements, and he

plopped in the chair next to Heather with a grin and a fourth gin and tonic, which Heather took from his hands as he had taken her glass from hers, like a crane. “Somebody save this wedding,” she said dryly.

Toby smiled. “It may be up to us.”

This was a vague reference to the jabs they’d been making since they arrived, three days ago, about the general un-coolness of Liz’s friends, who all seemed dazed to be out of the laboratory and not terribly familiar with who Liz was. Dave’s relatives were all people who, like Dave, seemed able to sleep with their eyes open, and appeared to be doing just that. It made uptight Heather and stoic Toby look like party animals.

Three couples and a single friend had gone onto the dance floor at the start of the song, and now only three people remained. The DJ showed no signs of recognizing a problem, and Liz and Dave were now moving their mouths in tight conversational displeasure, without looking at each other.

“Okay,” Heather found herself saying, just seconds before slamming her fourth drink. She crunched an ice cube while Toby stared at her from her right.

She lifted her right foot, uncrossing her legs, and her heel made a loud thump on the floor. “Let’s do it,” she said, taking Toby’s hand.

She felt her self-control slipping, but the gin was chasing right after it, numbing it before she could stop herself.

Heather was wearing a white sundress heavily saturated by a rose-red flower design, styled after fifties pin-up girl dresses: a halter top that cut low between her breasts. The waist was narrow, and the skirt bouncy to the knees; the dress gave her the appearance of having an hourglass figure. Her own straight, naturally blond hair was gathered and twisted up in a loose bun at the side of her head, with a red flower and sprigs of baby’s breath adorning the knot, and red lipstick in the exact shade of the pattern on her dress. The lipstick was less expensive than her usual brand, and too sticky, but she had applied it in such a way that her lips looked fuller than usual and a bit like they’d been bee-stung. Also a bit... libertine. Or cheaply whoreish. The dress and her general classiness canceled it out, but the sticky, candy-flavored lipstick beckoned with all the taboo promises of a Lolita.

She looked *hot*, which had not really been her intention. In the never-ending streak of bad luck that had been everything to do with this wedding, Liz's sister had come down with a debilitating flu, so Liz had asked Heather to stand in for her to keep the carefully orchestrated wedding party "even". The bridesmaids were all wearing red in some form or another, and Heather had been forced to go shopping the day before the wedding. This was the only dress she had found that fit and didn't make her look like a streetwalker. Liz had approved it from a photo: Heather had only been thinking of matching the other girls' outfits. No one had been there with her to tell her she looked *too good* in that dress to wear it as a bridesmaid, unless she was best friends with a supermodel.

Heather herself, never really a "pin-up" type, had been slow to notice herself. In retrospect, she had gotten more than one very obvious check-out by the guys that she passed in the hotel on her way to the limo for the wedding party. Toby had let out a low whistle, but had waited to make his observation until it was too late:

"Dude. You look better than the bride."

Heather rubbed her forehead, thinking of the memory. She barely knew Liz, and had really been trying to help her out of a jam. Personally, she felt like anyone getting this wound up about a wedding was silly, but there was a sense of female solidarity that had compelled her to agree to be in the bridesmaid clan. She had felt like a shit for looking as good as she did, once she realized it.

She had borrowed Toby's jacket for the first part of the reception, but the air had become steadily more dank and hot until she couldn't stand it anymore.

The reception location had also fallen through at some point, and this was Liz's last choice: a beautiful old mansion with gorgeous grounds and three ballrooms, two of which were on the ground and second floors. This one, the only one that had been available, was in the basement. While much had been done to make it elegant, and the level walked out on one side to the pretty gardens, it was still a basement. Evidently, it was also the sort of area the landlord thought did not require air conditioning, but the natural cool of the basement was no match for the old school DJ lights, the increasingly tense guests, and the scorching New Jersey heat outside.

Heather pulled Toby up with her but dropped his hand almost immediately. She had a plan, and now she was going to put it into action. If there was one thing Heather had become good at in her line of work, it was putting on a show and selling ideas to people. She flounced across the dance floor, the anemic crowd of four – someone must have come back – looking at her with hope. She seemed to be on a mission, and they sensed what it was.

She was drunk, too, but she felt in control of herself. Just more... likely to do what she was about to do now.

She flounced into an empty seat at a promising table. She didn't know any of these people, or which member of the wedding they were there for, but that almost made it easier. She put her arms on the edge of the table, one long bare arm folded neatly over the other. "Guys," she told the table. "We *have* to save this wedding."

For a moment, it seemed that it would flop as a tactic: one young girl rolled her eyes and complained about the music. A dark-skinned guy asked if there was any salsa, which made the girl to his left quip, "Salsa doesn't work miracles. And these are white people anyway."

Heather could feel her features as they morphed into her very best sales face. Understanding, empathetic even. *You and me are the same*, her face was saying. *I totally get what you're feeling, and if I were in your position, I'd feel the same... but I have something here for you that will make it all better. All you have to do is say yes.*

She pointed a finger at the brown guy. "You. Go ask the DJ to play something better." She moved her finger toward the girls. "You ladies look like good dancers. Get ready." Then, turning to her right, reading the guy sitting next to her correctly with her well-honed professional talents, she recognized the joker in the group. He needed a shot of something, and some encouragement. "You," she said. "I can tell you're the life of the party. What do you need? Another beer?"

His companion snorted, smiles began to sprout around her like a well-watered garden. The Latino kid was already headed to the DJ booth with a smile.

"I have work to do," she told them. "Don't let me down."

She flitted off to the next table.

*

Toby sat for a moment, watching his wife. This sort of performance was not totally out of character for her: she was a people-person, and scarily able to swoop into small groups and establish rapport, then get them all doing whatever she wanted. When she did this, it was as if another personality had elbowed its way through her ordinarily straight-laced, reserved character, and taken up residence inside of her. She became whatever was called for: jocular and sharp-witted with the doctors, complaining and put-upon with the nurses, hard-edged and respectable with the suits. Whatever it was they wanted, she delivered.

She was flitting from table to table like a sexy butterfly, her lean legs dangling from the full skirt to her red shoes. Toby watched her mouth as she spilled whatever convincing words she was choosing to the people seated at the tables, and Toby was mesmerized as they responded to her. Smiles broke out, feet shuffled, people spread out from their tables to the dance floor and the bar.

The music changed suddenly: by the DJ booth, the Hispanic kid who Toby was pretty sure was a cousin of some sort, was waving his hands emphatically for the DJ to turn up the volume. Toby didn't know what was playing, but they seemed to have entered the twenty-first century with the change, and the beat was well-received by Heather's minions, who were now pouring onto the dance floor.

And then, there she was, floating through the crowd she had created, towing Liz and Dave behind her, her lips twisted in a triumphant grin, her eyes on Toby. She released the wrists of her bride and groom captives, and they melted into the now-fun, gyrating group. Her eyes were still on Toby's and his heart was soaring, crushing itself into a ball, his fears clawing at their jail cells, his pride swelling in his flesh: this was *his* wife, this magical woman with the red lips that looked ever-so-slightly slutty. This glorious, blond siren, who looked voluptuous even though she wasn't, was walking straight toward him.

She gave a spin when she cleared the dancers, and her skirt rose up with the momentum, higher, higher, almost high enough to glimpse her panties. If she had continued turning, it would have revealed everything below it to the entire room, but she stopped with surprising grace, given

how drunk she must have been. The skirt fell into place over her hips, and the disappointment from all the men in the room who had seen her spin was palpable.

Her hands were reaching for him, a smile on her mouth. “Come *on*,” she was laughing. She pulled him into the growing group of dancers, and Toby, drunk enough at that point, began to do what most white, middle-aged men do on a dance floor, which involved balling his hands into fists that he kept next to his ribs as he moved his hips somewhat in time to the music.

But no matter: the black cloud lifted from the ambiance of the wedding, and Heather let loose in her incredibly hot dress, which was only looking hotter as both of them consumed more alcohol. Heather had done her job invigorating the party, she was dancing sexily, but she was with Toby, spinning for him, smiling for him, while everyone else envied him having such a beautiful wife.

“Wow,” Toby said at some point, as they collapsed at a table near the bar. “You really turned this party around.”

Heather’s skin was faintly luminescent, a sheen of light sweat mixing with the extra makeup she had put on for the wedding to create an ethereal glow. Her blue eyes sparkled, and she brought a drink to her lips. “I did,” she said proudly.

She set the glass down with a thud – Toby remembered looking at it at that point, and thinking it wasn’t even Heather’s drink. This may have been the turning point of the evening, but who could say? Heather stared at the dance floor like a proud mother for a moment, then blinked slowly. “I have to find a bathroom,” she said at last.

She was gone, and Toby remained seated to catch his breath. A lot of time had passed since they had started dancing, and he realized he was much more intoxicated than he had thought. He waited, ordered another drink, and as the dancing fizzled a little in Heather's absence, he began to scan the room for a sign indicating where the bathroom was, or the red and cream dress, or the shapely body of his wife.

But she wasn’t there. He stood up, took a walk around, chatted with Dave, who was incredibly drunk, for a few minutes. Spotting a small hallway with a sign for the restrooms, he walked down the hall and

discovered at the end of it not restrooms but a stairwell that led to the ground floor and, evidently, the restrooms.

When he finally wound up the stairs and down yet another hallway, he found the restrooms and waited outside the women's door. The wait dragged on, laughing, giggling groups of women came and went, but there was no sign of Heather, or her dress, and he really had to take a piss. He waited, kidneys beginning to scream, not wanting to be in the men's when Heather popped out, until he could take it no longer and hurried in, rushing the job to get back out to the women's.

A woman in a blue dress who had come out of the bathroom earlier and had given him a friendly, almost flirtatious smile, looked him up and down as she passed him to go into the bathroom again. "Didn't I just see you here?" she said.

"Waiting for my wife," Toby said, and the full depth of his drunkenness became apparent to him: the words clung to his tongue and left sluggishly, in pieces, like someone was pulling cotton from his mouth instead of him speaking.

The woman's smile changed from flirtatious to motherly, which might well have been in Toby's imagination. She shook her head the way she probably would for a lost three-year old and in the same tone she might have used, said: "I don't think she's in there, honey."

Toby must have looked sad, even if he only felt confused, because she reached for his arm and gave it a squeeze in the same motherly way she had spoken. "I'll check it out for you, what's her name?"

"Heather," Toby said earnestly.

Fabricated memories of the bathroom scene he hadn't even seen for himself at Salty's began to invade his mind. Like a mob of children in a control room, they started to punch at his emotional buttons, triggering anger, jealousy, arousal. Nausea.

The woman disappeared through the swinging door, and he heard her through the opening as an emerald-clad teen exited and glowered at him. "Anyone in here named Heather?"

The door swung shut, and what seemed like an eternity later, the woman exited and gave him a shrug.

Toby watched her turn the corner of the hallway before he rubbed his forehead. Of course Heather wasn't here.

He wondered how long he'd been idiotically standing there.

For whatever reason – it was something he only half-thought about, for a fleeting second – he followed the blue woman's exit path, in the opposite direction from the stairway leading to the wedding he was attending. The hallway twisted and turned and dumped him smack dab in the middle of a wedding on the ground floor.

This wedding was more lavish, more merry, and better attended than Liz and Dave's function. It seemed as though a hundred people were on the dance floor at that moment, bouncing and laughing and making all kinds of noise. The scene looked like someone had tried to suffocate a rock concert with a giant doily. Hands were in the air, and the crowd was yelling the words to "Sweet Caroline" like it was the greatest song they'd ever heard.

He scanned the room for an exit strategy, mostly because he didn't have the sense to turn around and go back the way he came in. His eyes found Heather immediately, hand in the air, wide smile on her face, red and cream dress gorgeous on her bouncing body. It took his mind a moment to believe the sighting, however, because his wife was in the middle of the dancefloor as though she belonged at that wedding, and that made no immediate sense. He kept scanning until, like a record scratch, his thought came to an abrupt halt and he snapped his gaze back at Heather.

She was oblivious to him standing there, and some instinct made him want to secure that anonymity. He edged himself sideways until he was standing by a large potted tree drizzled with fairy lights, and stood basically beneath it, where he was sure the wildly dancing Heather would not immediately notice him.

And he watched.

It didn't take long to see that Heather was with the Hispanic guy from Liz and Dave's wedding. His jet-black hair was shiny and full, easily recognizable. He was tall, his back to Toby, but he was definitely that same young guy.

The cool feeling Toby had experienced at Salty's nearly eight months before began to pour over him and well up from deep inside as the whole scene began to materialize before his eyes. Heather laughing, smiling, dancing. Now the Hispanic kid was giving her a spin, her delicate pale hand in his. She stumbled, or was pushed by the crowd, and fell right into his chest. When she looked up at the guy with her hands on his chest

and her mouth open in a wide smile, Toby felt like someone had actually grabbed his balls and given them a hard squeeze.

She's just dancing, he told himself. He could hear himself forcing the words on the man inside of him who felt jealousy in the way men were expected to feel jealousy. As though he were trying to talk himself down from a rage. But the voice was also like a seductive, beckoning finger, drawing him toward it to *feel* the peculiar sensation he had felt at Salty's, the rush that had overcome him when Heather had told him what Chris had done to her. It was the same part of his mind that had savored the story for eight months, picturing Chris's fingers slipping beneath the fabric of his wife's panties while Toby jerked off in the shower.

He watched her for a long time, losing himself in the moment so completely that he forgot he wasn't at the right wedding, and gave no consideration to what he might look like, standing behind a LED-drenched potted plant with a zombie-like expression on his face, getting an erection, at a wedding he wasn't even invited to.

Heather spun under the guy's arms again and laughed. He was pulling her closer with each turn, and Heather was melting into them a little too much. With each song, they seemed to be getting closer to each other, Heather's hands were on his chest, feeling his muscle -

"Can I get you a drink? Sir."

A waiter had materialized next to him, and he had the stern, well-practiced expression of a man who has dedicated his entire life to being a head waiter and lives in eternally renewed disappointment that butlers are not much of a thing in America.

His question was a polite suggestion that Toby get lost, and he somehow radiated, very professionally, that he knew that Toby was not part of this wedding.

"I'm sorry," Toby said, flustered. He had a picture of himself suddenly, and realized he probably looked crazy, on the verge of disorderly conduct or flashing someone. "I just..." he pointed at the dance floor, specifically to Heather, "got lost after the bathroom and my wife -"

"Aha," the man said. "You're from the party downstairs." Extending his arm in concert with a slowly rising, terse smile, and without taking his eyes off Toby, he indicated the hallway. "That hallway will take you right back downstairs. Happens all the time."

He remained motionless, his smile frozen and his arm elevated, for just a portion of a second, but long enough for Toby to see that he would find a walkie-talkie soon and have Toby tossed on the lawn or something if he chose not to leave via the hallway, so Toby mumbled “Thank you,” and wriggled toward the door.

He cast a look back at the dance floor, where Heather was still bouncing happily with the man Toby was privately referring to as Jose, but she didn’t see him and he didn’t want to linger. He staggered dejectedly along the hall, down the stairs, and back into the wedding he was invited to.

With Heather and Jose gone, the dancing had fallen apart, but most guests were drunk enough that it seemed like a loud bar instead of a funeral. Toby’s vision was swimming, and the image of Heather laughing and falling against Jose’s chest with a big smile on her face was replaying in his mind to the point that it was, occasionally, all he could see. He zeroed in on the bar and ordered two drinks, one a gin and tonic for Heather, but he suspected he would be drinking it himself.

He sat down, and a stranger who seemed to think he knew him began chatting amicably. Toby’s mind was upstairs, his eyes drawn to the hallway to the bathroom and the entrance to the ballroom from a main set of stairs. His eyes must have looked like jell-o as they darted back and forth. His companion paid no notice.

The wedding was slowly fizzling, while Toby was slowly burning up inside. He drank Heather’s gin and tonic and looked at his watch, but the time was meaningless given that he had never looked at it before. How long had she been up there? Was she still up there? Was she ever coming back? Was it minutes or hours? He had no idea. Could he legitimately text her without looking crazy, or had she only just left and his imagination was running wild to the point of destroying his sense of time?

He was about to get up when the doors to the main stairway – not the bathroom hallway – opened, the flash of a reflection from the DJ stage catching Toby’s eye.

They were together, Heather smiling, her hair slipping from the many pins she had used to hold it in place. Her lips were freshly reddened, Toby could see them from where he sat. Did that mean she had returned to the women’s room to reapply her makeup again, after making out with Jose,

who was also smiling? Or did it mean she had done exactly what she said she would do, and Toby was acting like a psycho?

They entered together. Heather opened the door, tipping her head back to laugh. Jose was talking. They moved like a couple – not touching, but complementing each other's movements, not total strangers, with some intimacy between them. Toby's neck burned and he loosened his tie and collar.

Heather was so busy chatting with her friend, so oblivious to how much time she had been gone, that she walked right into an empty chair at the table closest to the door. Jose steadied her by wrapping his dark fingers around her pristine, porcelain flesh, and they both laughed.

Toby was now boiling.

Heather stopped abruptly, and Jose bumped into her, his hands midway up her bicep, his chest against her back. It was definitely not the embrace of a total stranger. It was the way you held women who belonged to you, or who you wanted to belong to you.

Heather was looking around, making no effort to wrest herself from Jose's grip. Her search of the dancefloor was lazy, she leaned her head toward Jose to say something, he smiled, her head turned slowly like an owl's.

When she saw Toby she said something again, and Jose looked right at him. The old direct-in-the-eye stare. An apelike string was plucked inside of Toby and he felt like snarling, but his arousal was stronger, and so he remained seated as Heather wormed her way through the tables. Jose followed at a safe distance, his eyes on Toby.

Toby's spine tingled. Heather stumbled into a chair and her skirt caught on it, showing a healthy expanse of bare thigh and the glimmer of white panties. She pushed it down with a laugh and stumbled to the chair next to Toby. "That party upstairs is off the chain," she confided to Toby breathlessly.

Her skin was damp to the touch when Toby put his hand on her back. He wondered if she noticed that he was not looking at her, but at Jose, who was walking gracefully to the edge of their table, standing, something in his body language on the offense.

The voice of the DJ broke through the ringing in Toby's ears, which he hadn't realized was there, just as Heather's foot rubbed against his leg.

“Last few dances, everybody, get your requests in... the first shuttle is leaving in ten minutes for the hotel....” his final words were eaten up by the music.

Toby’s attention drifted to Heather’s foot, bare, and the sexual motion she was making along his calf, a twisting, snake-like rub that traveled directly to his cock.

“Oh no,” he heard her say. “We were just getting started.” Then, theatrically, facing Toby with a strange expression on her face, she waved her hand up at Jose without looking at him. “This is Ron,” she yelled over the music.

Toby and “Ron” looked at each other over Heather’s floating, sculpted arm. They gave each other the half-hostile nod that men give to other men who might, somehow, be in competition with them, which is pretty much all men at all times.

“Want a drink?” Heather shouted at Toby, trying to stand up.

Toby put a hand on hers. He wasn’t sure what he meant by it, or what he wanted to do, but the idea of sitting there with Ron while Heather fetched drinks was unappetizing for some reason, so he rose while pressing her gently toward the table. “I’ll get it. Same?”

Heather smiled and shrugged as if she didn’t care. Toby met Ron’s eyes. “Ron?”

“Sure,” he said. “Beer.”

Toby moved in a daze, the presence of his wife and Ron burning against his back as he deliberately turned fully away to walk to the bar. It was as if they were radiating cold against his flesh. He let the feeling simmer while he ordered the drinks and waited for them, his eyes on the hands of the bartender, his mind on what Ron and his wife were doing behind him.

The wedding was thinning out. Somehow, he realized, they had missed Liz and Dave’s departure; the bride and groom were long gone. Ron had taken a seat next to Heather, who was reclining gracefully in her chair, dress clinging to her for dear life, her breasts seemingly wanting to burst from the halter of her top. The image burned through Toby: they weren’t touching, or even talking, but a familiarity existed between them that rankled as much as it aroused.

He set the drinks on the table with deliberate slowness and remained standing. There were a few pitiful dancers on the floor. This wedding was, in comparison to the fun he had witnessed above, a sad affair. He sipped his drink and realized he had no recollection of ordering. A sour and sweet taste announced that he had somehow gotten a whiskey sour – not what he wanted at all.

“Looks like that first shuttle is full,” Heather mused, seemingly apropos of nothing except the hollowed dance floor and diminished presence at the tables. “When’s the next one?”

She dropped her bare arms to the table, her fingers folded together. It was a fawnish, somehow sexual gesture that did not go unnoticed by Ron, whose gaze traveled along her arms to her shoulders and then drank in the thrust of her breasts as they squeezed together and pressed out against the confines of her dress, teasing anyone who looked with the possibility of just bursting out.

What happened next remained a haze for Toby. They started to talk to each other: the topic of conversation being whether or not they should dance, how soon they thought the shuttle would be there, whether anyone would want to continue drinking at their hotel or if maybe they should go out.

How many minutes went by? Ten? Fifteen? They were rising from their chairs, presumably they had decided to get on the next shuttle. They were crossing the dance floor, the promise of something illicit and tantalizing happening between Ron and Toby’s wife evaporating, Toby feeling too drunk to reason, Heather seeming more sober than he, Ron not even looking back at them. Disappointment started to snake through Toby, a measure of relief behind it like an aftertaste.

The music at their own wedding stopped abruptly for a moment. The DJ was having trouble, making an announcement. There was a general shuffling of people, a sense that the party was being packed away, a clatter of stacking chairs somewhere and the glassy ring of dishes being hauled away in the background of it all.

Amid the cessation of music in their ballroom, a rumble started above them and an enormous cheer wound down the stairs and through the ceiling to the floor below. Heather, who had been digging through her purse, which she had acquired somehow, stopped dead in her tracks as

though someone had played an air raid siren. She looked at Ron first, grinning wider with each passing second. Eyebrows went up. Toby failed to recognize the tune. Heather looked at Toby next and clutched his wrists. “It’s Lagrimas Negras!” she squealed. Then she swung an arm around Toby’s shoulders, and one around Ron’s, pulling them close to her face.

She was very, very drunk, Toby realized, just as several other, more salacious thoughts occurred to him.

“Guys,” Heather said. “I’m going to go dance upstairs. Are you with me?”

She was already spinning away. Music cut into the silence with a blast and then an awkward strangle, before starting up again full-voiced in the basement. Heather was sashaying toward the bathroom stairway, not looking behind her. Ron had his hands in his pockets and shrugged.

Toby followed, his eyes on Heather, his mind on Ron, who seemed to be coming with them. Heather glanced over her shoulder and grinned when she saw them coming. Then she was gone, skipping up the stairs, surprisingly graceful.

Hallway, dimness, stairs, bathrooms, girl in a green dress scowling, lights. Heather stopping just short of the dance floor, turning to Toby and Ron as if they were one unit. “You know how to salsa?” she asked.

It was a question for either one of them, but felt like an icepick in Toby’s heart. He didn’t, and she *knew* he didn’t. Ron looked at him deferentially, Toby felt his body moving, his hands gesturing toward his wife with open palms. Heather reached out for Ron’s hand and grasped it before jumping excitedly. They plunged, together, into the dancers on the floor.

It was a fact, usually inconsequential, that Heather knew how to salsa. Something that had bobbed around in general conversation: she had had a roommate in college who had taken her along to salsa nights and Heather loved them. It was something she had mentioned when they first started dating, and invited Toby, too. Toby had managed to avoid going, he could never remember how. They had gotten married, and salsa had made appearances only in stories from the past, only as a secondary character. The conversations usually ended with someone saying, “You should go sometime!” in a saccharine female voice, and then being forgotten for years on end.

So Toby had never seen Heather dance. He had, in fact, never seen *anyone* dance salsa. It was hard to see Heather and Ron at first, because this was a raucous wedding, full of, Toby was noticing, a lot of Hispanic-looking people, and everyone present seemed to like salsa. He could see the flair of Heather's skirt, the blond of her hair, the sheen of Ron's black mane. They were in motion, synchronized, and that was all he knew. The bile of jealous arousal rose up in the back of his throat, he stared.

And then, as if by magic, the dancers around Ron and Heather thinned and moved away to give the pair more space. The reason was obvious: they were out there spinning around, looking like professional dancers. Close together, sweat forming on their skin and shining under the wild lights the DJ had chosen for this particular set, predominantly a primordial, seething red that bathed everyone in a pattern of sexual black and scarlet shadows.

Toby stood apart, as if time had utterly stopped where he was, and a tunnel alone afforded him a view into an alternate reality. A reality in which his wife was not his, did not love him, and would not lie down next to him tonight, but rather, she was the lithe and graceful dancer in the arms of Ron, her Latino lover, who could pick her up and spin her around so that the pinup girl skirt she was wearing flew up and the whole party could see her white panties and long, sculpted legs.

Heather's hair was falling out of her careful bun, getting damp, clinging to her skin. Her eyes were locked on Ron's as if they had known each other forever, and their embrace between bouts of spinning was so charged with feral sexuality that Toby could feel his hard-on all the way through his abdomen. Heather, ordinarily pressed neatly into a model of thorough tidiness, was slippery in her own sweat, glowing under the red lights, streaked across the face by damp strands of loose hair, and her dress was moving around her as though it were a creature with its own agenda, spinning up, folding forward, revealing parts of her body in flashes that tantalized every man in the room.

The song ended with a blaze of trumpets that both Ron and Heather seemed to anticipate coming, because as if they had worked on the choreography for years, they entered into a final frenzy of spinning that sent Heather round and round in circles with her dress flared out and her pretty legs pirouetting for all to see, right up to her panties. When the crescendo

came to a final, clamorous stop, she rolled up into Ron's arms, her own arms resting on his shoulders. Her eyes were locked on his, they both breathed heavily from the exertion, but it could easily have looked like lust that made them pant against each other. Toby felt ill: their sweat was mingling, their lips hovering inches from each other, the taste of his wife was within centimeters of this total stranger.

And they looked good.

The crowd cheered and moved back in on the dance floor, obscuring Toby's view. He leaned against a wall and stared at the pieces of his wife that he could catch amid the raucous group. She was still, leaning close to Ron, and then she was gone.

She reappeared, smiling, her hands in her hair, rearranging the loose locks and tidying herself up. She was looking at Toby, a grin on her lips and a glimmer in her eye.

Toby had no idea what to say. Since their evening at Salty's so many months before, he had decided it was best to submerge his fantasy in some cold water, certain as he was that Heather would never play such a game again. Not that he hadn't kept the flame alive inside his private world, but this was different. It was Heather who appeared to be breathing life into it, rekindling the flames. He had no idea whether he could trust his judgment or not, how to know if he was only reading what he wanted into what he was seeing.

"So?" Heather said, tucking a bobby pin into her hair and smoothing it down with an efficient set of movements. "What did you think?"

Toby wasn't sure what this question really meant, so he stumbled over his response before answering, somewhat awkwardly, "I think... you're a really good dancer," he told her. He sounded like some guy who had a crush on her in seventh grade and was seeing her at a high school reunion.

"Huh," Heather said, leaning toward him and placing a hand on his chest while she dipped past him to a table, picking up a glass of ice water. "Is *that* all you think?"

The profile of her face was next to him, the graceful curve of her cheek above her red mouth. Her skin burned through his shirt, her sweet sweat, infused with lavender, rose up to his nose and sent a shudder through

him. Heather stood up, sipped the water, and sucked an ice cube into her mouth, while Toby stared at her, weighing the signs she was giving off.

She had a certain look in her eyes, a flicker of mischief that Toby had only seen once before: that eventful evening at Salty's. Was it entirely alcohol-induced? Was it only a tease, a thing she would snatch away from him in a moment to call him a crazy pervert?

Or was it real?

Heather set the water down, leaning over and then back again with the same warm hand against Toby's chest. As she stood up again, her hand moved slowly down the front of his body until it reached his crotch, where her fingers stroked the outline of his erection and made his cock pulse under her touch.

The mischief ignited in her eyes, and her mouth turned up slightly as her other hand came to her lips to pinch the ice cube between two fingers and pull it from her mouth with her lips wrapped around it, until it popped filthily from between them.

A shudder traveled through Toby as his wife, who had never done anything even remotely like what she was doing, drew the ice cube from her lips to her neck, and then down to her chest, over her breasts. Her pale skin turned slightly red where the ice cube traveled, and then faded to pink and back to white. She moved the ice cube to the back of her neck along a route that transversed the plump hill of her breast, the hollow of her shoulder, and just below her earlobe. A tear-shaped droplet of water bulged on her chest and then rolled between her breasts.

The fingers of her other hand, meanwhile, traced a lazy circle over his dick through his pants.

And her eyes glimmered with mischief, locked right on his.

The ice cube was popped back between her lips, and she melted into Toby much the same way the ice was melting inside her hot red mouth. She kissed him, the cold of her lips invigorating but almost distressing, her tongue darting into his mouth. It was like a kiss from a different woman, and Toby felt as though the world shifted around him.

"What if I told you," she whispered in his ear, her voice just audible below the pulse of new salsa music, "that I learned a very, very dirty trick with ice tonight?"

The music, and the lights, changed abruptly, and with the sudden change Toby's world altered as the words Heather had spoken made their way around and around in his head. It was so unlike Heather to talk this way, and now she was backing up, grinning wildly, rolling the ice in her mouth. Her hand was still in his, and then it wasn't, and she faded into the dancing crowd while Toby tried to orient himself.

He was following her onto the floor, just walking, staring at his wife, his mind zig-zagging between terrifying and exhilarating thoughts. Or maybe they were one and the same. He was going to vomit, he was going to ejaculate in his suit on the dancefloor if she touched him again, he was jealous and looking for Ron, hoping he would be there with his hands on Heather's waist, sucking the ice cube from her mouth, and praying at the same time that he was gone. Forever.

Suddenly Ron was there, and Heather was fawning all over him, leaning close to him to talk. They were moving to the music, so it was inevitable that their bodies came into contact: lip on jaw as Heather was jostled, hand on shoulder, breasts against chest. Toby had stopped advancing and was standing two feet from them. Heather gave him the side-eye, and Ron looked at him for a brief moment, and then Heather leaned over, one hand still on Ron.

"The last shuttle is leaving!" she yelled. "From downstairs. But I don't want to go yet!"

Toby stared at her as she hollered something in Ron's direction. Her hands were now on both men's shoulders, she was pulling them together, talking loudly from one to the other, wrapping them up in a plan. "I say we stay and crash this wedding!" she yelled, pulling their three heads together for a huddle. "I'm not ready to go home."

Toby stared at her. Ron shrugged, looking at Toby. Then, smiling, he directed himself to Heather. "Don't you think these folks will notice we're not part of this wedding?"

Heather shook her head vigorously. "No way. And they have good music. And better food. I say we stay."

"How will we get home?" Ron shouted, glancing at Toby with a grin that was almost friendly, nearly conspiratorial.

Heather shrugged. "Uber!" And then she spun and started to dance.

Toby was left looking at Ron. "It's up to you, man," Ron shouted, leaning in and down a little to be closer to Toby's ear. Up close, he was quite tall. He had his hands in his pockets, fingers splayed out. He was letting Toby take the lead.

Toby shifted his eyes to take in his spinning, drunk, flirtatious wife, and for a moment his hopes went soaring. Sure, he knew they would come crashing down again, but maybe he could eke out some more really hot sex after they played this game.

"I do what my wife tells me," he shouted solemnly at Ron, over the music.

And he brought his hands to just below his shoulders, in fists, to do his imitation of dancing.

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At some point over the next two hours, which unfolded in a hazy blur of drinking and dancing, Heather by the minute becoming looser in her movements, her dress rising with more frequency to show her panties, her skin glistening with sweat, Toby found himself watching his wife dance with not just Ron, but a few other guys at the wedding.

The group thinned out, and it became pitch-black outside the windows. Heather barely paused to sit in unoccupied chairs while Toby fetched drinks for her, for her and Ron, for himself, alone and watching his wife dance shamelessly. It would live on in his memory as a montage of hands on Heather's small waist, flares of her dress exposing her entire thigh, resting moments when she leaned on the table and drew her finger in sexy circles around the rim of her glass and laughed at other men's jokes while her foot crept up his own leg suggestively.

It seemed there was never a time to ask her what she was doing: Heather clearly had a plan, and he was relegated to observer of it as it unfolded. Did she know that she was giving him exactly what he wanted? He saw the way other men looked at her wedding finger and then furtively looked at him, but he returned their questioning glances with an even stare.

"What's the trick?" he asked her at one point, as she spun around him, her lips freshly anointed with red lipstick.

Heather knew what he was asking her about and responded by winking. “I’ll show it to you later,” she promised.

The DJ was wrapping up the music what seemed like an eternity later. The music had died, chairs were being stacked, bright, awful lights had been turned on. The bar had been packed up without his noticing, because his attention had been so focused on his wife.

“We better call an Uber,” he said to her, as she took a pause to drink a glass of water. She was flushed, her hair loose again, and very, very drunk. She fell toward him, her hand on his chest again. “I have a new plan,” she said throatily. “These guys are all going back to the Hilton, in a shuttle.”

The Hilton was next to their own hotel, and Toby knew, basically, what she was suggesting even before she said it. He looked around for Ron, but he was nowhere to be found. Heather was already walking away from him toward a group of guys who looked single and hungry, and their eyes were on her as she approached. Her words drifted from her mouth as she walked away, low and intended only for Toby’s ears, but they floated around him for a few moments before he was able to parse them:

“I’ll just go ingratiate myself with these guys and we’ll get a free ride.”

Ingratiate myself.

The phrase coiled around Toby’s cock, coalescing deep in his balls, deep inside of him, wrapping around his soul like a boa, squeezing until he was sure he would burst. An announcement was made about the shuttle, and Heather linked an arm in one of the guys’ arms, walking with the remaining party toward the exit. She turned only after a few paces, only to glance at him, only to smile that same terrifying smile.

Toby followed, sure that he was not in his own body. Heather was clinging to her choice of man – a tall, jock-ish man in his early thirties with lustful eyes that seemed to always land on her breasts.

The evening became a blur: he followed his wife to a shuttle full of people they had never met, from a wedding they didn’t belong at, with Heather looking back over her shoulder. The expression on her face was the thing he would remember best, as odd as it might seem after everything that was about to happen, happened.

A smile he could not recognize, and something he couldn't describe in her eyes. The sort of look it is impossible to categorize as complicit or competitive, friendly or dangerous.

In the end, the image burned into his cornea, where it still resides, as indecipherable to him as the thoughts of the woman he married, but maybe didn't know.

CHAPTER 4

The guys Heather had “ingratiated” herself with went to the back of the shuttle, a full-length bench that straddled both aisles. Toby followed, his abdomen cold, his chest pounding, unsure of what Heather was leading them towards. His hands were clammy when he rested them on the back of a seat and squeezed his way next to Heather. The driver, who appeared to be an old hand at shuttling hoards of drunken wedding parties to the Hilton, stared into his mirror and repeated that they couldn’t leave until everyone was seated in a monotonous and unfeeling voice until finally the rowdy crowd settled into their seats. The volume was high, the guests all quite drunk. Heather placed her hand on Toby’s thigh while she leaned over to talk to the man second to the left from her. To do that, she had to rest her other hand in the lap of the man to her immediate left.

Toby’s eyes darted from his wife’s hand on his thigh, her thumb absently stroking the top of his leg, but her body otherwise limp and disconnected from him, to her bare back, and a smattering of goosebumps that had streaked over her shoulders with the cool air of the air-conditioned shuttle. Her left hand was hidden beneath her body, but there was nowhere else for it to be except in the lap of the guy next to her.

Over her back, that same man looked at Toby, and grinned.

Was it a grin for the man whose wife was stroking his cock? Was it a grin of challenge? Pity? Shared enjoyment?

Toby just stared. Heather sat back up and turned excitedly to him, saying something about an amusement park. The words careened around in his head, but they held no meaning for him. All he could see was Heather's mouth, her lipstick slightly smeared (had she kissed somebody?) and her hand, between the legs of her next-seat neighbor, fingers down and wrapped around his upper thigh, her pinky resting against his erection.

She leaned back, not moving her hands, and closed her eyes.

The guy next to her edged closer to her, glancing at Toby as though to check for trouble that he had already written off as unimportant. He fingered a loose lock of hair and pulled it from her face to tuck it behind her ear. It slid, wet with sweat, and then cooperated. “Heather,” he purred. “Don’t fall asleep now.”

A smile fought against Heather's controlled expression, but her eyes remained closed. Toby wondered if the man noticed, if he cared, if he knew that Heather was playing a game.

If maybe she wasn't.

His hand dropped to the edge of her halter top, his fingers tracing the shape of the dress down, along the curve of her left breast to her sternum, then back up, stopping at her shoulder, playing with the material. Toby was frozen, mesmerized by the man's playing with the strap of the dress. Heather's mouth moved in a twitch, and her eyes opened lazily to look Toby directly in the eye.

The man leaned in and his lips came into contact with her neck. He nuzzled her, and Toby's cock pulsed with blood so violently he thought he might pop. Heather's mouth turned up, her eyes locked on Toby's, and her fingers brushed over his cock, as if asking *that* part of him permission rather than getting it from his frozen stare.

"Heather," the man purred. His hand moved down from her shoulder, following the edge of her dress until he reached her waist. He continued down from there, his palm on her thigh, then her knee. And then, making Heather's pinky jerk in Toby's lap and her thigh wobble against his, the hand went slowly up beneath her dress.

Time seemed to stop, or slow, so that the moment dragged on for what seemed like an eternity. Toby must have stopped breathing as he watched the bulge beneath Heather's skirt move slowly closer to her waist. Heather's head was leaning against the back of the bench, her neck on the headrest, her lips parted slightly. Her eyes were on Toby, but they told him nothing. Nothing about what she was feeling as a stranger's fingers stroked her thigh and moved closer and closer to her panties.

But however long this took in reality, it was eventually heading toward something, and things would have to change: the man's hand could not forever be close to touching her mound with nothing but her panties between his flesh and hers. He moved his hand and took hers in it, pushing her onto his throbbing cock, conveying to her – he hoped – that she should let the show continue.

The man's lips were back on her neck now, and then moved lower. They pursed to kiss her on the slope of her breast, next to the fabric of her dress. Beneath her skirt, the lump of his hand was between her legs. Her

eyes went glassy and her lips parted in response to whatever he was doing. Toby felt a small jerk in her body and his own body shuddered in response: he must have his finger on her hot spot, he was making her shudder and hum.

The man's right fingers crawled up from the right, which was now facing Heather more than the front of the van. They pulled at the cream and red fabric, tugging down as his lips traveled with the retreating dress, until her breast pulled free of the material and her nipple poked out, hard, pink, and beautiful. Within seconds, it was caught up in the man's lips.

Toby's eyes were frozen now on the sight of his wife's nipple between the teeth of a total stranger. Right next to him.

The whole shuttle had gone eerily quiet, but that was all that Toby could have been relied upon to say about what was happening. He saw only Heather's flesh, the pink crest of her creamy tit being swirled by another man's tongue. Squares of light ran over the ceiling and back into the dark night, but for Toby the world had stopped moving except for the man and Heather.

It took a moment for him to realize that Heather was squeezing his cock, and he looked up at her sharply when her fingers dove into his suit, wriggling to get under the belt and toward his shaft, her hand backward, back of her palm against his pelvis.

Staring at the rhythmically moving lump beneath her skirt, Toby fumbled with his belt and managed, somehow, to unloop it. Heather's fingers moved down, but her attention had been taken away from Toby, and her fingers moved with an absentmindedness that revealed she was not really thinking about him, or what she was doing to him, not nearly as much as she was thinking about the mouth on her nipples or the fingers moving beneath her skirt.

The shuttle rolled to a stop and the lights came on. As if they were children on a school field trip, the three of them jerked their hands from wherever they had been and began to put things away, straightening pants and skirts and whatever else had been jostled out of place by their adventure. Heather looked at Toby, no anxiousness in her expression, and wiped the corner of her mouth to clear the smeared lipstick, a smile behind her open mouth. She pressed her skirt daintily around her with her other hand, as though she were trying to be proper for church.

The man who had just sucked on his wife's tit and probably fingered her looked at Toby with a smug grin. "Party in my room?" he suggested.

It was only at that exact moment that Toby realized that the man hadn't pieced together that he and Heather were married. They were all very, very drunk.

Heather looked at Toby, who was unable to say at the moment what forces were overcoming him. Heather looked, suddenly, like someone else entirely. Was this his wife? Was this real life? Had this man just asked them if they wanted to come upstairs and fuck?

But he was standing up already, Heather's hand in his grip. Heather stood, and followed, and Toby followed closely behind her.

He found her bottom and cupped it, the skirt between his hand and her skin. She leaned back against him. Perhaps she was doing that for another reason, perhaps she wasn't even aware of what she was doing. But Toby's mind was only able to think of one thing, and so Toby breathed in her ear:

"It's your call."

Toby didn't even know if he was included in this offer himself, so he clung to Heather's hand and squeezed. For a terrifying moment, he could feel what it would be like if Heather left him standing in the lobby, waving goodbye with a corporate-style finger wave.

Toodles. Back in three hours.

She paused at the steps to the hotel. A breeze picked up a loose strand of her hair, and time warped again. The moment was eternal, nothing but the pulse of Toby's heart marked the passage of time. He would never be able to know what Heather thought about in those seconds that seemed to last forever: did she consider it, see the evening unfolding ahead of them, feel her pussy pulse like Toby felt his cock?

He waited, suspended in time, cold with fear, excited with passion.

She gave a quarter-turn toward Toby. "Give me ten minutes," she whispered.

*

Heather's pulse was so fast, and her blood pressure so high, she could see it pulsing in her wrist, beneath the surface of her skin. She was

buzzing all over, reeling inside.

Ten minutes... to what?

She didn't know.

She did know, beneath the ocean of alcohol and the strange, lustful pull inside of her, that she was *not* this kind of person. She wasn't a person who said things like, "Give me ten minutes," unless she knew what she was going to do, and that it would, in fact, take her ten minutes to do it.

She was drunk; her thoughts came to her lazily, only under duress, and they had to fight through her wild emotions, her physical feelings, her racing heart, to even get to the first layer of her conscious thoughts. She had just let this guy – she didn't even know his *name*, and wasn't even sure she could pick him out of a lineup – slide his finger up her leg.

He had sucked on her breast in the back of a hotel shuttle.

In front of her husband.

She was entering the lobby now, light cascading over her and everything she was doing. She thought of Toby's face, staring down at the stranger's mouth, latched to her breast, his tongue making circles around her hardened nipple.

She liked thinking of Toby watching her as much as she liked the feel of another man's mouth on her nipple. The way his tongue moved, the unfamiliarity of it. The feeling that she was putting on a show.

The realization that she liked these things came to her as an ache in her pussy.

At the check-in desk, there he was: the man who had sucked her tits in the back of a hotel van.

Shame crept over her skin, traveling along her spine, heating her neck, making her nipples harden beneath the fabric of her dress.

It's your call, Toby's voice echoed in her ears.

Her call.

He – shuttle guy - was coming toward her now. He had a smug look on his face, the idea in his head that he could have her again, any way he wanted to. If she was slutty enough to let him finger her and suck on her tit in public, what would she let him do in private?

What *would* she let him do in private?

He was younger than her; closer to the bartender Chris's age than to Toby's. Early thirties, possibly late twenties. Well-groomed. Fit. Pretty

good-looking. His fingers hadn't been expert, but they also hadn't been clumsy.

"Want a drink?" he was asking. He looked over at the bar, then back at her. "I have a full bar in my room."

Where was Toby? Heather thought suddenly. This was a real invite, a ticket to a hotel room with a man who had already felt her wet pussy. Saying yes would seal the deal: she would follow him, he would let her take a sip of her drink, and then he would be on her, trying to get her dress off, convince her to lie down...

She glanced behind her. Toby was standing in the lobby. He looked odd, if you considered him by himself, and if there hadn't been so many people filing in just then, he would have looked insane. His hands were balled up, his eyes wild, his mouth open slightly. His eyes were rigidly fixed on Heather, and the man she was talking to.

And what if she did say yes, but first she told him that her husband had to come and watch? What if she took control up there, instead of letting him take her drink from her hand minutes after he poured it? What if she finished her drink, and held them both in suspense, before getting down on her knees and giving this guy a blowjob, knowing that Toby was standing behind her like he was right then, watching?

She could actually feel the hot liquid in her pussy ooze from inside of her.

"I never got your name," she said, to buy herself time to make a decision.

A flash of confusion crossed his face, and he said, "I'm Jeff. The brother."

"Right," Heather said, putting a hand on his chest. She played with his tie with her fingers. Teal. Sure sign of being in a wedding. This wasn't even *their* wedding.

A flash of porn that had come to her unbidden raced through her mind: a woman, blindfolded, giving a man a blowjob with her hands tied – by a suit tie – behind her back. She didn't know why she had liked it, but the image stayed with her, and she breathed life into it sometimes when she masturbated.

Was there a way to get herself into that position? Sucking not one cock, but two? Would she know her husband's dick from this guy's?

This slew of thoughts paraded through her mind, and her vision swam. Jeff, The Brother, placed a hand on hers, and began to turn toward the elevator bank. He had her hand between his fingers, his thumb was stroking her palm. Her pussy was throbbing, her mind was spinning.

Toby.

It's your call.

She took a few steps toward the elevator with him. The truth was that she didn't know what she was going to do until she did it. Had ten minutes passed? Would she really have this guy's cock in her mouth in ten minutes? Would Toby wait down here, or would she ask if he could come up, too?

She slowed, enough that after a few steps she caused some drag on their walk. Jeff looked back at her. He was already preparing to be turned down, racking his brains for a convincing anecdote, frowning a little.

"I'm married," Heather said.

This amused him. He held up his left hand, saying nothing. There was a ring on his annular finger.

Never mind where his wife was. Why would his wife not be at this wedding?

She gave a glance back at Toby. Still frozen to the spot, still staring. Jeff looked behind her, but he didn't seem to spot the husband, or perhaps he didn't care.

"Come on," Jeff said. "Just a drink."

His eyes dropped to her breasts, and she could see that he was savoring the memory of her nipple in his mouth.

They were walking again, Heather feeling unsure, the elevator being called. She tipped her head to look at the floor numbers, saw them coming for the first floor.

She broke free of his hand as the door opened. "I can't," she said. She was shaking her head. "I'm sorry."

A look of confusion. Disappointment. And then, below the features he contrived to give her a smile, anger. "You sure?" he asked. "I make a mean vodka martini with mini bottles."

Heather had a lot of things to say. She was a gin girl, she was married, she kind of wanted to be a slut with him but she didn't know how

to make it work, Toby was freaking her out, she was too drunk to make a responsible decision...

She said nothing, just gave her head a quick shake and spun on her heel, walking quickly to toward the exit.

To her right side, Toby stared at her, his head turning with her as she passed by, her heels clacking on the floor.

She ran out to the parking lot, worked up into a frantic dash by the time she got there. It was dangerous, toying with men like this, but when she reached the parking lot there was another shuttle, a lot of people, and it occurred to her that Jeff “The Brother” wasn’t going to follow her out and try to drag her to a hotel room with all these people standing around.

She turned to face the entrance. A few of the wedding attendees passed her and waved with familiarity. She must have really been putting on a show. Jesus. She had just crashed a wedding. What if someone called them out about it?

But Toby was pushing against the crowd, coming out of the lobby, and the sight of him filled her with relief, and a renewed sense of humor about everything that had transpired. Toby gave her a strange smile, nodded in greeting to a gaggle of girls from the wedding who seemed to know his name, and then trotted down the steps to Heather.

She seized his hand. She could see the bulbous trees that lined the grounds of their own hotel, blasted by ugly lights from below, over the tops of the bushes at the end of the parking lot. She pulled him, laughing, toward the side of the lot. They ran, laughing, looking back behind them like two kids who had just blown up a mailbox in an eighties movie.

There was no talking as they scrambled over an unexpected wall and squeezed through the bushes to get to the grounds of their own hotel. This was not the kind of thing Heather had ever, ever done in her life, but she was drunk enough that the absurdity of it – the possible legal ramifications, the utter lack of decorum that she would die of mortification if any of her colleagues (or God forbid, her boss) knew about – did not strike her at all.

What did strike her was the fun of it, the excitement pulsing beneath everything they were doing. She felt alive, outside of a box she had been living in, where all things were planned and done with utmost care.

Toby exited the bushes and stood next to her, shaking cedar sprigs from himself, while Heather marveled drunkenly at the night sky, as if there

were anything to see up there but the sodium orange glow of the city reflected back to them by the eternal Jersey haze. The hotels were on an expansive strip of loud street that would qualify as a freeway almost anywhere in the world, and the din of the cars added to the feeling of movement. A breeze picked up a loose strand of Heather's hair, and Toby reached for it to pull some cedar loose.

She grabbed another and pulled it across her lip, looking at Toby. Their eyes met and they laughed.

The laughter died down, and there was a moment of awkward silence. Neither one of them, obviously, knew what to say. But there was a deliciousness in it, Heather thought. It was an ingredient that had been missing for a long time now. Once you had been married so many years, well... you already knew what the other person was going to say, didn't you? They never did anything unexpected. Even an angry silence was predictable: you'd had the fight a million times before and you already knew what they would say, how it would resolve, and when it would be over.

Not in this moment. This moment had the delicious feel of uncharted territory, the excitement of wondering what the other person would say next, or do.

"You mad?" she asked Toby finally, pulling at another loose strand of hair. It clung to her lip and Toby reached to help her, shaking his head. But then, unexpectedly, he seized her and gave her a possessive kiss, holding her head in his two hands and pushing down on her lips with his mouth until she had no choice but to melt into his embrace.

It seemed ludicrous, walking backward into the shadows and making out against the wall of a hotel they had a room at, but that's what they did. Toby guided her to a single dark patch tucked away in the drab landscaping, between two large and shapeless bushes that were clearly never meant to be examined up close.

"That was hot," Toby said at some point, but there was no real room for talking while doing what they were doing. She was against the wall, the industrial-grade stucco scraping at her back, the heat of the day radiating against her skin.

It was exhilarating, feeling Toby's fingers under her dress, touching her where a stranger had just placed his hands, knowing that *he knew*, and

was remembering right then, that someone else had felt her. She could feel his jealousy in his fingertips, in the insistent way he found her pussy with his hands, felt it as though examining it for something to have changed, felt the stiffening of his entire body when he encountered her as wet as she had ever been.

How long had it been since they had had sex and not cared where they were? Before Salty's, before this turn in their marriage, sex had slowly wound down to a thing that seemed scheduled, a chore, never exciting in the way it was now. Never a thing they felt they had to do so badly that they couldn't enter a building and go up two floors to a private room. No, they were here in the shadows because they couldn't wait that long.

Toby pushed his fingers inside of her and lifted her slightly with the force of his hand, pushing on her clit from the inside out. His eyes were like steel as he wrapped her leg around him and somehow shrugged his cock from inside his pants. She bit his lip when he entered her, not to tease or as part of any plan to create a "feeling" of passion as she often did – but because her breath was actually taken away by the feel of her husband thrusting inside of her. She could feel his need to fill her, to reclaim her as his own.

She barely noticed the scraping of her back against the rough stucco, her absorption in the feel of Toby inside of her was so complete. They stared at each other as he fucked her – and there was no other word for it – hard, his eyes on hers, the lust in them as all-consuming and arousing as the feel of his cock.

When she came, her orgasm seized her whole body, as if from behind, wrapping itself around her and making her stiff with its power. She could feel herself clamping down on Toby's dick, her heels digging into his back, her head tipping back and no sound escaping her open mouth as she screamed silently. And then his hot cum was inside of her, his mouth on her neck, and wave after wave of pleasure rolled through her for what seemed like minutes.

*

There is a special kind of awareness that settles in instantly after you have sex in a public place, or even a semi-private place, and Heather

couldn't remember the last time she had experienced it. They looked at each other, having the same realization at the same moment, and flushed as they became aware that, while what they were doing had been the only thing *they* could see or hear, it was probably also obvious to anyone within 200 feet.

"Oh my God," Heather said, straightening out her skirt. "Let's get inside."

Toby was right behind her, his hand making a delicious swirl over her back. "You scratched yourself," he said, but his fingers felt exquisite and not painful. They clomped out of the damp grass and onto a service road that led to whatever the hotel wanted to be shielded from the public eye by wooden gates. They were holding hands, something they hadn't done in forever, either.

"So..." Toby said.

It was only then, as the glow of sex was fading and the insanity of having it against the wall of a hotel outside was gripping Heather with its impropriety, that the other acts she'd committed that evening began to close in around her.

"So...?" she said. Her voice was carefree and lilted playfully, but inside she felt like a weight was dragging her down. What the hell had she done? What were they doing?

"What happened with you and that guy? Why'd you run?"

Heather stopped and faced Toby. She had no idea why, but she felt a little like crying for a second. She could feel the hot tears in her eyes threatening to spill over. "I don't know what happened," she said. "That was so, I don't know... out of control..."

"It was hot," Toby said, his voice steady and assuring. He pulled her closer to him. "I wanted you to do it. It turns me on."

Heather could feel the scrape of his stubble, smell his sweat, the muskiness of his body. Jeff had tasted different than Toby, smelled foreign. The thought blossomed in her mind and surged inside of her.

She wondered if she should tell Toby about those thoughts. Did he want to hear them? Would he want to know what she was thinking about, right at that moment, as she was inches from her husband's lips and feeling guilty that she had acted like a slut in a hotel van, as she was hoping for forgiveness and affirmation – would he want to know that she was thinking

of the way another man smelled, wondering, still, what it would be like to have someone else's cock inside of her, the heat of another man's body against her skin?

Or was this all some kind of set-up? Something destined to go wrong? Toby wasn't the kind of guy to lay traps for his wife, not the kind of guy who said things he didn't mean.

But... if anyone had asked Heather if Toby was the kind of guy who wanted his wife to sleep with another man, she would have laughed that idea away. And yet, here they were, and Toby seemed to be *exactly* that kind of guy.

"What are you thinking about?" Toby asked tenderly, brushing some hair from her face.

She wouldn't even know how to say it. She shook her head, gave him a smile. "I can't believe I did that," she said, and maybe that was really what she was thinking.

Toby turned with her hand in his and started leading them to the hotel entrance. "What did you say to that guy?" And, without waiting for an answer: "Why'd you leave?"

A shiver traveled down her spine. She'd have been hard-pressed to identify it as either excitement or remorse. "It just... he was *married*," she said.

She sounded exasperated, and they both laughed at how ridiculous the idea of the other man being married was, in light of themselves.

Heather's laugh faded before Toby's and she turned serious. She was certain she had something serious to say, if only her intoxication didn't keep pulling it away from her. "But no, you know? Where was his wife? And he was also the brother of the groom. So... I just got scared. I don't know. That we would get busted. Or something."

"Or something," she delivered with an ominous whisper. Was she afraid of getting busted for crashing a wedding? Sleeping with another woman's wife? Or was she scared of something else?

The thought was like a black eel in her mind, she couldn't hold onto it for long, nor did she really want to.

Toby was nodding, looking at his feet, smiling. Heather knew he probably heard this as a linear narrative: she got scared because he was

married and the brother of the groom. As in, afraid of getting caught at the wedding.

But she had actually meant it as three separate thoughts, each of them part of her feelings but not necessarily causing one or the other. She *had* gotten scared, but it wasn't because he was married or because he was Jeff, The Brother. Something else scared her.

"Heather," Toby said calmly. "I don't want you to ever do anything you don't want to do..."

There was a "but" at the end of this sentence, at least implied in Toby's tone. She looked at him.

"But I did think it was...hot. I don't want you to feel bad about anything that, you know, you do. When it's like that, I mean. I'm into it. Really."

Heather looked at him. It was hard to believe that, even if she really wanted to. Also, he was drunk. Would all of this seem different in the sober morning light? She looked up at the sky and made a sound like a sigh. Toby squeezed her hand.

"What?" he asked her.

What? What was troubling her?

"I just don't know," she said helplessly, as if Toby had asked her that very same question.

"*What* don't you know?" Toby said, pulling her toward him.

Heather shrugged into his embrace. She felt another wave of tears coming on, which made her frustrated at herself. "I just don't... know. I don't know about all this."

Toby had a finger on the hem of her halter, his flesh hot where it touched her, moving down the outside curve of her breast, over her wildly beating heart, to the bare skin just below her sternum. He slipped his thumb under the fabric and rubbed the nipple Jeff had played with. There was still a tenderness from Jeff's attentions, and when Toby moved her hardened nipple in a slow circle with the pad of his thumb, it ignited an erotic quiver through her whole body. This was so wrong, so bad, so... delicious.

"Hey! You made it!"

Toby's thumb slipped smoothly out of her dress and he moved away from her, smiling. Her nipple throbbed, connected through her body by what seemed like a coil carrying electricity, right to her pussy. He turned his

head slowly in the direction of the voice. A glittering laugh erupted in that direction: a female voice. Another low male baritone.

Heather turned, confused, to see Ron and the woman she just then recalled as being his date, and another couple who looked familiar from Liz and Dave's wedding, crossing the parking lot, headed toward Toby and Heather.

Toby and Heather separated a little from each other, one of those consensual partings from their adolescence, made to look like they hadn't been doing anything there in the shadows of the parking lot.

Ron was smiling, his girlfriend was so wasted she could barely stand. "How'd you guys get home?"

Heather was lifting a hand toward the other hotel, trying to find a way to explain that they'd hitched a ride with the wrong wedding and she'd let the brother of the groom (or maybe the bride, who knew?) feel her up and bite gently on her breast on the way home.

But because everyone was so very drunk, the conversation moved along quickly and disjointedly. Ron told the girl draped against him, happily, "This is my dance partner," and the other couple invited them to go to a place called "Annie's". One of the girls linked an arm with Heather's. Heather remembered exchanging a glance with Toby, and feeling like there might have been more to discuss or decide upon, but by the time she got around to thinking that thought with any seriousness, they were all on the sidewalk, traffic roaring next to them, hot summer breezes snaking around her skirt, cool where Toby's cum was still wet on her inner thigh. Headed... somewhere.

CHAPTER 5

Toby wasn't entirely clear on how they had ended up walking around in the hot Jersey summer with a group who must have been friends with Liz, because he didn't know any of them and neither did Heather. Images of the evening were popping up in his mind, flashing around out of order, and the only thing he could think about consistently for more than a second was Heather. Heather on the shuttle bus, Heather's skirt spinning high above her hips, Heather's skin being tasted by that guy in the back of the shuttle. Heather's vacant, savory, "I don't know," that left him wondering what, exactly, Heather didn't know about. The promise, in everything that she did, that Heather might just keep doing things she didn't know about.

Sure, he didn't like that she obviously felt conflicted and guilty, so he reached for her hand whenever he could to reassure her. *This is my fantasy*, he kept wanting to tell her.

Really.

Truly.

It was.

He wondered what had actually made her flee the other hotel. He was both grateful she had done so, and still reeling from the dizzying fall of his expectations. Standing there, watching her walk toward the elevator with that man, he had felt like he was getting squeezed in a vice. And yet he had wanted it, wanted so badly for her to disappear through elevator doors, meet his eyes one last time, and then disappear upstairs, that he was pretty sure he had felt his mouth watering.

Now, his mouth was dry, and they had been bounced at a bar named Annie's before they even got in, because Ron's date (or whatever she was) was too inebriated. They were walking back to the hotel now, righteously complaining about the bouncer, planning to take over the hotel bar.

Toby would have been all for taking his wife upstairs, sinking into her hot, wet, cunt again, and reliving the whole evening in his mind as he did so.

At the hotel bar they were told they were closing in fifteen minutes. How did it get so late? He bought Heather a drink, trying to resuscitate the

level of inebriation that had led her to letting go of her inhibitions. He sipped his drink, feeling devious and maybe even a little predatory for wanting to stay sober. The drunk girlfriend or date or whatever she was disappeared, and it took Toby almost ten minutes to notice she was gone. Ron told Heather she was the hottest woman at either wedding, and Heather rolled her eyes. The other couple – nameless, somewhat faceless in Toby's memory later, suggested that they continue the party upstairs. Someone had a cell phone out and was texting people who were evidently in room 1204.

These were all just slices of his memory. Walking down the hall behind everyone else, stark hotel lighting making sharp angles of their skin and their bodies. No one able to walk in much of a straight line. An aggrieved woman with a look of studied and religious anger opening the door and glaring at them as they passed noisily by her room. A promise to call the manager. Everyone laughing loudly and reducing their voices to the loudest whisper imaginable. Heather losing her balance and colliding with a wall, laughing. Ron's hand on her hip, maybe her ass, as he helped her steady herself. A pause, as their faces came close to each other. Toby's cock, improbably hard again.

He made a note of the room as they passed through the door. 1204. The occupants were already there, someone had turned on some music. It was a very typical wedding after-party, one like any of the others Toby had been to: everyone was drunk, nobody knew each other all that well, they were being too loud for the hotel and drinking the fridge stock like it was free. Everyone was way too old to be acting like this, but nobody cared.

He was pleased when Heather chose an armrest next to Ron to sit down on. She had obtained a plastic cup of clear liquid, and he found himself perversely pleased by that as well. Ron's face was right next to her well-rounded bottom, the shape of which was hinted at but slightly disguised by the red and cream dress. Ron's eyes were pulled to it occasionally as though it were planetary gravity. Toby was leaning on a bar, fetching drinks for anyone who asked from the rapidly depleting fridge.

Three people – the couple with Ron and one of what Toby guessed was an occupant of the room, a woman he recognized but did not remember – started having an intense political discussion, two of them sitting on one of the beds, the man standing. Toby sipped a bottle of Jack Daniels.

He heard Heather as she untwisted her hair from its decaying hairdo, shook it, and pulled it back into a ponytail. "I need to get out of this dress," she complained. Ron was sitting next to another guy. "Noooo," they complained in unison.

"No, keep the dress," Ron said, smiling.

Toby moved his eyes to the political debate, sensing what would happen next: Ron shot a look in his direction, determined the coast was clear, and then ran a hand along Heather's calf to her shoes. Toby thought he heard him make a comment about the shoes. He liked them. They were sexy.

In the next frame of his memory, Toby was standing next to Ron, facing the bar. There were no drinks left. "Shit," Ron was saying.

And then Toby was talking. The voice was his and he could feel his mouth moving, but it was, for not the first time, a lot like watching a movie.

"You know," he heard himself saying. His voice was low, made gravelly. "You don't have to worry about me, you know, and you putting the moves on Heather."

Ron froze, and his eyes went to the mirror above the bar to look at Toby, then quickly away from his gaze.

"We have an arrangement," Toby said.

He sounded smooth now. It was almost repulsive how smooth he sounded. Ron was still frozen, lifting his hands with the palms forward, shaking his head, about to make the universal gesture of not having anything to do with something, or knowing about it, or having any fault for it. "Hey man," Ron started to say.

Toby, not himself, made a half turn and leaned on the bar so he was facing the room, and gave a quick glance at Heather, who was watching him, perhaps because she knew what he was saying. "I'm serious," Toby said, so only Ron could hear. "We have a deal. So no worries on your end. Just... well, it's Heather's choice in the end. I'm gonna run to our room and get some more booze."

Toby punched Ron lightly on the arm and gave Heather a meaningful glance. "I'm going for more drinks," he mouthed to her, and pointed down, in the direction of their room.

He turned away from her as she looked alarmed, and strolled out of the room.

It was madness. Careless, unthinking, drunken madness. The hallway swam around him as he made his way back to their room. Down the hall, wait for the elevator, turn, turn, keycard in, door opened too harshly, bang against the doorstep. A loud click as it closed behind him.

Their room was silent. Heather had gotten dressed and put everything away in her suitcase as neatly and tidily as possible. His own preparation was sloppy: ties here and there, a shoebox discarded on the floor with the tissue paper tossed out of it at the last minute. In the silence of the room, the single light coming from the bathroom, the full weight of what he had just done washed over him.

He remembered his excuse for being there: the booze.

He emptied the fridge into a handbag of Heather's and stood up, feeling dizzy. What was Heather doing, right now, at this moment? He sat on the bed and fished around in his suit for his phone. Did he even want to call her, to interrupt what she was doing? Or was he just concerned about his phone as an object, a lifeline he had no intention of using?

He had no arrangement with Heather. No "deal," as he had apparently told Ron. He had just left his wife with a man who was obviously into fucking her, and he hadn't said anything to her about it.

His phone was missing. Sitting, the full picture of his drunkenness coming into focus, he patted his suit repeatedly wherever there was a chance of a pocket existing. Nothing.

He stood up, clumsily, and retraced his steps with the handbag clutched unceremoniously in his hand. Mouth dry, heart pounding. How long had he been gone? Where was his phone? Where was his wife, right now, and what was she doing?

He stood outside of room 1204 for a few moments. The political debate was still raging. Someone was laughing. He rapped on the door and the voices went quiet. Toby swayed in front of it, holding the bag of drinks in two hands like an imbecile.

He *was* an imbecile. An imbecile who had just told another man to fuck his wife, without ever really finishing the conversation about that with said wife. A man who was paying far too much attention to how hard his dick was and how much his balls ached, and not the very real consequences of his actions.

No one answered the door.

He knocked again. "It's Toby," he added after a moment. "I have the drinks."

His voice was loud in the hallway and he half-expected someone to come out and shush him. Footsteps approached the door, and it clicked open.

There was a different vibe in the room now, and it took Toby a second to scan it and figure out what it was. Fewer people? New people?

No Heather.

No Ron.

The loveseat they had been sitting on was empty.

Someone took the bag from his hand as the realization that his wife was missing hit him like a series of concrete waves. Gone. Gone. Gone. And he didn't know where to.

He patted himself again for his phone. His mouth was dry, he reached for a bottle of water, which they had in abundance on the littered bartop. No one paid him any attention, except for one guy, who lifted a small bottle of vodka and grinned at him. "Cheers, man," he said.

Toby, stunned, looked around for help. A clue. For a moment he soared on the hope that Ron was a smoker, and maybe Heather had gone out with him to have a drag. She did that sometimes. Always a drag, never a cigarette. She had never smoked a whole cigarette in her life.

But he knew, as he crossed the room, his stomach coiling into cold, slithery knots, that Heather and Ron were not outside smoking.

How long had he been gone? Not that long. Not long enough for his wife to have disappeared on him like this.

"Hey," he said, leaning toward the bar to get the attention of one of the political debaters, a guy who had gotten tired of the conversation and was staring at the wall. "You seen my wife?"

The guy looked at him, confused.

"The blond. Red dress?"

The guy pointed at Toby suddenly, recognition on his face. "The calendar girl?" He made a motion on his chest indicating the cut of Heather's dress. "Dude, that's your *wife*?"

He looked as if he were really expecting an answer, so Toby nodded.

"She was here," Toby said impatiently, waving at the bar. "With Ron. Any idea where they went?"

The guy was shaking his head and lifting a drink to his mouth. “No, bud, sorry,” he said. His eyes traveled up and down, sizing Toby up, wondering almost loudly enough to hear how Toby snagged a wife like that. Wondering how a guy could be such an idiot to let a wife like that stay in a room with a guy like Ron, by herself, unsupervised.

He waited, simmering, apart from the party in every possible way. Glaring at the door, his heart wild, his mind full of dirt and angst. He felt for his phone repeatedly, rose to get a drink and then, halfway to standing, decided better of it and sat back down to collect his thoughts.

What had he done? What had he said to Ron, what had he said to Heather?

Heather. For all her pretending to be scandalized by his fantasies, she certainly got up and went off with a guy the first chance she got.

The feel of his wife’s pussy clenching around his cock, the rough stucco of the hotel beneath his hands, her legs bouncing in their heels next to his thighs, rose up in his mind almost as though he were actually doing it. Superimposed over it, the image of her swanlike neck stretched back against the shuttle bench, her lips parted, her eyes consumed by their pupils and pleasure.

Inside of Heather, it all said, in pictures smeared by his drunkenness, *there lived a wild slut.*

His cock throbbed, and he wriggled to make his erection less obvious. He leaned forward, elbows on knees, and one of the women arguing her political point, which had somehow turned into a vicious debate about going to the moon, gave him a strange look before turning her attention back to the conversation.

Toby looked around. He knew none of these people. Heather’s handbag, which he suspected was extremely expensive, was still sitting on the bar.

And Heather, it was plain to see, was not coming back.

He felt for his phone again, but gave up without much of a fight, because he knew it was missing. If he’d had it, he could call her, tell her to come back to their room, put an end to this.

Or just find out what “this” was.

An image of Heather, propped up against a hotel wall, her legs spread open for Ron’s dark Latino cock, bubbled to the surface of his mind

and clouded his judgment. His cock throbbed again. He gritted his teeth, stood up, snatched the purse, dumped the bottles he'd stuffed inside, and pushed his way to the door.

No one said goodbye.

*

Their room was empty. Toby spun around in it, turning things over, looking for his phone. Wandered in and out of the bathroom, cursing, giving things a toss here and there as if he were looking for something, but he wasn't anymore.

He sat on the bed. Discontented and restless, he went to the bathroom. He could feel himself taking his cock out, holding it in his hand. His left hand was against the wall, the toilet below him, his balls aching. But he couldn't see anything except Heather, sexy red shoes dangling in the air, cream and red dress bunched up around her waist, head against the stucco wall, rolling in his direction. Her voice a porn star's moan as her lips opened and she told Ron to fuck her harder.

Heather, on all fours, ass being slapped hard by Ron's thighs, pussy squelching with every thrust, pussy getting filled with another man's cum.

Toby didn't have to work hard to make himself come, only to hold himself against the wall and get what he could in the toilet as his orgasm squeezed his abdomen so tightly he thought he might fall over. As his ropes of cum splattered against the white tile and the toilet lid, floating uselessly in the water, he saw nothing but Heather: Heather with her mouth open and her limbs rag doll-like, surprised that Ron's cock was so big.

Some of his need having exited his body, Toby looked at himself in the mirror, panting. The shame that usually came after watching porn tried to wrap itself around him, and almost succeeded, but the knowledge that his wife was on the loose somewhere with Ron pushed it out of the way fairly quickly.

From there: a missing piece of time.

Then he was standing in the hotel lobby, a full-on erection developing again already. "I need to know where Ron... Ron, with the wedding party for Liz and Dave Gleason, is staying. I don't... I don't have his last name, but he's in the block with the rest of the...party."

The night manager was shaking her head, her lips pursed together in the expression of polite negation, the kind of smile people gave you right before they had you removed by security. She couldn't give that information out, sir, and if he didn't know Ron's last name, she was very sorry, but she couldn't even -

"Did you see a woman with a cream and red dress walk past here?" Toby interrupted her, causing a flicker of annoyance to erupt on her face. She shook her head. Toby could hear the slur in his words, feel how close to a police escort he was probably getting, but he kept going. "It's just... that's my wife. She has my key. Has anyone turned in a cell phone?"

The night manager shook her head, politely and without judgment, at all of this. If he was locked out, she could get *his* key, just provided he had his name and room number available.

But Toby, annoyed at this woman who did not understand the depths of his problem, was already backing away, shaking his head, sounding like a stoned adolescent saying: "Nah, man, that's okay, I think they might be outside..."

Which he didn't, but he was suddenly captivated by the idea that his phone might be by the wall where he had fucked his wife, and by the outrageous idea that she might be right where he had fucked her, just with a different man in her pussy. These ideas, and the slowly dawning realization that he was making a total ass of himself, propelled him out the door.

The traffic had died down, but not that much. It was anyone's guess what time it was. Toby turned the corner and was met by the loud hum of the air conditioning unit, and empty shadows and pools of orange light. No Heather.

Then he was looking disbelievingly at the ground. His phone. Resting on a tacky red mulch bed. He stared at it, disbelieving his good luck, as he often did when he was drunk and actually managed to find something.

It was face up, a blue light pulsing in the corner. Messages. Notifications. Could be anything.

He leaned against the wall as he swung at the ground with his arm and scooped up the phone.

It took a few swipes to unlock, but there it was; six messages from Heather, the last one partially displayed.

His insides burned as he stood up. Heat crept up from some unknown source, setting his neck on fire and wrapping around his face. He was suddenly, inexplicably, absolutely sober. His thumb moved easily to bring up the previous messages.

*Ditto actual yell this guy we hab nt
arrangement*

Okay.

Toby

Okay. So I'm going

Room 42251

421

The messages, all but the last, were spread out, five to seven minutes apart from each other. Toby's pulse raced: how much time had passed since he had left the room, returned to the twelfth floor, gone back, jerked off, talked to the manager, retrieved his phone?

Long enough.

*

Time flowed like lightning and mud at the same time. Toby, walking back into the hotel, the night manager looking at him suspiciously. He held up his phone. "Found it," he told her, and passed her before she could reply. Hands in pockets, waiting for the elevator. Impatience grinding against his spine, looking for the stairwell.

The ding of the elevator as soon as he opened the stairwell door. A fire hose, terribly bright lighting. He was out of breath when he reached the fourth floor, and his abdomen felt like ice. A hum in his ears matched the pitch of the lights, tuned to a dark and steady hum with the drumbeat of his pulse beneath it as he turned the corner, stared at the signs, took a moment to blink and calculate: Rooms 401-415 this way, 415-445 to the right. He

turned left, but pulled out his phone to double-check his destination. His hunch was correct, it was not 412 but 421.

That could have been embarrassing.

When he turned around, the hallway loomed before him: the room would be in the middle of it, and he could not get there any slower or faster. It seemed to come at him, rather than the other way around, a tunnel that moved around him and brought him closer to the door behind which, apparently, his wife was ensconced with Ron.

Eternities and not even a second passed as he walked to stand in front of room 421. Heather, laughing, his wife, taking care of his children and baking cookies. Heather, pressed against walls with the fingers of strange men in her cunt. What on earth would have made him say that he had an arrangement with her? What arrangement?

His chest was sore from the incessant pounding of his heart against his ribcage as he swayed, suddenly drunk again, hand raised to knock on the door. He leaned close to it, hoping to hear something before knocking. Part of him wanted to walk away, pretend to have passed out in their room, pretend that none of this had ever happened. He checked his phone again.

Heather's voice came through the door. Speaking, a low drawl, a sexual sound.

Toby knocked.

CHAPTER 6

She had seen Toby talking to Ron. Sure, he was facing away from him, looking at her, but he had his head turned slightly and was speaking low, so his voice would reach Ron. And whatever he said, it made Ron's head snap up, his eyes look for her reflection on the sofa, and a strange expression take hold of his face.

Heather looked at her fingers. She had been almost sober at one point, and now she was drunk again. When she was less so, the whole evening had seemed like the actions of another woman. Almost hard to believe they had happened to her.

By her. She had done them.

But now she was here, and she had slipped onto the couch seat so that Ron would sit next to her. She could picture the rest of the evening playing out, Toby watching with his jealous, mad eyes, while she flirted with Ron. What would she let him do? It wasn't even so much that Ron was all that attractive to her: sure, he was young, good-looking, a good dancer. He was dumb as rocks, but what did that matter? She was only doing what she was doing because the idea of Toby watching her, burning up with desire, was appealing to her.

It came to her like an epiphany, as she watched Ron approaching: she liked driving Toby wild. It was fun, in a deeply troubling way, to feel another guy's hands on her body, and there was the thrill of the illicit, the un-composed, the totally inappropriate behavior that was so far outside of what she

normally did, how she normally behaved. But the real thrill came from thinking about herself as Toby would see her: being touched by another man, letting someone else touch her body while he watched and waited to see if she would come back to him.

It was a wildly drunk thought, and she knew it, but sometimes those thoughts were the clearest.

Ron had a smirk on his face as he approached. Heather gave Toby another glance, but he was studiously watching the political debaters in the middle of the room.

“So,” Ron said, sitting next to her. He handed her a bottle. “These were the last ones I could get. Your husband there is going for some more.”

She looked up to see Toby leaving while Ron emptied the contents into her plastic cup. “You want a mixer? I think I saw -”

Heather shook her head. Ron had turned to face her, his hand on her knee. He was stroking her from the sides of her thigh inward, fingers light on her skin, tickling a little until they met at her kneecap and then moved downward again. And up. He edged a little further up with each stroke, and each descent and ascent of his fingertips sent refreshed, concentrated arousal through her body.

Ron’s voice was just above a whisper. “So are you, like, swingers or something? You and...?”

“Toby?” Heather asked, taking a sip of the burning, straight vodka in her cup. She didn’t need it, so she let some of it leak from her lips back into the cup. Her voice was steady but she felt like she was on a boat in a storm, flailing for the railing. Ron’s hand was halfway up her thigh now, burning, the heat traveling along her leg and licking at her cunt like a flame. “Not exactly,” she managed to say.

She wasn’t a swinger. That was ridiculous. She didn’t know what she was, but that wasn’t it.

She was impressed with this line, because it was true and sounded good. Confident. Mysterious. Toby would be back soon, maybe see this guy feeling her up, and then they would decide what to do... surely she would just go back to her room with him, laugh about this, and have hot sex.

“So what’s the arrangement?” Ron purred. He leaned on his arm next to her head and moved in closer. The fingers of his left hand were in her hair, his attention on her lips and her breasts. Her nipple panged, the ghostly feel of *yet another* man’s lips on her breast becoming visceral. Her nipples hardened, and she felt like her body was taking her mind hostage.

What’s the arrangement?

“Arrangement?” Heather said, not really thinking about the words she was saying. “Arrangement” was making its way through her mind to her conscious thoughts, but it had an uphill battle through the flesh-bound cravings that were eating her alive.

“He said you had an arrangement,” Ron purred, and he dropped his lips to her neck to nuzzle her. His lips were warm, and the muscle beneath

her skin was massaged to fiery life. She was being attacked from both directions: her neck, her leg, even the follicles of her hair.

Arrangement.

As Ron's hand traveled further up her leg, precariously close to finding her wet panties, probably already encountering the sticky cum mingled with her own juices in rough patches dried to her thighs, probably already feeling for himself that she was some kind of slut, Heather fought to think.

Did they have an arrangement? And if they did, what was it?

She looked back at the bar, and Toby was gone. Surely he had seen Ron next to her, surely he knew that if he left her there she was bound to do something over the line with him.

Arrangement.

A flare of anger erupted in her chest. They had no *arrangement*. They weren't swingers, they had no rules or assurances, no guarantee of what would happen. And what the hell was Toby doing, leaving her here?

Ron's lips were nearing her mouth, and she let him kiss her, her eyes open. Ron's were closed, his kiss insistent, assured. He was kissing her the way men kiss women they know will respond to them. The kiss was entitled, a prelude to something else that Ron apparently believed he could get.

"What did he say this arrangement was?" Heather asked, when Ron let her mouth go for a breath.

Ron smiled. His confidence faltered. "He didn't," he told her, brushing his lips over hers. Teasing, igniting something in the lowest parts of her abdomen. She could actually feel her clit pulse in the wet liquid around it. Ron's fingers moved up her leg, found her panties. He sucked in his breath.

A flurry of thinking happened inside Heather's mind, and she put a hand out to Ron's chest. Her thoughts were totally unclear, she had never concluded anything, but this felt like the right direction. Ron's heart thumped against his sculpted chest, a hot and beating need beneath his skin.

"Not here," she told him. He went in for another kiss, and she put her finger to his lips, stroking them to keep him heated, a gesture of incubation, meant to put him on hold while she straightened out her plan. His fingers beneath her skirt played with the sticky wet fabric of her panties

and she let him for a moment, enjoying the feel of it, the uniqueness of each man's exploring fingers. Then she stood up, pushing his hand away, bringing her drink with her.

She downed it, thinking she would need more liquid courage, or less inhibition, for whatever it was she was about to do. She turned and bent to scoop up the tiny handbag she had with her – in it she had red lipstick, her phone, fifty dollars, and their room key. She slipped the phone out as Ron took advantage of how she was standing to slip his hand up her leg.

As she moved her finger over the screen and rose back up to standing, Ron got his head beneath her dress and brushed his lips over her thigh just below the line of her right buttock.

Heather looked up. The political debate had paused, while they watched her, and looks of vague confusion, judgment, and surprise began to creep drunkenly over their faces.

This annoyed her, so she put a hand on her hip and contorted her face into an expression of careless contempt. *Yeah, and?*

She pushed against Ron's head, laughing, as she typed a message for Toby. It was garbled by the movement of her body, and Ron began to stand up so she hurried to send it before he could see it.

Did you tell this guy we have an arrangement?

That wasn't, ultimately, what was sent from her phone, and she knew it, but Toby was a smart guy, had enough context to figure it out. She dropped the phone into her bag and turned to Ron. "You have a cigarette?" she purred.

She was buying time, waiting for Toby to respond. The easiest thing for her to do, she realized she had decided, was to punt this back at Toby. He could make the decision. He said he wanted her to do this but she couldn't quite bring herself to believe him.

Ron's lips were on her shoulder now. "No cigarette," he breathed.

"Hey," she said, approaching the group on the bed. "Any of you guys smoke?"

Someone produced a cigarette, and they left as a group of three, Heather leading the way to the elevator. She pressed the button, stood back,

feeling her loose, flirtatious movements, disbelieving the way she was acting as she smiled at Ron. All the time waiting for the quick buzz of her phone. Nothing came.

In the elevator she checked again. Then again, as they walked through a ground-floor door outside. The evening was still hot. Ron decided he wanted a cigarette, his hands were on her lower back as they smoked.

She stole away by turning her body from the two of them, to type. Still nothing from Toby. She started and deleted a few sentences, then wrote:

Okay

What did that mean?

Toby

Nothing. The third person left. She was standing with Ron, half a cigarette still in her hand. She'd only had a drag. She brought it to her mouth and inhaled it, noticing that she did it with a deliberate thrust at sexiness.

"So what's the deal?" Ron said, pushing her back into the wall, his hands on her hips. Heather smiled to demur, dropped the cigarette, gave Ron her full attention. The seconds ticked by and Toby did not reply.

The deal, it would appear, was that Toby was not going to make the decision for her. Ron looked from side to side and pressed against her, a hand wandering under her halter. "Are you one of those, what-happens-in-Vegas-stays-in-Vegas couples?"

She didn't know. But she didn't like the idea of Ron thinking she didn't know. She smiled mysteriously and Ron put his mouth against hers. Adobe finish behind her crumbled and trickled down her back.

Ron's mouth moved along her jawline and then up to her ear. His hands were everywhere now, too many points of attack for her to monitor and defend, and she felt her body giving in to him, her grip on her thoughts losing the battle.

"Or does he like to watch?" Ron whispered. "I'm cool with that."

His breath felt deliciously foreign on her ear. He was doing something with her nipple that no man had ever done before. Against her

hips, she could feel the hard outline of his cock, and it seemed larger than Toby's.

Her recurring masturbation fantasy bubbled up again in her mind: the blindfold, the tied hands. The curiously arousing idea that she might not be able to identify her husband's cock from another man's.

And then there was this guy. She would never see him again, never have to answer for her sins, never face him sober. She could ask him to do things like that to her, whether Toby was there or not, and never have to deal with any of it again.

"Sometimes he likes to watch," she said quietly into Ron's ear. "And sometimes he doesn't. But I can tell you what *I* want."

Ron pulled away from her, and she felt a corkscrew of power twisting through the center of her body. She had Ron's attention as fully and completely as she had ever had anyone's, and the thrill of it was delicious.

"I want you," she said, gaining a bizarre kind of confidence with each word, "to take that tie off and blindfold me with it. And then, you're going to take off my dress, and tie my hands up, and do whatever you want with me." Her pussy throbbed. She leaned forward, a boldness she had never possessed in this particular arena of her life gripping her. "But I hope," she added in a whisper that was throaty and low, gravelly because of the puff of cigarette, "that you'll make me suck your cock."

She turned, feeling taller than she was, electricity traveling up and down her spine, and neatly removed her key card to open the door.

By the elevator, Ron's erection harder than ever against the small of her back, his hands moving all over her body, he breathed against the back of her neck. "And hubby?"

It sounded like "Toby." She flicked her phone out, her lips a sudden straight line, and, finding no messages from Toby, something inside of her clicked. Well, fine, she thought.

"We'll see."

They were in the elevator making out so long that the doors reopened. Heather laughed, and Ron broke away from her to punch them closed. "What floor?" he asked.

A chain of events flashed through Heather's mind: waking up with Ron in her room in the light of morning, having to face him. Forget it.

"Your floor," she said.

Ron looked crestfallen, and he started to explain what Heather suddenly remembered for herself: his date was passed out in there. Words began to come out of his mouth, but Heather leveled him with a look and shook her head slowly.

He took his phone out. The elevator doors opened again and he held it out of the shaft to get better reception. “Those guys aren’t using their room right now. Hang on.”

They stepped out of the elevator and Heather took her phone out again, disbelief trying to seep into her raging body when she saw that Toby hadn’t written back. Ron was talking on his phone, a short conversation, a glance in her direction to see if she was listening. She was leaning against the wall, a foot crossed over the other, and she leveled him with another glance. *You solve it*, her expression said.

She liked how that felt. She had all the power, and she could make everyone do whatever she wanted.

Except Toby.

Okay so I’m going

She typed. Then she dropped her phone into her purse.

Ron was putting his away as well. “Sorted out,” he told her.

They went into the elevator, and he pressed level two. They stepped out and Ron pressed her against the wall next to the elevator. “Stay right here, I’m getting the key.”

Heather leaned against the wall. She looked at her phone again, still nothing.

She brought up Toby’s number to the phone. Her fingers hovered over the call icon, while she weighed everything that she could.

But if Toby was going to answer the phone, she thought, he could just as well answer a text.

So there wasn’t any need to call him.

Ron appeared, loping like a wolf. “Got it,” he growled, and slid his hand around the back of her neck, his fingers tugging slightly at her hair. His other hand was loosening his tie, his fingers working the knot, the implication of what he was preparing for making Heather’s pussy throb.

Guilt stabbed her stomach with the rise of the elevator, but it was brief. Maybe it was just the elevator.

Fourth floor. Ron had his tie undone, he whipped it off his neck. Heather smiled at him.

So Toby had lost his chance. That was his problem.

“What room is this?” she said, taking the card from Ron’s hands as they stumbled down the hall to a t-intersection.

“Four-twenty-one,” Ron said, looking at the card, pulling one arm behind her, ready to tie her up.

She slipped away from him, pulling the card from his hand. As she walked she tried to key the message into her phone by typing surreptitiously, one hand stuffed in her bag and propping it open with her wrist. It didn’t work, it was garble.

She turned on Ron, remembering her power over him. He had her wrist in his grip, she held her other hand up with one finger sharply pointed at the ceiling. He grinned as she took out her phone, typing carefully.

421

“Just in case,” she murmured. “He wants to join.” She lifted her eyes to gauge Ron’s reaction.

He looked as if he could go either way about it, but Heather sensed this was probably just her female interpretation of a man’s reaction. It was a commonly traded fact among all the women *and* men that she knew that guys with a hard dick “this” close to having sex wouldn’t say no to anything you proposed. Men agreed this was true, to a man.

Women tended not to believe it, but here they were.

She leaned against the door and dropped her phone into her purse. The ease with which the lie left her lips surprised her, and made her swell with the same confidence and power she had felt downstairs.

“We like to play a game sometimes,” she purred, the deception effortless on her lips. She waited for Ron’s body to perk up and electrify, for his interest to narrow to what she would say next, before she leaned even closer. “We like to see if I can tell which cock is his, if I’m blindfolded.”

She put her finger in her mouth to emphasize her point, felt a rush as Ron’s cock spasmed in his pants and kicked against her leg. Then she

dropped it, smiling, and felt the outline of his dick with her hand. “It should be easy,” she told him – and it would; he was thicker and longer than Toby, and she could feel that through the fabric - “But it’s a fun game anyway.”

A pulse of his cock, the key card dropping into the slot.

“You okay with that?” she asked him.

And then, proving every conversation she had ever had about this topic, of men being okay with anything, Ron pushed the door open, spinning her around to tie up her hands with his tie.

He was okay with it.

CHAPTER 7

The Ron who answered the door was not the Ron from the wedding.

His shirt was off, his face was flushed, his eyes were consumed by lust. Toby recognized it even if he had never seen it face-to-face: the wild eyes of a man interrupted just before meeting his goal of getting his cock wet. Impatience, dominance, lust, and not a trace of anything rational floated in the miasma behind Ron's eyes.

For moment Toby was scared, but Ron seemed to be just as frightened by whatever Toby looked like. He was, after all, face-to-face with the husband of the woman he was trying to fuck.

"We're just getting started," Ron told Toby. There was a shimmer of hesitation in his voice, almost like he wasn't sure if he should continue, or open the door for Toby, or perhaps thinking he should run away.

But he didn't; he turned toward the interior, and Toby floated behind him into the room, the image coming into focus slowly, his mind rejecting it frame by frame, until he couldn't any longer.

This was real. This was happening.

Heather was on the bed on her knees. The dress had been stripped from her shoulders and loosely piled around her hips. Her small breasts were heaving slightly with her ragged breath, both nipples puffy and red, the marks of another man's attention on them in whoreishly pink hues. Her hands were behind her back, and she left them there, almost as though she were thrusting her tits forward so that Toby could appraise her offering of herself more fully.

Her lips were stripped of their red gloss, a tiny streak of it beneath her lower lip and smeared whoreishly to mid-chin. Toby's cock throbbed and his gut was kicked in by all the possible scenarios that might have made her lipstick streak like that, all of them flashing through his mind as detailed images.

Above her open, well-used mouth, a blue scarf was pressed against her eye sockets, tied at the back of her head. It was only on further contemplation, as he walked unsteadily into the room and the door clicked closed behind him, that Toby realized her hands were tied behind her back.

Behind him, he heard Ron unzipping his pants, the plop of them as they dropped to the floor. Heather's lips were unreadable. They were not smiling or frowning, not frightened and not at ease. They were parted in an expression he had never seen before, or even imagined on her face.

He was frozen in place, absolutely unsure what to do.

And then Heather spoke, and her voice sounded like it was a million miles away.

"You decided to come after all," she said, and a smile turned up the corners of her mouth briefly.

Ron brushed past him, and Toby barely noticed his naked form as he stood behind Heather and pushed her hair to one side to kiss her neck. His hands moved from her shoulders to her breasts, fondling them with long, wiry fingers. Heather's mouth fell open again, she sucked her breath in audibly. Toby stared at her nipples as Ron rolled them in his fingertips and they hardened into long buttons of tender flesh.

The scent of sex was in the air. Had they already fucked?

But no, Heather's pussy was the predominant scent, and she had her legs apart beneath her crumpled dress, where the scent of Toby fucking her would be drifting from between her legs.

"We're going to play your game," Ron said, his hands moving down to Heather's hips, his eyes lifting to meet Toby's as he pushed Heather gently forward.

What game? Toby's mind raced, searching through the shambles of his mind for a game, any game, that they had ever played that would make sense in this context.

Ron suspended Heather by her arms, holding the shirt tie that bound her wrists aloft, above her hips, as he pushed the dress down and over her ass, until it was bunched on her calves. Her round bottom was tilted up, a white lacy thong cutting through the center, and Ron ran his hand over her skin, his eyes watching his own caress.

Toby, not knowing what else to do, left his eyes on his wife, fought against the vague nausea in his throat, and felt his fingers undressing himself. Unbuttoning, Unzipping. All the while, Ron made lazy circles over Heather's skin, and then hooked a thumb beneath the thong and slipped his finger artfully into the valley between her butt cheeks, eliciting a gasp from Heather when his hand moved lower. Toby could only imagine the journey

Ron's fingers were taking, into the fine, trimmed hairs on her mound, over the bunched pink velvet of her asshole, into the engorged red lips of her pussy.

Toby stepped out of his pants, shaking slightly. He was glad that Ron didn't see him.

Ron seemed to have lost the thread somewhere, perhaps even forgetting "the game," or perhaps this was part of it. He slipped Heather's panties down with a jerk, and then slipped his fingers into her pussy. Toby couldn't see it, but he heard the squish as Ron cut through the swollen flesh and oozing juices to worm his way inside of her.

Toby was still paralyzed by both his confusion and disbelief, so he stared and did nothing. His cock bounced enthusiastically between his legs as Ron withdrew his hand and leaned forward to place his fingers in Heather's mouth. She closed her lips around Ron's pussy-drenched fingers and sucked them clean.

"Which game is that?" Toby managed to choke.

As if they had so many.

Ron pulled Heather back to her knees and placed her back in the position she had been in when Toby entered. Heather squirmed, making her breasts bounce lightly. The sheen of her juices and saliva gave her lips a glossy, sloppy appearance.

"The game where I have to guess whose cock is whose," she said.

A smile. As if that game existed between them, as if this was something they did all the time. As if she were a completely different woman, the kind who sucked cocks blindfolded and not the kind who ironed hand towels so they would hang straight.

The raging, fucking bitch of a sexy whore.

The blood in Toby's body raged so much that he had a moment of dizziness, and then he felt much the same way he had felt seconds after snorting his first and only line of coke during his freshman year of college.

Ron was now looking at Toby, wanting him to guide the next bit. Toby, as though he were operating a robot from another room instead of his own flesh, moved his body toward the bed. He pointed Ron to his right, scarcely believing that he was directing a naked man to get on the bed next to him, with his blindfolded wife poised to suck on their cocks.

But there he was.

This was actually happening.

Standing right in front of Heather, Toby heard himself say: “No talking.”

As if this were a game they played all the time.

Heather bit into her lower lip. The tug of her teeth on her puffy flesh was so sensual, so dirty, so *final*, that Toby’s cock squeezed from the inside out. He dropped his hand to steady it.

Ron’s face was pure carnal concentration as he put his knee up to the bed and climbed onto it, his cock erect between his legs as he rested back on his heels. Toby did the same, his whole body on fire. In his mind, he felt the sensation that he was shaking, but he moved smoothly, as if he did this all the time.

They paused for a moment. In the tomb of silence within the room, their breathing was loud, but it mingled unintelligibly like the sounds of animals among them.

“Hold my arms,” Heather said, her voice silky but firm. There was no doubt in Heather’s voice: she had a plan, and she intended to implement it.

Toby felt his grip on the reins of control slipping. But instead of frightening him, as he would have expected, the slippage aroused him even more.

Heather leaned forward, and Ron rose onto his knees, leaning toward her to capture the necktie binding her wrists. He lifted her arms by the tie, and suspended them above her yet again. Toby reached for the tie beneath Ron’s hand, and they held her together, the weight of her upper body dangling from the tie, her skin turning white where the tie bound her.

Ron released his grip on the tie, looking to Toby to indicate it was his turn. Heather swung toward Toby’s lap, her mouth open, seeking his cock. He used his free hand to push himself toward her mouth, grazing her cheek with the wet crown. Her open mouth found the tip of his cock and licked it, scooping up a pearl of precum and then meandering along the ridge of his crown.

He watched as she strained to reach more of his cock, exploring his skin as though she had never tasted it before.

Surely Heather would know the shape of his dick, the taste of his cum? He shifted her toward him, feeding his dick to her hungry mouth, and

watched himself disappear into her hot wet orifice, her tongue winding in circles around him until he filled her so completely that she could only open and take it in.

Ron's hand was suddenly on the back of her head. The image was disorienting for a moment, and then made Toby's blood surge and threaten to send him over the edge, so much so that he had to briefly close his eyes.

Ron pushed Heather further down Toby's shaft. Toby felt the squeeze of Heather gagging on his cock and had to shut his eyes again to stop himself from erupting in her mouth. Ron gave a shove – gentle, but firm, and Toby's cock slid past the back of her throat. Heather's lips made contact with his pubic bone and his balls. He was deep in her throat and another man had just pushed her head down to get there.

Toby put his free hand on the left side of her head and pulled on her hair, causing Ron to mimic his movements. Staring, he watched as he and Ron together pushed Heather's face down, then pulled her up. He expelled air, fought against a telling groan, and pulsed in her liquid heat, her teeth scraping slightly along his shaft. The sound of her mouth on his cock grew stickier, wetter, louder. His fingers clawed at her hair and he pulled her away forcefully, an orgasm threatening to blow his load deep in her throat.

Not yet, he thought painfully.

Ron grasped the tie and pulled Heather toward himself. Toby released her hands and pushed her head in concert with Ron, just as they had done when she sucked Toby's cock. Toby stared at Heather's lips and chin, dripping with spit. Her tongue emerged from her mouth to seek out Ron's cock – it was fuller, thicker and longer, but not by much, in Toby's estimation.

Heather made a sound as her hungry tongue explored this new cock. Toby saw flashes of the underside of her tongue, her lips as they thinned to accommodate the whole of Ron's organ, the shake of her abdomen as she gagged, and then, with a little pressure from both Ron and Toby, she slid all the way to the base of his cock.

Heather pushed back against them, and they released her head. From there, it was her show. She bobbed up and down Ron's cock under her own steam as he held her arms above her.

Then she abandoned him, and switched to Toby again, sucking him from tip to base twice. And then she switched again, finding Ron's dick

with his help, letting him feed it to her but moving her head up and down of her own free will.

Toby was close to coming, his balls boiling with cum, but Heather moved from cock to cock for what seemed an eternity. She worked him up and then left him, strands of saliva stretching thin between their dicks before falling in a neat line on the bed.

With her tongue against Toby's shaft, she murmured, and the vibration of her voice stroked him almost as if she was sucking him off: "Don't come yet, I want somebody to fuck me."

Toby bent forward, trying to fold his orgasm up inside of himself, he supposed – but it was too late. He stared at the pulsing vein on his shaft, started to reach toward Heather to give her a heads-up, but before he could do anything, his milky cum was spurting from his shaft.

It splattered Heather on the blindfold she was wearing and partly in her hair. Normally one to lean back and out of the way on the very rare occasions when she sucked Toby's cock to the end, Heather made the surprising move of grasping him and turning her mouth toward his erupting cum.

Toby stared at his cock disappearing into her mouth, spurts of cum splashing onto her lips. His final squirts landed at the back of her throat, and she continued to move her tongue playfully around his shaft, cleaning every last drop of fluid from him before releasing his trembling dick with a wet pop.

She smiled.

Toby was incapable of making no sound when he came, and he could feel the features of his face scrunched together. He had dropped the necktie and Heather's hands had dropped behind her back again. She sat up on her heels, breathless, a smile on her face. Cum snaked down her skin, from her throat to her heaving tits, and she moved her tongue around her mouth to slurp up the splatters that had landed close to her lips.

Ron stared at her for a moment, and then, just as Heather opened her mouth to say something, he reached for her head, and pushed her down to his cock.

As Toby watched Ron pumping Heather's face up and down on his shaft, his cock began to stiffen again. By the time Ron arched his back and sucked in his breath, looking down at Heather to tell her to swallow it all,

Toby's dick was hard again. Ron grasped Heather's head and pushed her onto him, thrusting his cock into her deep as he came.

Heather drank it all. When she sat up, other than a tiny dribble of translucent white in the corner of her mouth, Ron's seed was all down her throat.

Ron stepped off of the bed, panting, and fell onto the second bed, behind him. Heather smiled. "That's not it, is it?" she asked. Toby shuddered as something stuck in the back of her throat – probably a bubble of white cum that had thinned and then popped, draining down the back of her mouth, bitter and slimy.

He reached out a hand and brushed his thumb roughly over her lower lip, scooping up the drop of spilled cum and feeding it to her. He reached behind her and tugged on the necktie to loosen it until she could wriggle her hands free.

"Did I get it right?" she asked, as he did. "The first cock was Toby's?"

Toby grunted.

Heather's hands were free, and she leaned forward on her wrists, thrusting her ass backward. "I could tell by the size. I wonder if that would work with *everything*."

Toby stole a glance at Ron, who was staring at Heather's tits and stroking his cock back to life.

Toby looked back at Heather.

He had often wanted to fuck his wife like this. Like a whore. Bent over, hair pulled, pushing her head to the base of his cock.

But he never did.

Now, though, Heather seemed like both a different woman, and the same one he wanted to fuck, and so Toby gave license to his mind to actually imagine some of the more sordid scenarios he had pictured with Heather in them.

He shuffled backward to get off the bed, standing up, cock in hand. Moving quietly, he went around the bed to stand behind Heather. He was not exactly himself as he reached for the knot at the back of her head, pulling her sharply toward him by the scarf, smashing her body into his chest. He hooked an arm around her and felt the front of her body at his own leisure: her skin was wet and he glided over the firmness of her

stomach, each of her breasts, her hard nipples. He dove between her legs and felt the juices welling up from inside of her, trickling down her thighs.

She wanted it. Whatever this was, there was no denying that Heather liked it, that swallowing two loads of cum had made her wetter than ever.

Toby pushed her onto her hands and knees. His right hand explored her gash, watching her body tremble when he slid over something sensitive, liking the way she was bucking against him. He guided his dick into her pussy, and slammed inside of her deep.

Heather was ready to fuck. When he didn't start to saw away in her gash, she began to move her hips wildly, her pussy squeezing against him. He grabbed her hips and jammed himself into her deep, holding her against his pelvis as she flailed and moaned, trying to rock her body against his.

"Toby," she panted, after trying for a while. "Toby, please."

Toby said nothing, only wound his fingers around her right hip and squeezed hard. His wife was petite enough, and he had the strong fingers of a contractor, that he could hold her largely in place with one hand. With his left hand, he ran his palm over her back, up to her neck, her sweat burning against his skin, slippery and warm, smelling of cum.

Around his cock, the velvety insides of Heather's pussy pressed and undulated, side to side, up and down slightly. He continued to stroke her.

As he wanted, she eventually gave up, calming down, letting him take over. He moved his left hand to her puckered pink eyelet, and drew the juices of her pussy to the eye, swirling over them with a feathery touch as Heather's pussy throbbed around his cock.

Heather mewled, and Toby began to fuck her, enjoying how she howled with pleasure, bucking wildly against him, barely seeming to notice when he plunged his thumb inside of her ass. This had always been a taboo with Heather, but she just kept bucking and letting Toby hammer her until at last she squealed and threw her back.

Her orgasm rolled around his cock, the pulses of her satin walls timed with each shriek she let out. She fell onto her chest, arms at either side of her, and let Toby fuck his cum into her, moaning with sensitivity, too fucked-out to mount a protest even as Toby hammered her sore clit with every thrust.

Toby blew a load into her after a few minutes, and Heather squealed at the final thrust. He stepped back, watching his dick as it slipped from

inside of her, white cum in waves gushing from inside of her.

Heather began to push up onto her hands and knees again, just as Ron took Toby's place. Within moments, Ron had shoved his cock – looking much larger, now that it was filling her pussy – deep into her. Heather gasped, her arms weakening, her chest falling to the floor. “Oh, oh no,” she was squealing. “I can't... it's too much... oooohh...” her voice trailed off as she fell to the bed, letting Ron fuck her relentlessly, her body scooting forward, her pussy lips stretched, her hands clawing at the bed.

“Fuck!” Ron exclaimed, looking at the ceiling and ramming deep into her. Toby had not moved, so he was close enough to touch Heather's thigh with his own just as Ron dumped a full load of cum into her overflowing cunt.

Ron rammed her a few more times, grunting as the final spurts of jizz exploded deep inside of her. Heather was making renewed noises of enthusiasm, her teeth biting into the sheets.

“Oh God,” Heather moaned. “Please don't stop. Don't stop, I need to come.”

Ron's cock flopped out of her, and he pulled her shoulder to flip her over on her back. “Spread your legs open, make yourself come,” Ron told her. “Give us a show. Get me hard again, baby.”

Heather's legs flopped open, and she didn't hesitate to slip her fingers into her wet, messy cunt, and start to stroke her clit with very practiced, fast fingers. Cum was gushing from her pussy, and it was so wet that the sloshing noises of her fingers echoed in the room. Heather's fingers moved faster and faster, until she lifted her head, almost as though she could see herself through the blindfold, and her whole body went stiff before she let out a long, strangled cry.

Her hand fell away from her pussy, and her legs fell open.

Toby was ready to go again. He nudged Ron aside, scarcely believing that his cock was hard again. He pushed Heather's legs up to beside her ears. She was still in her red heels, and the image was incredibly sexy as he thrust inside of her and the long heels bounced next to his face as he fucked her again.

Heather complained, tossing her head side to side and saying she was too sore, it was too much, but before long she was into it again, sucking

in her breath, pushing her pelvis toward him to grind herself against him more readily.

Now that he had come several times, even though he felt closer to an orgasm than he had probably ever felt in his life, including the moments preceding every other climax of his life, he knew it would be a while before he could come again.

Again.

How often had that happened?

Ron had come around to the other side of the bed, and was seated on the bed opposite, his cock twitching to life again, his hand languidly assisting.

Toby was never sure how the shuffle occurred, but it happened wordlessly. Ron must have put his hand out, his dark skin on Heather's pale throat, somehow pushing her or guiding Toby to push her to the edge of the bed, until her head could fall over the side and Ron could push her calves until they folded down, toward Toby's hips. The cool plastic of her heels scraped against his waist.

Ron's cock was suddenly where Heather's face had been. Ron pushed the blindfold from her eyes, letting it fall from the top of her head. She was practically upside-down, her throat upturned to Toby.

And then, as Toby stared, his cock deep in his wife's thrice-used pussy full of cum, Ron's dick brushed against her lips.

She opened her mouth. The muscles of her neck rolled beneath her skin, tendons flexing to make her mouth big enough for the next part: Ron's dark, meaty cock sliding slowly into her mouth.

Toby shifted himself to get up in a more or less horizontal position, lifting Heather's ass with two hands to keep her pussy on his dick as he got onto his knees and then his heels. Sure, he wanted to watch as Ron fucked her mouth, but not that close to him.

Heather lifted her arms and put them around Ron's hips, clutching his ass. Meanwhile, Ron fucked Heather's face, the bump of his cock clearly visible in the white of Heather's throat as it traveled up and down inside of her. The sight was so obscene that Toby almost forgot he was part of the action and stopped pumping her, staring at Ron's cock as he pulled it from her mouth to let her breathe. Rather: splutter, drool, and run her tongue over her lips might have been a more appropriate description.

But after watching this for a few deranged and filthy repetitions, Toby felt himself boiling up again. He stared at Ron's dick pumping Heather's willing mouth, deep in her throat like a lump, Heather's heels digging at his side as he came, hard, shoving himself as deep into her pussy as he could.

The staggering filth of what Ron was doing to Heather only hit him then, as he slipped from inside of her pussy and she dropped her arms to grasp her knees and hold her legs open for him to stare at her swollen, pulsing pussy, a river of cum draining down between her legs to her pink eyelet, which he stared at, wondering...?

That would be too far. Surely.

But the spluttering of Heather's mouth as Ron fucked her right in the face made him think otherwise. Heather would never have done any of this. Before. Now she seemed not only to want to do it, but as if she had a natural calling to do it.

Toby edged himself around the bed, exhausted. Ron did not seem to be, he continued to ram himself deep in Heather's mouth and then withdraw, letting her breathe, rubbing his dick over her lips and lifting it to let it slap against her mouth with a wet spurt.

Toby sat on the bed to get a better view, and Ron gave Heather a playful slap on the cheeks. Two wet splats against her skin. "Open your eyes, honey. Let your hubby see what a whore you are."

Ron was sawing at her mouth when she obeyed this command, opening her eyes and looking at Toby dead in the eye as Ron's dick moved in and out of her mouth.

Her face was getting red, and Toby was starting to worry that she couldn't breathe, that Ron needed to lay off, when Ron seemed to get the message telepathically and pulled his cock from her mouth. Heather gasped and spluttered, and Toby stared at her saliva-streaked face, her reddened lips, the unholy mess of it all, not noticing until he plunged into her again that Ron had made his way to finish himself off in Heather's pussy again.

"Ohhhh," Heather moaned in disappointment. She lifted her head to look at Ron. "Don't stop," she whispered, reaching for Ron's body and putting her feet down to push herself up at him and grind against him. "Don't stop, I'm so close."

Ron let out a sharp exhale, grabbing Heather's hips to stop her from grinding on his dick. Toby recognized the intense shudder that ran through his body: it was too much for him right after he came. He gritted his teeth and pushed into her, shuddered again, and then let himself fall from inside of her. Her pussy slurped as his cock fell out. "Fuck," he muttered. "You are one wild whore."

Ron scooted off the bed, staggering against the curtained window a few feet from the bed, and held himself against it, panting. Heather folded her legs under herself and rose up on her knees, crawling toward him.

Ron gave Toby a look. "She's not done yet," he remarked, impressed and also defeated, moving away from Heather's hungry advances. Heather's naked backside gleamed with sweat and she turned to look at Toby. Her fingers were moving down the front of her body, he could hear them in the wet slosh of her pussy.

She met Toby's eyes, her face hungry, almost possessed. It was the same look Ron had had, the same expression Toby imagined that he wore when he was nearing his climax: it was the only thing on her mind. Strands of hair stuck to her face, saliva and cum and sweat holding them to her damp skin.

A demented giggle left her mouth as she turned to face Toby, walking on her knees toward him. He was transfixed by her as she climbed off the mattress and crossed the short distance between the beds to Toby. She stood in front of him, and his hands floated up to her skin, his face inches from her belly and the feathery blond of her mound, matted with sweat and cum. She smelled like sex; it was oozing from her pores. Her pussy was tangy and sweet, overpowering the scent of bleachy cum that trickled down her thighs.

"Heather," Toby murmured, as she pressed her body close to him. His lips were against her hot abdomen, the taste of her sweat and other, sexual, foreign tastes in his mouth suddenly. He wasn't sure if she would push him back and sit on his face, which he didn't really want to do, but felt unable to stop if it happened.

Instead, she climbed onto his lap, pushing him so that he edged backward on the bed. Her legs were spread over him, her thigh muscles hardened with effort as she found his cock with her hand and guided it between her drenched pussy lips.

Toby's cock was coming reluctantly back to life again, pulsing with fresh surges of blood as she gripped him. He felt her clit against the tip of his dick as she used his crown to masturbate herself, the juices of her pussy, Ron's cum, his own cum, pouring from her cheating pussy and over his cock. The hot liquid drained down to his balls, between his legs.

Heather held his gaze fiercely, her blue eyes distant, looking through him more than at him, while she rubbed herself with his cock until her whole body grew stiff and the nails of her left hand dug into the flesh of his shoulder. "Oh God," she gasped, "oh fuck, I'm going to come..."

Her voice was squeezed to a strangled, unintelligible gasp as a violent shudder overtook her, and her back arched, pushing her pussy forward and roughly onto Toby's cock. Her pussy was already throbbing, pulsing, gushing out her own cum, as he slipped inside of her.

If he had been even remotely soft before she did this, the sensation of pushing into her pussy while she came overrode any biological restrictions on his libido. He was suddenly very hard inside of her, staring at her tits as she threw her head back and bounced lasciviously on his cock.

Her thighs began to tremble, her weight fell onto him, and he tried again to get going inside of her, but Heather's eyes flew open and she pushed against him. "Oh God," she said, half-exhausted, with a shudder. "I can't, I'm too sore..."

She shifted off of his cock and collapsed on the bed next to him. Toby's gut felt wrenched, she looked as if she might have to lie there, exhausted, and again he was hungry to fuck her, as astounding as that seemed.

He started to turn toward her, forgetting that Ron was even in the room – Ron had moved to a small couch at the foot of the bed and collapsed there, watching.

Heather surprised him though, by sliding to the floor, almost as if she were collapsing. Confused, Toby stared as Heather knelt in front of him and took his cock into her mouth. Her eyes were on his, her mascara streaked, the picture of utter slutdom. She stared up at him as she sucked him off, her tongue working inside her mouth, making sensual circles around his shaft.

He put his hand on her head and pushed her into a rhythmic sucking of his dick. When she got into it, still looking at him, he leaned back on his

elbows. He could feel the pained expression of his face: part too much sensitivity on his overused cock, part the splendid and glorious pain of seeing his wife so debased, and part the gnawing strain of trying to come again – needing to come again – for the third time in less than an hour.

Heather let his cock fall from her mouth, and something about the way she rubbed his dick over her lips told him her jaw was sore. She started to give him a hand job, grinning with her mouth just inches from his dick. Every now and then she would tease the tip of his cock with a wet lick from her tongue.

Toby braced himself as his climax began to seize his entire body. He felt a little faint for a moment, and wasn't sure if he would survive this next event, but Heather's grip on his dick was firm, her eyes burning into his, and he was going, whether he wanted to or not.

He yelled as he came, almost needing to shut his eyes from the violence of the climax. When he opened them, his cum was spurting out onto Heather's tits in thick ropes, more clear than white, the last of his load. His abdomen spasmed as the last spurts erupted, covering Heather's chest in two more glistening streaks of cum.

"Fuck," he said, wrenching her still-moving hand from his dick, leaning toward her, reaching for her sticky chest. "Fuck, Heather, that was so hot."

He fingered the slimy cum on her chest, spreading it into her skin, drawing it up to her mouth and feeding it to her off his fingertips. Heather sucked his fluids from his fingers with wet, sloppy sounds that Toby felt sure would have Ron rising to the occasion again. He couldn't go again himself, he was thinking, and wondering how to pry his slutty wife from this room, or whether to pry his wife away, if she still wanted more.

He didn't hear the door click, or the bang as the drunken party entering threw it open. Their voices came to him through the miasma of his thoughts, reaching him much more slowly than the drunken couple from the previous party.

"Oh my God!" a girl's voice said, ripping him from his stupor. Heather looked over at them at the same time that Toby did. The guy was staring at Heather, and the girl was staring at Ron.

A panging sense of trouble and guilt started rushing in to fill the void left by Toby's orgasm.

But Heather, standing up and pushing her hair from her face in one graceful moment, teetering only slightly on her heels, saved the moment with grace. “Sorry,” she said, her voice hardly indicating that she was. It was the apology of politeness, the kind of thing you said when you bumped into someone else’s cart in the grocery store.

The couple were rendered silent, the girl crossing her arms and glaring at Ron, who waved his hands limply as if the whole thing had happened without him having any control over it whatsoever.

She turned furiously to her male companion, who was still staring at Heather, who had turned to fish her dress from the tangle of sheets on the bed. “What about Cassie?!” she whispered harshly.

The guy made a noise, absolving himself of any knowledge or blame for whatever was happening with the all-purpose male grunt.

Heather looked at Toby as she slipped her dress over her head, raising her eyebrows. “Better find your pants,” she told him.

The girl whacked her male companion and stormed out of the hotel room. Toby jumped to life at the same time as Ron, and Heather grinned as she scooped a pair of pants from the floor and tossed them in Ron’s direction. Toby found his pants but was having trouble getting them on. His legs were weak, his hands shaking, and the drunkenness that had so warmly enveloped him just moments before was now flooding back into his system as some kind of de-coordination elixir.

Heather pushed him gently on his lower back. “I can’t find my shirt,” he said in a low voice.

“Just go,” Heather said, as if she were removing him from a house party where he had gotten too drunk. Her fingers pressed against the small of his back.

They left awkwardly, Heather dashing back to grab her purse. The door closed on Ron and the male companion starting to argue mildly.

Heather looked both ways down the hallway, and then grabbed Toby to pull him toward the stairs. “Let’s get out of here,” she whispered fiercely, but when she looked back at Toby he was relieved to see that she had a wicked grin on her face. “Before that crazy chick comes back.”

She kicked off her heels, which Toby found amusing after all that had just happened. She grabbed them, and pulled Toby’s arm. He

remembered that he had no shirt on, and felt for his phone in a panic, but found it in his pocket.

They ran, laughing, toward the stairs. Outside, the first very weak rays of light were emerging in the sky.

EPILOGUE

Something that had always bothered Toby about the sexual fantasies he had about his wife was the ending: what happened, after the fantasy was fulfilled? Was it like what happened after porn, when a tremendous sense of guilt and humiliation overtook you in the stark blue light of a computer screen, your cum cooling on a wad of tissues and something you didn't mean for it to land on, the very filthy video you just watched repulsively continuing, the contents of it temporarily stripped of their ability to arouse you? Or did something else happen, as he thought it surely must, if there were so many couples out there who explored this lifestyle? And if something else did happen, what was it?

Perhaps if these reservations could have drowned out his libido, he might have stopped his wife and never experienced what happened in Jersey. Perhaps if his wife had not been the one to lead the charge, they never would have done the things they did.

And that was where the mystery still remained: inside Heather's head.

They went back to their own hotel room. Down two floors, their giggling and their footsteps echoing in the terrible acoustics of the stairwell. They entered quickly, Heather looking furtively down the hall, perhaps checking to make sure that the disdainful woman from two floors above would not appear in their hallway.

The door closed behind them, and they stood in the utter darkness, breathing heavily, their laughter dying down to something more serious. The moment seemed to last a long time, at least to Toby's memory. Then Heather moved in the darkness, and tripped on the discarded shoebox. Toby fumbled for the light, and then it was suddenly on, and they were standing in their hotel room, looking very worn, Toby without a shirt and Heather without panties. She was holding a shoebox in her hand, a familiar look of irritation creeping into her features.

Married people, they argue about these sorts of banalities all the time. Who left the dishes in the dishwasher, who didn't properly crush the cans in the recycling bin, why this pair of socks or that screwdriver was left on the table instead of put away. The furor of these domestic disputes had

always seemed to Toby like an acid, pouring into the more serious cracks of their marriage and making them bigger, deeper, more jagged.

But seeing the look on Heather's face at that particular moment felt comforting. She never got going about the shoebox, not like she would have ordinarily: *why can't you put anything away? How hard is it to set this over here?* Toby stepped toward her, made a joke, he forgets now what he said exactly, but it made Heather laugh.

They stripped out of their clothes and took a shower. It ended up being a shower together, and then they moved to the bed, where their make-out session turned ferociously passionate. The sex they had was conservative by the standards of that previous evening/morning. The excitement came, on Toby's part, from pushing past the squeaky, just-cleansed folds of Heather's outer lips, into the wet and velvety center of her, where another man's cum still made her body slick. In the reddened soreness of her nipples, and the way she squirmed when he sucked on them, part discomfort, part pleasure.

They made love, Toby reclaiming the body of his wife that had been used by other men. He has very clear recollections of meeting Heather's eyes, of feeling like she had come back to him in full. She was incredibly into it: it was one of the best and longest lovemaking sessions they had ever had. They fell asleep mid-morning, and housekeeping came to kick them out at 1pm, after they had exceeded the checkout time by an hour and not woken to any of the knocks on the door.

"I bet every man asks that question," Heather said, after thinking long and hard about Toby's question, the one he really wanted answered. How had he phrased it? *Will we ever do this again?* Or was it: *Is this 'us' now?*

Toby had stared at her, not really knowing what her answer meant.

"I just mean," she said, unprompted, "that guys are always like... that was great, so when are we doing it again. With sex, I mean. And then women are more..." she stared over Toby's head, thinking.

Toby bit his tongue, but not long enough. "Are you saying you don't... are you saying you're upset by what we did?"

Heather's eyes drifted from the point above his head, wherever they had been floating and whatever they had seen unknown to him. She smiled. It was the same sort of smile she had tossed back at him, as they'd walked

to the shuttle bus. Unknowable, uncategorizable. She brought her wine to her lips and took a sip. It was the same wine she had pushed away, saying just moments before she never needed to drink again in her life.

Inside his own head, Toby's mind screamed with unanswered questions: *what did she think? What was she thinking of now? Had she done something she didn't like? Or had she liked it, better than him? Would she do it again? Would their marriage be the same?*

And finally, a juggernaut of a question, which spilled from his mouth:

"Why did you do it?"

This was a friendly conversation. They were both smiling, having made some kind of binding arrangement between them that had never been spoken aloud but which Toby could feel. But the question burned inside of him.

Heather smiled again. Another sip of wine.

"Why did *you* do it?" she asked.

How long passed between them, Heather giving him a kind of know-it-all look that ordinarily would have irritated him, swirling her wine, grinning. She did this kind of thing when she was trapping him at the ass-end of an argument, when she knew she was going to win. Maybe, in fact, he started to have the reaction he always had when things went that direction, but Heather set off in a new direction before he could build up any steam.

He had no answer. He could feel the answer, but he would never have been able to articulate it.

She reached across the table, took his hand. Her fingers slipped into his, weaving themselves in and out. She was looking at them when she said:

"People can have different reasons for wanting the same thing. They can even... not be sure what they are."

"Sure, but -"

"I don't *know* why I did it," Heather said softly. She smiled. "I don't think you know, either. But..." she sighed. "I don't really *know* why I'm married to you, you know what I mean? It's not something knowable. It's just... a feeling."

Toby blinked. Heather squeezed his hand. "Does it really matter why it's your fantasy?" she asked. "Or why it's mine? Does it really matter if

those are two different things?”

It was a good question. Toby said so, as he lifted his beer to his lips. Did it matter if two people did something together for different reasons?

Wasn't marriage like that? Having children? Pretty much any aspect of sex? Wasn't there just basically an endless field of things two people consigned themselves to doing together by being married, and why on earth would their reasons be exactly the same?

“I say,” Heather said, lifting the drink menu and reading it studiously for a moment before finishing her thoughts. “What happens in Jersey, stays in Jersey.”

She scanned the drinks menu. “I need like, a Caesar or something,” she murmured.

She looked up at him, and searched his eyes. Toby had a moment of extreme lucidity, in which he realized that Heather might be searching for the same certainty, the same reassurance, the same absolute knowledge of her husband that he sought in his wife. But neither one of them could ever know everything.

He didn't even really know himself enough to give it to her, as much as he wanted to.

“Want to split this giant fishbowl Caesar with me?” she flipped the menu around to show him a picture of what must have been a Caesar in a huge glass that looked like a fishbowl. He nodded. The powers of speech had left him.

“Stays in Jersey,” Heather repeated, lifting her arm and her pretty face to get the attention of their waiter.

Then casually, almost as if she were talking to someone else: “But that doesn't mean, it can never happen again, anywhere else.”

It took a while for Toby to realize that something in her final words about the matter was at the heart of what he would have said, if there had been any conceivable way to put into words his answer to her question.

“Why did *you* do it?”

Lots of reasons. Mostly feelings. One of them being something to do with the hope embedded in the unknowable.

The unknowable, like what Heather's answer to that question might be.

END

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Scarlett and Will are not finished with the adventure they began in *Working On Her Game*. Will gives his blessing to Scarlett to return to her physical relationship with her tennis instructor. At first, their sex life is re-invigorated and the affair seems to bring them closer together. But the

young, Italian bull is always pushing the limits of Will's jealousy, Scarlett's comfort zone, and the strength of their marriage. Will things go too far?

Mixed Doubles

Will thought that Scarlett's affair with her tennis instructor ended months ago, but her strange behavior makes him suspect otherwise. As evidence of Scarlett's cheating mounts, Will discovers that he enjoys the thrill of Scarlett's now very illicit affair: the casual lies, the deleted texts, the sneaking around. But there is much more to Scarlett's renewed affair with Alessandro than meets Will's eyes, and she may be in way over her head. Is there any way to untangle the delicious mess Scarlett has made, while salvaging the trust in their marriage?

Romantic Hotwife Books By Arnica:

A Taste For Teasing

Oren knows he's a lucky man with a hot wife: Monica is blond, stunning, and has a killer body. She was even a cheerleader in the NBA in her university days – and there are even more interesting jobs in her resume than that. But Monica is also a practical, down-to-earth, and happily married woman.

Things take a turn one year when they're vacationing with friends. Oren discovers that he has a taste for thinking about his wife with another man. And Monica has a taste for... well, something. Monica is becoming a hotwife before his eyes: but Oren can't be sure of *who* she's teasing. Is his fantasy coming true, or is it turning sour? Was there more to Monica's past than she ever let on? Is a hotwife really what he wants?

Ela's Performance

Peter's sweet-faced and fiery wife is headed back to school for a degree in violin performance. Unexpectedly, Peter finds himself becoming very paranoid about who Ela is spending so much time with, and what she is doing at school so very late. It isn't as if he doesn't have his reasons for suspicion. There's the way his own relationship with Ela started, and their own past experiment with an open relationship before they were married. A few other strange things to fuel his jealous fantasies...

And when he discovers someone from Ela's past has resurfaced, he'll take a chance and confront his own desires and obsessions...but will he get what he really wants?

The Houseguest

Sharing and temptation...and sharing temptation. An old buddy returns to Erik's hometown, down on his luck and getting a divorce. By offering to let Ethan stay with them, Erik sees a way to get closer to making his wife-sharing fantasies a reality. To his delight, Natalie seems to be game for something far more adventurous than ever before. But as things heat up, Erik can't help but wonder: Who's seducing whom?

A Conventional Hotwife

Paul Banks was thrilled when a luggage mix-up five years ago opened a window of opportunity for his long-buried desires. Since that time, he and his wife have been playing a little game at their yearly company conventions, and every year his wife ups the ante, going further into his fantasies. But Kathy Banks might be getting just a bit out of control, and things might be going a little too far...

Or not.

The Hotwife Summer

When Ben and Summer have the chance to spend the summer in Italy, their stale marriage starts to heat up in ways Ben could only have dreamed about. Summer is ready to take his hotwife fantasy all the way, and her choice is a

sexy, Italian, Michelin star-studded chef. It's too late to put the brakes on what he's set in motion when Ben discovers the humiliating truth about Summer's choice of man. Summer has a taste for being naughty, and a filthy little plan of her own. Will it be everything he could wish for, or will Ben's cuckold fantasy turn into a nightmare he can't escape?

Body of Research

When ever-suspicious Chris plays private detective on his wife's phone and finds that she uses dozens of dating apps, he worries that his darkest fantasies have come true. And it may not be as delicious as he had imagined.

It turns out that Jen is up to something other than cheating, and the door is open for the two of them to explore the boundaries of their marriage. But in any experiment, the results can be unexpected...

The Hobby Job

Former career professional Laura is going crazy living her stay-at-home-mom life in a small country town. Her husband Conrad has the perfect solution: get a “hobby job.” Laura gets turned on to the idea, and to Conrad's surprise, chooses to wait tables at a run-down restaurant down the street. But she gets a lot more than a hobby job when she meets Nate, a young, hot waiter who has his eyes on her from the start.

Conrad and Laura start on separate journeys, exploring new possibilities in their marriage, and opening up to their hidden desires, fantasies, and needs. Will their journeys merge, or will Laura's “hobby job” make a hobby of their marriage?

The Hotwife Tatto

When Greg's brother marries his wild, tattooed, ex-girlfriend Renee, he knows things will be a little complicated. But when Renee befriends his wife Sara, she starts to change in almost unbelievable ways. Greg sees that there is something more to Renee's plans than just friendly sister-in-law bonding. Is Renee's influence all bad, or can Greg get something he has always wanted and never admitted to his wife – maybe even himself?

Interracial hotwife books by Arnica:

Laura's Dark Side

Laura and Chris have an ordinary marriage. Like most ordinary marriages, it's missing something.

They have ordinary friends, too. Or, at least they thought they did.

When Laura and Chris see firsthand that Jenna and Rob have their own solution to the marriage blahs, they have wildly different reactions – at least outwardly. But behind Laura's shock and disappointment in her friends, she's hiding a very dark secret... one she doesn't want to admit, even to herself.

Luckily for her, Jenna has a stable of dark men who know just how to unlock the needs of a woman like Laura.

Is Chris ready for the ride?